

FIGURE IT OUT

Twelve Rules for Building Something From Nothing

York W. Sims Jr.

Copyright © 2026 York W. Sims Jr. All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced in any form without written permission from the author, except for brief quotations in reviews.

This book describes real events from the author's life. A small number of names have been changed to protect people's privacy.

For my daddy, who handed me the crate.

And for Zuri, who gets the ball.

“Here. Figure it out.”

York W. Sims Sr.

Contents

Introduction: The Kitchen Table

Crate 0: The Nail

PART I: THE FOUNDATION

1. Figure It Out

2. Know What You Inherited

3. Bet on the Insult

Crate 1: The Break

PART II: THE FALL

4. Pay the Bill Once

5. Get Up Faster

6. Count Your Friends Twice

Crate 2: The Dirt

PART III: THE BUILD

7. Build It Before They Believe You

8. Treat Every Loss Like Tuition

9. Always Have Your Own Ticket

Crate 3: The Empty Wall

PART IV: THE HANDOFF

10. Keep the Crate, Change the Game

11. Be There, Not Just in the House

12. Leave Them the Ocean

Conclusion: Run It All

Crate 4: The Ocean

Introduction: The Kitchen Table

It's late in Folsom, California, and the house is finally quiet. My daughter is asleep down the hall, a few steps from the little indoor hoop she already shoots on with a real follow-through. My wife is asleep too. I'm at the kitchen table, because I'm always at the kitchen table when the day runs out of noise, and tonight I'm thinking about you.

Pull up a chair.

I mean that. Everything worth knowing that ever got handed to me got handed across a table. Money got counted on tables in my family. Dominoes got slammed on tables. Hard news landed on tables, and so did every plate of Sunday food my daddy ever fixed. When he had something real to tell you, he told you up close, where you could see his face and he could see yours. A table is honest furniture. Nobody can perform at a table. You're close enough to get your wrist grabbed.

So here's the arrangement between you and me for the rest of this book. This is not a stage, and I'm not a keynote speaker. Nobody is dimming the lights or warming up slides. You're at my table, and I'm going to talk to you the way

somebody should have talked to you a long time ago. Plain and straight, with receipts.

Receipts first, matter of fact. You don't know me yet, and you should never hand your one life to a stranger just because he wrote a book.

* * *

I was born in Clarksville, Arkansas, a town of about 5,000 people, to a mother who once walked three kids five miles in the dark to get us somewhere safe, and a father who came out of Memphis with a hustler's record and a mathematician's brain. By my junior year of high school I was the number one ranked basketball player in the state of Arkansas and the number 22 shooting guard in the country. Oklahoma State knew my name. UConn knew my name. Stanford knew my name. In a town that small, that's about as close as a teenager gets to walking on water.

By graduation I had three felonies and a statewide ban that kept me off every court in Arkansas for my entire senior season. Let that sit with you for a second. Let it marinate. I was the number one basketball player in Arkansas, and I couldn't play basketball in Arkansas. The recruiting letters stopped the same day the handcuffs went on, and they never started again. And a felony doesn't leave when the sentence ends. Mine built a wall between me and voting, between me and financial aid, between me and whole categories of work, and I've spent two decades finding places to climb over it.

At 17 I stood on a Tyson chicken line next to my classmates' parents, on four hours of sleep a night. I clawed back into the game through a junior college where I started out as the eleventh man in a rotation that played eight, and one February night in 2007 I beat the number one ranked team in the country with a floater at the buzzer. That night gets its own chapter, so I'll leave it alone for now. What came after it was slower and meaner. Two knee surgeries. A dream that dimmed instead of ended. I chased the game all the way to a tryout in Turkey and came home without a contract. And one punch outside a California bar turned into a felony assault charge and 49 days in a county jail, where I read the Bible cover to cover because I'd never finished a book in my life and needed to prove to myself that I could.

The next thing I built was green. Cannabis calmed stomach ulcers that felt like a blowtorch on my insides when nothing from the pharmacy could, and then the plant became my next obsession. I taught myself to farm off YouTube tutorials on raw land with no water and no power (and I'll be straight with you later about which parts of those years were legal and which weren't), and eventually I started a licensed cannabis company in Oklahoma. I bought 8.5 acres sight unseen. I raised \$1.2 million across three years and a pandemic, in dozens of yeses and hundreds of nos, without a single institutional check. And I paid tuition the whole way. \$25,000 gone on a concert the promoters never promoted. \$30,000 handed over in cash for a nursing home that never existed. \$37,000 of an investor's money wired into a smooth talker's

account before I could stop it. Every one of those stories is in this book with the price tag still attached.

At 37, with a newborn at home and a business on my back, I taught myself to code. I didn't know code editors existed, so I built my first application line by line in a raw terminal, the way people did it in the 1980s. That terminal taught me something that runs underneath every page here: you can teach yourself anything if you're willing to be bad at it first. I wore out three computers in two years. As I write this, I've got 25 public repositories and more than 40 working applications live on the internet under my own name, plus certifications from Google, IBM, Vanderbilt, and CompTIA. I sent applications to Anthropic, OpenAI, NVIDIA, and Micron with all of that sitting in plain view, and got back rejections and silence. I built one company an entire working platform for free and watched the seat go to somebody else. So my wife and I opened a studio of our own, and our first client paid us. A small check with our names on it, which beat every big promise that never cleared.

That's the resume, and here's the disclaimer that goes with it. I'm not a guru. I'm not rich-guy famous. There's no jet story coming, and I'm not writing this from a beach house. I'm a builder in the middle of the build, which is exactly why you can trust me: the man still laying brick remembers what a brick weighs. My life isn't a clean arc you can trace with a finger. It's a series of explosions, connected by moments of grace that I didn't deserve and stubbornness that I probably should have outgrown but never did. I don't have a pedigree.

I have a record and receipts. And anywhere a number could have been prettier or a win shinier, I left it alone, because I'm not going to lie and pick a big round number so it sounds good in a book.

And the wins cost, every one of them, because receipts run both directions. Some of the bill was money. Some of it was cartilage. The heaviest line items were people, and you'll meet them by name where I can name them.

The middle of the build is also the best seat at this table. A man on top of a mountain can only point at the trail behind him, and the weather has changed since he climbed it. A man still on the wall can hand you the rope he's actually using. That's what this book is. Rope in use. Some of these lessons I learned 20 years ago and have tested a hundred times since. A few I'm still standing on as we speak, and where that's the case, I'll tell you straight, because you deserve to know which handholds I set last week.

* * *

Nobody ever handed me the regulation version of anything. Not a regulation hoop. Not a regulation childhood. Not a regulation resume, and not a regulation second chance. For most of my life I thought that was my disadvantage. It took me the better part of four decades to understand it was my education. That's why this book exists.

I've read the shelf this book sits on. Some of those books are good, and I'll tip my hat to a few of them as we go. But a

lot of them were written by men who started on third base and wrote a bestseller about their home run trot. When you grow up where I grew up, you can smell it on the page. The safety net under every “risk.” The family friend who happens to appear right when the story needs a miracle. Regulation everything, and the reader never told. I’m not mad at those authors. I just couldn’t use them. And if you’re who I think you are, you can’t either.

Early in my life I learned there were two Americas, and I learned it in the backseat of a car, watching a friend ask his mother for \$20 for a t-shirt and watching her hand it over without blinking, while I sat there running the math on what \$20 meant at my house. Most of the books on this shelf were written from that mother’s America. This one was written from the backseat.

Somewhere along the way, somebody sold us all the same list of prerequisites. The degree first. The network first. The clean record, the seed money, the mentor, the permission slip. Regulation equipment, then you get to play. I believed that list more than once, and every time I believed it, it cost me a year. Here’s what I kept crashing into instead: the game teaches you the game. The building teaches you the building. Waiting teaches you to wait, and that’s all it ever teaches you.

So let me show you my credentials in one image instead.

When I was four years old, my daddy knocked the bottom out of a milk crate and nailed it to the back of our house, because a real basketball goal cost money we didn’t have. He

said, “Here. Figure it out.” And I shot on that ugly hoop until I could really shoot.

That crate is this whole book, so let me give you the thesis in one sentence and you can decide whether you want the next couple hundred pages of it: nobody is coming with the regulation version of your life, so you take what’s already in your hands, nail it up, and figure it out.

My father lived that sentence long before he ever said it to me. He rolled into Arkansas with next to nothing. What he had was the absolute, unshakeable, borderline delusional belief that he was going to figure it out. That belief is the family gospel. It fed a household for decades without a resume anybody would print, and it’s the one inheritance that came with no ceiling on it.

Half the time somebody says “figure it out,” they’re walking away from you. When my daddy said it, he’d already nailed up the hoop. That’s the difference, and it’s the model for everything that follows: I can’t take your reps for you, but I can build you something to shoot at. This book is the crate. The reps are yours.

Every rule in this book is that one sentence wearing different work clothes.

* * *

Before we go on, you need to meet the man properly, because he’s on damn near every page.

My father was York Sims Sr., Webb, Mississippi, by way of Memphis, Tennessee. I'm going to tell you the truth about him, because this book doesn't work if I clean him up. He was a hustler. He ran streets and he went to prison, and he never held a regular job for long, because somewhere down in the deepest part of his soul he refused to make another man rich. He was also the smartest person I've ever met in my life. He answered Jeopardy questions before the host finished reading them, then went back to his beer like nothing happened.

The man never owned a pair of jeans or a pair of sneakers. Pressed slacks, hard-bottom shoes, a button-down, and a walk that announced him before he said one word. On Sundays he cooked food that fed the whole neighborhood, no measuring cups, no recipes, and in his kitchen everybody got a plate. When his boys wanted to play baseball, he carved us bats out of two-by-fours. That was how he loved you. He built the tool, put it in your hands, and watched what you did with it.

Now the other half, because this table doesn't do worship. The same man drank too much. He fought with my mother in the middle of the night, and some nights my brother and I slept with our shoes on so we could leave the house fast. He went to prison and missed years he never got back. He talked about a restaurant he never opened. And on May 6, 2018, he died without ever once seeing the ocean, after spending his whole life giving us everything he had. Hold onto that ocean. There's a stretch of water at the end of this book, and it belongs to him, and I'll take you there once we've earned it.

He came to exactly two of the games I played in my whole childhood. Both were championships. We won both. Was that man present or was he absent? The honest answer is yes.

Some people get two fathers to learn from, one to copy and one to take warning from. I got both of mine in one man. The code and the ceiling arrived in the same package, and learning to split that inheritance, what to keep and what to break, took me half my life. Chapter 2 is where we do that split properly, line by line. For now I just need you to read him right. Every time my daddy shows up in these pages, he's both dads at once. Take the lesson, then audit the lesson. Both moves are love.

And while we're on it: you have inheritances too. Everybody does. Somebody handed you a code, and somebody handed you a ceiling, and odds are good they came from the same person. Part of the work ahead of you is learning to tell those two apart in your own house, and we'll do that work with paper and a pen, not with blame.

* * *

What he handed me, plus what the 30-some years since have beaten into me, I call the Milk Crate Code. It's 12 rules in four parts, and the order matters. The Foundation is what you start with, which is more than you think you have. The Fall is what breaks you, because something will, and a code that only works in good weather isn't a code, it's a souvenir. The Build is how you make something real out of whatever survived.

The Handoff is what all of it is for, and I'll tell you right now, it's not a car.

There's a shape to the order. The Foundation is a private fight, you against your own starting line, and nobody's watching. The Fall is where life gets a vote. The Build is where other people finally see what you're making, and the Handoff is where you understand why you were making it. I didn't invent that arc. I just lived it out of order enough times to learn it only works in order.

I'm not going to list all 12 rules here, because out of context they'd read like posters, and I didn't write posters. I'll give you a taste instead. One rule tells you to bet on the insult. Another tells you to pay the bill once. Another says always have your own ticket, and the first one, the one that owns the cover of this book, says figure it out with the hoop you have. Each rule comes wrapped inside the story that taught it to me, because stories are how my daddy taught, and it's the only honest way I know.

These rules aren't theory to me. I've run the same play on a milk-crate hoop in Arkansas, on a cannabis farm built from raw dirt, and in a computer terminal at 37 years old. The tools change. The pattern does not. That's what makes it a code instead of a memoir.

I call it a code and not a system on purpose. A system is something you install and forget. A code is what you live by when nobody's watching and nothing's working, and it's the only kind of help I've ever seen survive a burned-down house or a banned season. You'll read about both.

Let me also tell you what this book is not, so nobody feels cheated at the register.

This is not manifesting. I won't be asking you to whisper at your bathroom mirror until a Range Rover appears in the driveway. In my experience the universe does respond, but it doesn't respond to vibes. The universe keeps receipts. It pays out on work, and every claim I make in these pages comes with the work shown, the way a math teacher makes you show your steps.

It's not a shortcut, either. Every rule in here cost me something real. Money, skin, years, relationships. A few cost all four at once. When a chapter tells you what a lesson is worth, it will also tell you exactly what I paid for it, because the price tag is the difference between advice and testimony.

And it's not a promise of outcomes. I can't promise you a Ferrari, and I won't pretend the game is fair, because you and I both know better. What I can promise you is a way of moving. A way of getting up that's faster than whatever knocked you down, and a way of looking at the pile of nothing in front of you and seeing parts.

This isn't hustle worship either. I've done the 16-hour days and you'll read about them, but you'll also read what they cost the people closest to me, because obsession always bills somebody. Work is the engine here, and I'm going to ask a lot of you. But working yourself away from everybody you love isn't a code. It's a prettier way to lose.

One more ground rule: everything in this book happened. The dollar figures are the real dollar figures. A few names are

changed and a few people go unnamed on purpose, and the unnamed ones should understand that anonymity is its own kind of judgment. Where I was wrong, I say so. Where I got lucky, I say that too, because luck loves to dress up as genius, and I refuse to let it wear my clothes.

Now, how to use the thing. Read it in order. The four parts build on each other the way floors build on a foundation, and stories from the early chapters come back later carrying more weight. Each chapter opens with something that happened to me, lands on one principle, works that principle into your life, and closes with two short sections. The first is called Run It. That one's yours: pen and paper, dated, specific, small enough to finish inside a week. The second is called The Crate, a few lines to seal the chapter shut. Between the parts you'll find short interludes about a boy and a milk crate. They're small on purpose. Don't skip them, and by the last one you'll know what they were building the whole time. Don't binge any of it like a television series either. Take a part, run the exercises, let a week do its work on you, then come back for the next one.

About Run It: do the exercises. I'm dead serious about this part. If you skip them, this becomes a story collection. My stories are good. But you didn't buy this book to watch me build.

Write in this book while you're at it. Dog-ear it. Argue with me in the margins. I won't hear you. You will, and you're the one we're building.

Last thing, and then we go.

This book is for somebody specific, and I'd rather lose the sale than lie to you about whether that's you. It's for the person building something out of nothing. The first one in a family to try. The athlete whose game ended before the plan did. The one with a record, or a gap in the resume, or a past that keeps getting read out loud in rooms where you're trying to become somebody new. It's for everybody who's ever been told, in words or in silence, that where you come from settles where you can go.

Some of you are reading this on a break at a job you've sworn is a bridge and not a destination. I had you specifically in mind. I've stood exactly where you're standing, in rubber gloves at 2 in the morning, and this book is what I wish somebody had slid across the table to me that year.

If you came here for permission, I'll save you the read: this is the wrong book. You do not need permission to build something great. Nobody handed me mine. Nobody is coming to hand you yours.

Maybe you came to find out whose fault it all is. That's the wrong book too. I'll say this once, kitchen-table straight: some of what happened to you is genuinely not your fault. Some of what happened to me wasn't either. My felonies are mine to own, and the small town that decided to make an example out of a 17-year-old is real too. Both of those things are true at the

same time, and neither one of them ever moved a single brick for me. This book is about the bricks.

And if none of this is landing, no hard feelings. Hand your copy to somebody with an ugly hoop and a lot of quiet fire. They'll know what to do with it.

But if you're still reading, I believe you're my people. You've got a crate somewhere. Maybe it's an ugly first version of a business, a night-class certificate, a garage full of product nobody's ordered yet, a jump shot nobody's seen. Whatever it is, it's not regulation, everybody can tell, and some quiet part of you has been waiting for the official version to arrive before you really start.

It's not coming. And that's not the bad news. That's the secret.

My daddy handed me a milk crate and four words, and I've spent every year since finding out how much a man can build off that start. This book is me nailing a crate to the wall for you. The ocean is at the end. The table is always here.

Turn the page.

Crate 0: The Nail

It is 1991, in a small town in Arkansas, and a boy wants a basketball hoop.

He has seen one in a store. Orange rim, white net, a pole that stands up straight in a bucket of concrete. In this house, a hoop like that costs the same as a helicopter. The boy does not know that yet. He knows only the wanting. He asks in the morning. He asks at supper. He asks until the asking is a sound the house makes, like the screen door, like the box fan in the window.

The father does not explain the money. He does not say no. He does not say anything at all. He gets up from his chair, goes out the back door, and comes around the side of the house carrying a milk crate.

That crate has spent its whole life carrying milk. It has ridden in cold trucks and sat on loading docks and stacked itself in back rooms, and nobody has ever asked it to be anything else. The father turns it over once in his hands, the way he handles everything, dominoes, a pot on the stove. Then he knocks the bottom out of it.

At the back of the house he sets the crate against a sheet of plywood. He pulls a nail from his pocket, holds it to the plastic, and swings. The hammer speaks. The wall answers. Another nail. Another. The whole job takes less time than the wanting did.

He puts the ball in the boy's hands.

"Here. Figure it out."

Then he goes back inside, because he has other work, and the wall does not need him anymore.

The boy stands in the dirt and looks at what he has been given. It is not orange. There is no net. There is no pole and no concrete. It is a plastic square nailed to scrap wood, and its mouth is barely wider than the ball. A shot at a rim like this has to be true or it is nothing.

He shoots. The ball rattles the plastic and falls back in the dirt. He picks it up. He shoots again. The crate does not care. The wall does not care. The ball comes back every time, and that is the one kindness of a wall.

The sun drops behind the trees. Down the road the streetlights buzz and come on, one by one, and the boy keeps shooting. He learns the sound of a make, the clean fall through the plastic, the soft thud in the dirt below. He learns the sound of a miss, the clatter, the long chase into the dark yard. When his eyes give out, he shoots by sound.

Inside the house the father does not watch from the window. He does not have to. He can hear it coming through the wall, steady as a clock. Plastic. Dirt. Plastic. Dirt.

The nail holds.

PART I: THE FOUNDATION

What you start with

Chapter 1: Figure It Out

My daddy came around the side of the house carrying a milk crate in one hand and a hammer in the other, and nothing about the man said a tender moment was coming.

I was four years old. For weeks I had been begging for a basketball goal with the persistence only a four-year-old owns, because a four-year-old does not yet know that money is a real thing with real edges. All I knew was that basketball existed and I needed to be inside it.

Let me hand you the context I didn't have then. This was Clarksville, Arkansas, a town of about 5,000 people where everybody knew exactly what everybody else didn't have. We were broke. Not sitcom broke, where the family drives one older car and the whole crisis wraps up in 22 minutes. Broke for real, where a store-bought basketball goal, the pole, the backboard, the actual orange rim, was as realistic as buying a helicopter. Some parents would have said "maybe for Christmas" and let the lie do the babysitting. My daddy didn't traffic in that kind of lie.

What he did instead was what he always did. He looked at the problem, assessed what he had available, and engineered

a solution from nothing. A milk crate was available. He knocked the bottom out of it. He nailed it to a piece of plywood on the back of the house, high enough to mean something. Then he stepped back, checked the work the way he checked all work, and gave me the entire ceremony in two sentences.

“There’s your basketball goal. Now quit bothering me.”

No speech about believing in myself. No card, no hug, no slow-motion moment where the music swells. A crate, a wall, and a screen door closing behind him.

Here’s what you need to understand: I did not feel cheated. I felt rich. I ran at that thing like it was Madison Square Garden. And the crate turned out to be a mean teacher from day one. It had no net to slow the ball down and whisper sweet things to you, no backboard glass to forgive a flat shot. The ball went through clean or it came back at your face with an attitude. So I learned to shoot it clean. Every day after school. Every summer morning. Until the dark made the rim a rumor and somebody hollered me inside. And every rim I met for the rest of my life was more generous than the one I learned on.

A crate doesn’t care that you’re four, either. That’s the other thing about mean teachers: they treat you like the real thing from the first rep. There was no adjustable height, no beginner setting, no version of that rim scaled down to a child. It hung where he nailed it, the same height on day one and day one thousand, and every make had to be earned at full difficulty. Kids are supposed to get things softened for

them. Mine never was, and I'm convinced that's half of why the game took root so deep.

Now the part that took me 30 years to fully see. A milk crate is not built to take a basketball for hours a day. About every other week, mine would crack and give out from the abuse. And every time it did, without an announcement, without a lecture about being careful with things, a new crate would be up on that plywood. He was not a man who said "I love you" on a schedule. He said it in nails. He recognized the fire in our eyes, and he fed it, one milk crate at a time. He never said any of that out loud. But he built me the hoop.

Understand, the crate wasn't a one-off. The man engineered everything. The domino table where he held court sat on top of the storm cellar. When we needed baseball bats, he carved them out of two-by-fours. If a thing was needed and the money wasn't there, the thing got built out of whatever was there. Watching that, week after week, installs something in a kid that no store can sell you.

If I stayed inside too long, got underfoot, started whining about being bored, the instruction never changed: "Boy, take your ass outside and shoot on the goal I put up."

And if you had asked him for the philosophy underneath all of it, the entire instruction manual was one sentence long.

"Here. Figure it out."

I've been figuring it out ever since.

The Principle: A hoop doesn't have to be regulation to teach you how to shoot.

You've got a crate problem of your own. There's something you want to build. A business, a body, a skill, a way out of a job that's eating you alive. And somewhere, in a note on your phone or just circling your head at two in the morning, you keep a list of everything you supposedly need before you can start. The right laptop. The certification. The startup money. The gym membership. The camera. The cosigner. The quiet season of life that stays permanently two months away.

I've read a hundred versions of that list, including a few of my own, so let me tell you what that list actually is. It's not a plan. It's a permission slip, and you're waiting on the world to sign it.

The permission slip has a favorite phrase, too: one day. One day when the money's right. One day when the kids are older. One day when work calms down. Notice something about one day. It is not on the calendar. Monday is on the calendar. October is on the calendar. One day lives nowhere, which is exactly why it feels so comfortable. A date can arrive and catch you unready. One day can't catch you at all. I've watched people stay faithfully committed to one day for decades and call it a plan, and they will defend it hard, because letting go of one day means either starting now or admitting you never meant it.

Somewhere along the line, somebody sold all of us the idea that every goal has an official version, a regulation version, and that starting any other way doesn't count. Regulation hoop: ten feet, glass backboard, painted lane. Regulation business: funded, incorporated, an office with plants in it. Regulation education: four years, brick buildings, a paper with a seal on it. The writer thinks she can't write until the degree comes. The cook thinks he can't cook for money until the food truck is financed. The trainer is waiting on a lease for a gym he's never run, to serve clients he's never coached. Every one of them is standing at the store window pricing helicopters. And notice who profits from the regulation myth: the people selling the equipment and the schools selling the seal. Waiting has a whole economy built around it, and that economy has no interest in you discovering that the sidewalk was free the entire time.

And since the regulation version costs money you don't have and requires permission nobody's giving, you wait. The waiting even feels responsible. "I'm saving up for the right equipment" sounds like discipline. Most of the time it's fear with a budget attached, because the day you start shooting on whatever you've actually got is the day you find out where your shot really is. The list protects you from the scoreboard. The crate doesn't let you hide like that. The crate is honest. It tells you today, in one afternoon, what the list was going to keep from you for years: where you actually stand. Knowing where you stand is worth more than appearing to stand somewhere better. You can't coach a highlight reel.

While I'm at it, let me name the sneakiest version of the waiting, because I've caught myself doing it too: shopping. Researching the gear. Comparing the programs. Watching the roadmap videos, each one two hours long, each one contradicting the last. Buying the domain, the planner, the running shoes with the special foam. Shopping feels like progress because money moved and a box showed up. But a receipt is a prop. Nothing about your shot changed. Nobody has ever bought a jump shot, and the people who tried are easy to spot in the layup line.

Here's what the crate knows that the list doesn't: the asset was never the equipment. The asset is reps. Equipment is a multiplier, and that's all it is. So do the poverty math with me, because I grew up doing this math at the dinner table: any multiplier times zero is still zero. Ten thousand ugly reps on a milk crate beat zero reps on a glass backboard, and it is not close. The kid waiting on the regulation hoop is getting outworked by the kid shooting at a crate every single afternoon, and neither one of them can feel it happening yet. It shows up years later, all at once, and everybody calls the crate kid "a natural."

There's real machinery under that, by the way, nothing mystical about it. Ugly setups teach faster for two reasons. The feedback is instant and rude. A crate rim doesn't flatter a flat shot; it spits the ball back at your chin and lets the whole yard see it happen. Fancy equipment softens feedback, and soft feedback slows learning to a crawl. Constraint also kills your hiding places. On a full court with a forgiving rim, you

can spend an hour dabbling and call it practice. At a crate, there is one shot to take and ten thousand ways to take it, so you take it, ten thousand times. Fewer options, more reps. The truth gets loud.

I've watched this from both ends of the driveway. Summers, we'd stay in Northside Manor in Memphis, and let me tell you how the Manor taught basketball. There was no court. The kids hooped by shooting through the top rung of the monkey bars. A gap barely wider than the ball, no backboard at all, iron that gives you nothing. Out on the street we played curb ball, a whole sport invented from a curb and an argument. And I say this with my whole chest, with no fear of contradiction: there is nobody alive from Northside Manor who can credibly claim they beat me in curb ball. That crown is mine. But the point is bigger than my crown. When you learn basketball with that many restrictions, you learn how to make something beautiful out of nothing. Every restriction was a coach. The tight rim taught touch. The missing backboard taught arc. Nobody in the Manor was embarrassed by the monkey bars, either, and that matters more than it sounds. The ugly version of the game embarrasses people out of playing it all the time. Grown folks quit good ideas every day because the starter version doesn't look like the dream. The dream is downstream of the reps. It has no opinion about how the reps looked.

The crate pays you one more dividend that regulation never will: nobody can repossess a skill you built out of nothing. A jump shot that came from a store can leave you

wondering, somewhere deep, how much of it was the equipment. A jump shot that came off a milk crate answers the question before anybody asks it. Confidence built on reps doesn't wobble when the setting changes, because it was never leaning on the setting. That's why crate kids walk into fancy gyms without blinking. The gym is nicer than what made them. It is never bigger than what made them.

Now, I can hear somebody deciding this figure-it-out talk is a setup for a motivational poster, so let me show you where the method came from and where its edges are. It has edges.

My daddy's teaching style had exactly one move. Out at Spadra, when it was time for me to learn to swim, he threw me in the Arkansas River. That's the whole story. No lesson. No easing into it. Figure it out. So I figured it out. I survived the water, and then I got dominant in it. I became a real swimmer, a diver, somebody who owned a pool the same way I owned a court.

But I have to keep it a buck with you, because this book is about truth, not image. That same wiring once signed me up for the 100 meter butterfly at a swim meet. I see a challenge and I walk toward it, regardless of whether I'm equipped for it. This is, depending on the situation, either my greatest strength or my most catastrophic weakness. The butterfly is chess. I was not a chess swimmer. I was a checkers swimmer. King me and get out of my way. I died at the far wall in front of everybody and finished that race hanging on the lane rope while the whole pool laughed. Told everybody it was the basketball shorts. It was not the basketball shorts.

Both of those stories run on the same method. One produced a swimmer. One produced a cautionary tale in wet shorts. The difference wasn't courage; I had courage both times. The difference was reps. Figure it out is a starting method, and it is only a starting method. Courage gets you to the starting block. Reps get you to the far wall. The crate philosophy was never "wing it and believe." It's get in the water today, then do the work that keeps you off the rope. And I'll say this much for the lane rope: it handed me a skill I didn't know I'd need again at 37. Being bad in public, and coming back the next day anyway.

There's a second place people bend this principle wrong, and my daddy straightened me out on it early, in a Dollar General parking lot.

He had a Sunday side hustle sweeping the Dollar General lot for cash, and I had a Sunday problem called church. So I ran a negotiation at him. I'd take over the sweeping, all of it, I'd drive us there, and he could keep every dollar. Free labor, and all I wanted in return was out of a pew. He accepted in about three seconds, which remains the fastest I have ever closed a deal with any human being.

I figured sweeping a parking lot was self-explanatory. Push broom, push dirt. My daddy watched me flail at it for a minute and then took the broom, because in his world there was a right way to sweep a parking lot. You work with the wind, never against it. You gather in piles. You finish with the blower. And somewhere in that lesson he handed me the sentence I have carried into every warehouse, every

greenhouse, and every codebase since: “If you’re gonna do something, do it. Do it all the way. Don’t halfway clean it. Don’t clean it seventy five percent. You clean it, you clean the whole damn thing.”

When the lot was right, I got the nod. That was the entire compensation system. He did the work, then he looked at the work, then he looked at you. If the work was good, you got the nod. If it was bad, he told you exactly what you didn’t do right and you did it again. I learned more in that parking lot than I ever learned in any building with a steeple on it.

I told you that story for one reason. Start ugly is about your tools. It is never about your standard. The crate was ugly; my jump shot was not allowed to be. The broom was cheap; the lot still had to be clean all the way to the corners. People hear “start with what you have” and think it licenses sloppy work, and when the sloppy work fails they blame the method. The method never said half-do it. The method says use the ugly tool at the full standard, today. Ugly equipment, clean reps. That combination is nearly unbeatable, because everybody with better equipment assumes the equipment is doing the work, and everybody with your equipment assumes the work can’t be done at all.

You’re going to need a nod of your own, by the way. Working with ugly tools means the outside world won’t score you for a while. Nobody claps for a clean parking lot. Nobody reposts your first ugly rep. So you build an internal inspector. Do the work, then look at the work, then be honest about the work. Did I do it all the way, or did I do it seventy five

percent? That question, asked nightly, will carry you through the whole unglamorous stretch between starting and being seen. The nod has to come from inside your own head first. Learn to give it honestly and learn to withhold it honestly, because a nod you hand yourself for sloppy work is worth exactly nothing.

Now let me show you the crate again, three decades later, wearing a different costume. Because if this principle only worked on plywood in Arkansas, it wouldn't be worth a chapter.

In 2024, at 37 years old, with a wife, a baby girl, and a whole company already behind me, I decided to learn to code. No degree. No bootcamp. No guy in my phone who worked at Google. What I had was a laptop, an internet connection, and hours carved out of nights and nap times. And here is how far outside the building I was: I did not know that IDEs existed. If you don't know either, an IDE is the software that professional developers use to write software. It colors your code and catches your mistakes. It practically holds your hand. Every working developer on the planet uses one. Nobody told me.

So I built my first real application, a crypto wallet called DualPay, line by line in a raw terminal window, the way people coded in the 1980s. Black screen. Blinking cursor. Me, typing every single character with my own hands. No autocomplete, no colors, no help. It was the software equivalent of my milk crate basketball hoop. Functional, ugly, built entirely out of stubbornness.

I was proud of it, so I did what I do: I posted a screenshot online. A little while later, one of the Winklevoss twins, the guys from the Facebook lawsuit, the crypto billionaires, replied to it. Two words. “DM me.”

Sit with that sequence for a second. A man who did not know the professional tools existed shipped something real enough, ugly as it was, to pull a billionaire out of the scroll. Then, and I need you to hear the order of operations, then I asked ChatGPT what actual developers write code in. That is the day I learned VS Code existed. Opening it for the first time felt like I’d been writing with a crayon my whole life and somebody handed me a Montblanc pen.

Let me be careful with that story, though, because I promised you no lottery tickets in this book. I cannot promise you a billionaire replies to your first ugly thing. Mine didn’t send money either; a reply is a reply. What I can promise is the direction of the arrow. Shipped work can get seen, and unshipped work cannot be, and that math never flips. The screenshot only existed because the wallet existed. The wallet only existed because I started with the tool I had instead of researching the tool I lacked.

Run the alternate version of that story. Say I had started where most people start, with the research phase. Best laptop for programming. Which bootcamp is worth it. IDE comparison threads. That version of me spends three months assembling the regulation setup and ships nothing, because research is the most respectable-looking form of waiting ever invented. The real version was typing in the dark with a

crayon. The real version shipped. And rooms open for shipped ugly things that never open for perfect plans.

Here's the mechanism. The terminal gave me the exact gift the crate gave my jump shot. When you type every character by hand with no assistance, you are forced to learn what every character does. The mean teacher strikes again. Fundamentals went in at the bottom because nothing was there to fake them for me. So by the time the Montblanc showed up, the hand already knew how to write. That's the whole pattern, and it's mechanical: the ugly version forces fundamentals, the fundamentals compound, and the upgrade lands on top of skill instead of on top of hope.

One more piece of that story matters for your inventory. Strictly speaking, I didn't start from zero at 37. As a kid I used to edit the code on my MySpace page, back when the whole internet was doing it, and I never forgot how it felt. It felt like a magic spell. Type the right words in the right order and the world changes. That seed sat dormant in me for two decades. Same way cannabis seeds go in the ground. It didn't grow right away. It didn't die either. It just sat there waiting for the right conditions. You have seeds like that too. Something you touched years ago that lit you up and then got buried under rent and reality. When you write your inventory tonight, dig for those, because "what I can do" includes everything you half-can-do and once loved. Dormant is not dead.

I won't pretend the tuition was free, because in this book every win comes with a receipt. I wore out three computers in two years. I was bad, in public, at 37, at a thing teenagers

were better at, with a family watching me be bad at it. Being a beginner at four costs nothing. Being a beginner at 37 costs ego, sleep, and time you are painfully aware is not unlimited. I paid it anyway, because the crate had already taught me the core truth: you can teach yourself anything if you're willing to be bad at it first. People ask what qualified me to jump into tech at that age, and the honest answer is the same thing that qualified me at four. The willingness to start before I'm ready and the stubbornness to keep going when I'm lost. That willingness is the entire price of admission, and most people won't pay it. They would rather be a person with great equipment and no reps than an obvious beginner in motion.

In case you're wondering where a man learns to hand his son a crate instead of an excuse, I can trace it. My daddy came to Clarksville from Memphis with next to nothing to his name and the family gospel already in his chest: he was going to figure it out. That belief is the first line of every inventory I've ever taken, written down or not. Belief like that isn't magic either. It's a decision about which direction you face while you work. He faced forward, and he built domino tables and baseball bats and basketball goals out of scrap, facing forward, until facing forward looked normal to his sons. It took.

Before we run this, let me clean up the places people take this principle and bend it until it breaks.

Don't romanticize the crate. Poverty is not a secret blessing, and struggle is not a personality. My daddy did not choose a milk crate for its character-building properties. He

chose it because the helicopter money did not exist, and if it had existed, he'd have bought the real goal that same day and I'd have learned to shoot on glass just fine. The crate is a bridge, never a destination. The afternoon I found out VS Code existed, I switched. No loyalty to struggle. All the loyalty goes to the work. And you'll know it's time to upgrade by one sign: the ugly tool starts stealing reps instead of feeding them. When the crate cracked, my daddy didn't preach perseverance at the crack. He put up a new crate. Maintenance is part of the method too.

And don't wait for anybody to hand you regulation. Nobody handed me a regulation anything, and the rest of this book carries the receipts: a farm scratched out of raw dirt, night shifts on a chicken line I had no plans to stay on. Both started as some version of a crate nailed to a wall. Where I come from, waiting on the regulation version means waiting forever. You do not need permission to build something great. Nobody is coming to sign your slip. The signature was always yours.

Somebody's about to raise a hand and say their field really does require the regulation version, and to a point, fair. Some doors check for paper. If your dream is surgery, please, go to school; nobody wants a figure-it-out appendectomy. But be honest about which kind of door you're actually facing, because most people claim the surgery exception while chasing goals that carry no license requirement at all. There is no credential for starting a lawn business, writing a book, learning to sell, getting strong, or shipping an app. And even

where the paper is real, the crate version still exists on the way to it. You can be deep in the library books years before any institution admits you to anything. The paper takes years. The reps can start tonight.

One more. Don't let "figure it out" turn into "alone forever." My daddy handed me the crate, but he also nailed it up, and he replaced it every single time it broke. Somebody keeping your crate on the wall counts as equipment too. Before you decide you have nothing, look around. Half the time your inventory includes people who would hold the plywood steady if you ever thought to ask.

Now, finding your crate version takes one skill, and that skill is stripping. Every goal is a bundle: one core rep wrapped in accessories that look like the goal but aren't. The cook's core rep is feeding strangers and hearing what they say. The menu fonts, the logo, the truck: accessories. The writer's core rep is finishing pages and showing them to somebody. The website, the retreats, the perfect desk: accessories. The trainer's core rep is coaching a body that isn't his. The lease, the merch, the supplement line: accessories. Here is what nobody tells you. Accessories are the part that costs money and permission. Core reps are close to free in almost every field on earth. The expensive part of your dream is mostly packaging.

The test for whether you stripped it right is simple. The ugly version has to make you better at the thing itself. Shooting at a crate made me better at shooting. Sweeping a lot made me better at finishing. Typing in a terminal made me

better at code. If your starter version only makes you better at talking about the thing, planning the thing, or dressing like the people who do the thing, you stripped it wrong. Go back and find the rep.

Speed is the last ingredient. A decision starts rotting the minute you make it, and the gap between deciding and doing is where the rot gets in. Tonight beats tomorrow by more than one day; it beats it by a whole category, because tonight is a rep and tomorrow is a promise. My daddy didn't put the crate on a vision board. He nailed it up, and I started shooting.

Inventory. That's the whole move. The list you've been keeping is a list of what's missing. Tonight we flip the paper over and count what's there. Skills nobody certified. People nobody calls a network. Hours nobody scheduled. Seeds nobody watered yet. Because the hardest part of everything I have ever built turned out to be the same part every time. Starting. And starting is available to you before you sleep tonight.

Run It

This one costs nothing and takes about 30 minutes. The nothing is the point. If your first move costs money, you're shopping again. Do it tonight, not this weekend. The weekend is where first reps go to die.

1. Get one sheet of paper and a pen. Paper, not the notes app. A note in your phone is buried behind 40 other notes by Tuesday; paper gets taped to walls. Write today's date

in the top corner, because in seven days we are checking your work.

2. Write four headings and fill them honestly. **What I can do:** every skill, certified or not. You can cook, drive, write, lift, fix things, talk to strangers, organize chaos, keep a toddler alive on four hours of sleep. If somebody would thank you for it or pay you a dollar for it, it goes on the list. **Who I know:** real names only, people you could text this week without it being strange. **What I own or can touch for free:** your phone, a library card, a garage, a sidewalk, a kitchen, the free tier of half the software on earth. **When I'm free:** the true number of hours this week. Open your screen time report first and let it testify against you. Then write the honest number.
3. At the bottom of the page, write your goal in one sentence with a number and a date in it. Not "get in shape." Run a 5k on a date you name. Not "start a business." One paying customer by a date you name. If it can't fail, it isn't a goal. It's a mood.
4. Design the milk crate version: the ugliest workable version of that goal that runs this week using only what is on the page. No gym on the paper? The sidewalk is the gym. No camera? The phone shoots the video. No website, no LLC, no logo? A text to five people offering the thing is the business. The rule is hard on purpose: if the version needs money or permission that is not on the page, it is not

the crate version. Redesign it until it runs entirely on paper you already own.

5. Do the first rep before you sleep tonight. Send the one text. Finish lesson one of the free course. Walk the first mile. Write the first page. Cap it at 30 minutes. If your rep is bigger than that, you didn't pick a rep, you picked a project. Shrink it until you can't negotiate with it.
6. Tape the sheet where you will see it every day. Seven days from the date in the corner, count your reps. Five days out of seven and you have earned the right to start pricing better equipment. Anything less, and equipment was never your problem, and now you own a dated piece of paper that proves it. No shame in that. Run the week again.

This exercise is a test of how bad you want the thing. That is all it has ever tested. The crate doesn't care either way. It will still be on the wall tomorrow.

The Crate

A milk crate exists to carry milk. Nobody who designed it ever pictured a rim. That is the secret the crate has been keeping all along: nothing around you knows what it is yet. A curb is a backboard. A river is a swim coach. A black terminal window is a classroom with one desk. The world hands everybody unfinished materials, then waits to see who picks up the hammer. My daddy picked it up, knocked the bottom

out of nothing, and nailed a beginning to the back of a house that had no business producing a shooter. Your crate is sitting somewhere right now, looking ordinary, looking like not enough. It is enough. It has always been enough. Here. Figure it out.

Chapter 2: Know What You Inherited

On Sundays in Clarksville, Arkansas, my daddy ran a two-position game.

Position one was the stove. Position two was the domino table out back. He worked both all afternoon in slacks, a button-down, and hard-bottom shoes, because York Sims Sr. did not own a pair of jeans or a pair of sneakers in his entire life, and he cooked with a white towel over his shoulder like a cornerman working a title fight. He'd stir the pot, taste off the spoon, holler at the table through the door, walk out, slam a domino, collect his winnings and his talk, and be back at the stove before anything even thought about burning. I watched him run that game a hundred Sundays and never once saw him lose either one.

That kitchen had no cutting board in it. No measuring cups either. He cut whatever needed cutting in the palm of his hand, measured by eye and memory, and if a pot went sideways on him he fixed it mid-cook the way a point guard fixes a broken play. No panic. No cussing at the food. A little of this, a minute of that, taste, nod, keep moving. The whole

time he's singing along with the Isley Brothers like the kitchen came with a stage, and the stage was his.

You did not cut through that kitchen while the man was working. Me and my brother Calvin tested that law exactly as many times as it took to learn it. "Get the hell out my kitchen. Matter of fact, take y'all's black asses outside and don't come back in until I call ya." That was the entire hearing. No appeals process. Outside we went.

One Sunday the domino game got heated in the middle of his cook, and my daddy handed off the most important thing in his world with one sentence. "Vanna, keep an eye on that stove, I gotta finish kicking Clarence's ass real quick." My mama watched the stove. He went and finished kicking Clarence's ass. The food still came out perfect. That's the two-position game played at a championship level.

When the food was done, the doors opened. Neighbors. Cousins. Whoever was hungry and close enough to smell it. Everybody got a plate. Nobody left hungry. That law outranked every other law the man had, including the one about staying out of his kitchen. Never mind that we were tight on space and two missed meals from a civil war ourselves. Everybody ate.

Here is the sentence that took me thirty years to understand: the kitchen was the only room in his whole life that he fully owned.

Read that again. A man that sharp, that skilled, that certain of himself, and his entire kingdom was one room with a stove in it. Everything I ever became was cooked in front of me on

those Sundays. So was everything I had to fight my way out of. I just couldn't tell the two apart yet. Sorting them took me half my life, and it turned out to be the most important audit I ever ran.

Now I'm going to show you how to run yours.

* * *

The Principle: The apple didn't fall from the tree. It just landed on different soil.

Let me tell you who my daddy was. All of it, both columns, because the lesson doesn't work if I shine him up first.

York Sims Sr. The family called him Bing. Born in Webb, Mississippi, came up through Memphis, landed in Clarksville, Arkansas, married to my mama, Javanna. Before he was my daddy he was a pimp, a hustler, and a robber. That's the record, and I'm not going to dress it up, because how he got to Clarksville tells you exactly what kind of man we're dealing with.

The night before he left Memphis for good, a dealer fronted my daddy crack and \$2,000 in cash at the same time. Fronting a hustler the product and the money in one transaction tells you everything you need to know about that dealer's future in the business. My daddy took both, pointed the car at Arkansas, and married my mama at the courthouse on the way out of town. Even hustlers have a sense of occasion. He rolled into a town of 5,000 people with stolen

money, a new wife, and a belief in himself so complete it sat somewhere out past confidence and just this side of delusion: whatever came next, he was going to figure it out.

I want you to notice something inside that story, because it's the first move of the audit. Even his crimes had a curriculum in them. Never front product and cash to the same man at the same time is a real rule about deal structure, and I have used the legal version of it in rooms with lawyers and term sheets on the table. My daddy taught it by robbery. I do not recommend the delivery method. The lesson still cashes.

His first day in town, his new brothers-in-law sat him down at the domino table, probably to find out what their sister had dragged home from Memphis. A rules dispute broke out. My daddy, outnumbered three to one in a town where he knew nobody, stood up, dropped his pants, and invited all three of them to do something about it. Nobody did anything about it. A week later they were all laughing at that same table, and that table stayed the center of his world, running at 4:30 every day for as long as I knew him. He understood something most men never learn: force has consequences, but the threat just rearranges the power in a room. I've carried that into every boardroom and negotiation of my career. Not the pants dropping part. Usually.

And the man could think. I mean think at a level I have still never seen matched. My daddy could look at a pile of money and tell you what it counted out to without touching it. He ran odds and percentages in his head in real time. He answered Jeopardy questions from the couch before Trebek

finished reading them. I used to think my dad was just some street dude. I was wrong. He was the smartest person I've ever met in my life, and I've since sat across from engineers and investors with degrees stacked like firewood.

So what was a brain like that doing running hustles in a little Arkansas town? He answered that question with how he lived: my dad chose the streets because he fundamentally, philosophically, in the deepest part of his soul, refused to make another man rich. Punching a clock so somebody else's name got bigger was a kind of death to him. He would rather run his own operation out of a kitchen and a domino table than manage the best shift at another man's store. Hold onto that sentence. It's about to show up in both columns of the ledger.

Robert Kiyosaki wrote Rich Dad Poor Dad about growing up with two fathers, his real one, educated and broke, and his best friend's, unpolished and rich, and he built the whole book on the gap between their two philosophies. People have argued for years about whether the rich dad was even real or a composite character invented to make the lessons land clean. I never needed that argument settled, because I got both dads in one man. The genius and the ceiling shared a body. And I'll take my one real, flawed father over two tidy composite ones every time, because a composite can be edited until his lessons come out spotless, and a real man cannot. His flaws are the verification. The reason you can trust what I kept from my daddy is that I'm about to show you what I had to throw away.

There's a second thing the two-dads-in-one-man setup teaches you, and it's bigger than my family. People think you can only apprentice under somebody's success. Wrong. You can apprentice under a man's failures just as closely, sometimes closer, because failure runs its experiments right in front of you, at the dinner table, every night, free of charge. A studied ceiling is worth as much as a copied code. My father was my rich dad and my poor dad, my mentor and my warning, and I am his student twice over.

Start with the column I kept.

Belief got installed before I could walk. When I was born, December 11, 1986, at Johnson County Regional Hospital, my family looked at me and said, "A king was born." I'm not being arrogant. That's just what they said. And my daddy said it loudest with the name itself, because he gave me his own name before he gave me anything else. When you grow up hearing that about yourself, belief isn't something you have to go find later in a seminar. It's installed at the factory.

Conviction came by demonstration. During the 1992 NBA Draft he pulled five-year-old me to the couch, pointed at the screen, and made a declaration: "This boy right here. This boy is going to be the best to ever play this game." That's how I got my first hero, off my father's certainty alone, and it's why I wore number 32 for years. He never said "believe in things, son." He just believed, out loud, with his whole chest, and let me catch it. Conviction might be the most contagious thing a parent carries.

Reading people came next. When I was seven I spent two solid weeks arguing that the Knicks would win the 1994 Finals. Built my whole case, brought new evidence daily. My daddy let me run it, then put his beer down and ended the debate in one sentence: "Son. You're only going for New York because your name is York." I had no comeback because there was no comeback. He read me like a Sunday newspaper. And he never brought it up again, no victory lap, nothing. He didn't need to win an argument twice. I have spent my whole business life trying to be the man at the table who can find the real motive underneath the stated argument and name it in one sentence.

My decisions, he handed to me. When a man showed up at our house offering to cover the fees and the rides so I could play organized basketball, a league my family could not afford, my daddy didn't give a speech and didn't run the man through an interview. He turned to me and asked one question: "Do you want to play?" I said yes. He said okay. A man who would argue with anybody about anything did not argue with his son about his son's path. He put the decision where it belonged, in my hands, and then he backed it. Years later, on the worst night of my young life, he handed me a far heavier decision the exact same way. That story gets its own room later in this book.

Showing up, he did rarely and perfectly. My daddy came to exactly two of my games in his whole life, and both were championships. In one of them we were down one at halftime, and I looked up and there was York Sr., who had not

been there at tipoff, standing by us with a dill pickle from the concession stand. He said, "Go back out there and kick their ass," gave each of us boys a bite of that pickle like it was communion, and disappeared back into the crowd. We won. Two games attended lifetime, two titles, undefeated as a spectator. That's love. Weird, unconventional, deeply Southern, York Sr. love. Now, I am not telling you two games is enough games. Hold that thought, because it belongs in the other column too. What I'm telling you is the man understood that presence at the moment of maximum pressure counts double, and that a short word at the right time beats a thousand words from the bleachers.

Calm, he taught in one afternoon. A kid I ran with shot me in the neck with a high-powered pellet gun when I was a boy, and I sprinted a mile and a half home holding the hole. My daddy's entire emergency protocol was two words: "Can you breathe?" I could. He poured rubbing alcohol in the wound, checked it with his finger, and said, "It didn't go through. You're good." That calm came from decades of rooms where panic would get a man killed. When everything around me has caught fire since, in courtrooms and in hospitals, my resting heart rate is my father's. That pellet is still in my neck as I write this, by the way, and that fact belongs in the other column. Hold that thought too.

And everybody ate. Broke as we were, my daddy took in whole families when they needed a place and fed anybody who came near that kitchen. I got that from him. It has cost

me real money more than once, and I still won't give it back. Generosity was never a strategy to him. It was law.

That's the code: belief, conviction, reading people, respect for my own decisions, presence under pressure, calm in disaster, and a plate for everybody who shows up. If the chapter stopped here, you'd think I grew up rich. In every way I just listed, I did.

But if I stopped here I'd be handing you a myth, and you can't audit a myth. Some of my family would probably rather I told you the shined-up version of York Sr. I love them, and I won't do it, because a shined-up father is useless to you and he'd have been useless to me. The whole point is that the same box carries both. So here's the other column. Same man. Same house.

My daddy drank, and the drinking was so regular it worked like a stock ticker. Every Saturday, whatever beer came home announced the family's finances better than any bank statement could have. Red Dog meant the bills had won that week. Budweiser meant we were thriving. Steel Reserve in particular was a cry for help in liquid form, 8.1% alcohol content, tasted like it was brewed in a radiator, and cost approximately the same as a pack of gum. That's a funny line now. Back then it was a language, and I was fluent in it before I could do long division. The man who could count a pile of money on sight let two little boys learn accounting that way.

The streets billed him too. They always do. Prison was part of my father's story. How he ended up there involves who he trusted. What trust costs is a lesson that gets its own chapter.

What matters on this ledger is what the bill reveals: the same defiance that made him nobody's employee also kept him in a cash economy with no paper, no protection, and one phone call when it all went wrong. The refusal that I inherited as fuel, he carried as a wall. Same trait. Different ending.

Our house carried weather I should never have learned to forecast. There was drinking, there was arguing in front of us, and some nights there was worse than arguing. My brother and I learned to read the signs the way other kids read cartoons, and there were nights we went to bed with our shoes on so we'd be ready to move. My mama fought her own war inside that house. More than once she walked us out at three in the morning rather than keep us near a situation that had turned volatile, five miles in the dark, on foot, with three kids. That's love, messy and imperfect. It is also evidence. Part of what I inherited from my father is what my mother had to do because of him, and if you need one sentence for your own ledger, take this one: some of your inheritance is what one parent's ceiling cost the other parent. My mama gave me life twice, once when she had me, and again every time she refused to let me quit. Her column in my ledger is long, and almost all of it is code.

My daddy, for all the pickle magic, was present without being there. He was in the house. He was at that domino table at 4:30 every day. He fed us, he built for us, and God help whoever touched us. What he did not do was sit with us, ask us how we were doing, or let us see one inch inside him. Two games in an entire childhood is a real number, and I gave you

the shine on it earlier, so here's the cost of it: I had to teach myself, well into grown manhood, how to be emotionally in a room, because I never once watched it done.

The kitchen holds the saddest entry. The man could truly cook, cook well enough that the whole neighborhood showed up on Sundays, and he talked about a restaurant. He never opened it. The kitchen stayed the only room he fully owned because he never got, or never took, the shot at a bigger one. And it wasn't until the end of his life that I even learned where the cooking came from. That story belongs to the end of this book, so I'll leave it there. What I'll say here is that even the most beautiful thing my father owned had a scar running straight through the middle of it.

Then there's the ocean. My father lived his whole life and never saw it. Not once. That's the tax poverty charges, and it doesn't stop at your wallet. It takes your horizon. When people ask me why I push the way I push, that fact is somewhere inside the answer every single time.

So there's the whole man. A genius with a one-room kingdom. A giant heart and a beer-label bank statement. A walk with a limp in it that he'd turned into a strut, a walk that told every room *I'm him*, and a record that locked him out of most of the rooms that mattered. Love expressed through engineering and almost never through words. Both dads. One body. One box, handed to me with no labels on anything.

Now let's talk about you, because you got handed a box too.

Everybody inherits two things from the people who raised them: a code and a ceiling. The code is what worked, the beliefs and moves and instincts that got your people through whatever they had to get through. The ceiling is where their life stopped, the habits and wounds and walls that kept them from going further, and that will stop you in the exact same spot if you carry them unexamined. And here's the trap: nobody hands you two boxes marked KEEP and BREAK. It arrives as one inheritance, shrink-wrapped, the gold tangled up with the poison. The sorting is your job, and it does not run itself.

People make one of two mistakes with the box, and both of them will eat your life.

Mistake one is worship. You loved the man, or you needed to believe in him, so you keep everything. His sayings, his hours, his drink, his silences, his ceiling, all of it, installed and running. Worship feels like loyalty. It isn't. It's laziness in a church outfit. If I had kept my father's whole script, I'd have died a genius in a cash economy with a one-room kingdom, teaching my own kid to read my bank balance off a bottle.

The second mistake is arson. He hurt you, embarrassed you, left you, so you burn the whole box. Whatever he did, you do the opposite, and you call the opposite a personality. Arson feels like freedom. It isn't. The man is still driving; you've just turned the wheel upside down. I know men who threw out a father's work ethic because it came packed in the same box as his temper. I know men who won't hold their kids to anything at all because their daddy went too far, and

now their kids are paying interest on a correction aimed at a dead man. If I had burned my father's box out of anger at the drinking and the distance, I'd have thrown out the defiance that built my companies, the calm that carried me through handcuffs and hospital rooms, and the belief that got installed before I could talk.

Neither worship nor arson is the move. The move is the audit. Love the man, audit the lessons. Gratitude and honesty are not enemies, they're partners, and anybody who tells you that looking clearly at your parents dishonors them has it exactly backwards. You don't inventory what you don't value. The audit is the respect. My father's inheritance mattered enough to me that I went through it item by item, kept what was gold, and named what was poison, out loud, with his name still on all of it and my love for him not moved one inch. I can tell you he's the smartest man I ever met and tell you the drinking hurt us, in the same paragraph, without either sentence canceling the other. That skill has a name. It's called being an adult about the people who made you.

Here's the part that trips up smart people: most items in the box aren't purely code or purely ceiling. They're the same wire with different insulation. My daddy's defiance made him nobody's servant, and that is the exact same audacity that drives me today, the "I'd rather build my own thing than work for yours" that sits under every company I've ever started. Uninsulated, that same defiance kept him allergic to everything that could have protected him: banks, paper, contracts, help. His showmanship lives in how I enter rooms

now. Uninsulated, it's pants down at a domino table on your first day in town. His calm saved my neck. Uninsulated, it's a man who never once considered taking that boy to a hospital, which is why the pellet is still in me and nobody ever answered for it. And the anger I inherited has been rocket fuel in my life, fuel I'll teach you to burn on purpose in the next chapter. Unmanaged, it ran a pattern I finally had to name for myself: every time I'd been in trouble, every single time, it started with anger and ended with consequences. More than once those consequences came with handcuffs. The only person who could break the pattern was me. Same wire, every time. So the real inheritance question is almost never keep it or trash it. The real question is where the insulation goes.

While you're auditing, you also have to grade the soil, or you'll grade the man wrong. The apple didn't fall from the tree. It just landed on different soil. My father's brain, in his time, in his skin, in Mississippi and Memphis with every legitimate door welded shut, had exactly one market that would pay it what it was worth, and that market was the streets. Take that same brain and drop it on my soil, with the internet, with legal industries that didn't exist in his day, with a terminal window that never asks about your record, and he doesn't die a hustler with a one-room kingdom. I believe with my whole chest he'd have been the founder in somebody's magazine. The soil I landed on was luck, and luck is not a license to judge him. It's the reason the audit is owed. Grade the tree without grading the soil and you'll walk away arrogant, thinking you're better than the man when mostly

you're just later than the man. And the same blade cuts toward you: soil explains your people, but for you, going forward, it's an explanation and never an excuse. You know about soil now. Your kids will be grading yours.

One more stall I have to clear out of your way: waiting for the apology. Some of you have the right-hand column half-written in your head, and you're sitting on it until your father acknowledges what he did, until your mother explains herself, until somebody signs off on your accounting. Let me free you. The audit doesn't require their participation. My father never apologized for one single item in my right column. He didn't do apologies; he barely did words. I sorted the box mostly after he was gone, which means the man never approved my ledger, and the ledger stands anyway. Waiting for permission to be honest about your inheritance is just the ceiling operating under an alias.

Here's what the audit gave me back, once I ran it. When people ask me what I got from my father, the answer comes out sorted now. What I kept: the toughness, the love, the pride in his children, the willingness to do whatever it took to provide. The big heart that helps anyone who asks. The defiance, insulated with paper and lawyers. The showmanship, insulated with substance. The calm, insulated with health insurance. What I threw away: the drinking. The smoking around the kids. The arguing with their mother in front of them. And the violence. That second list reads fast. It did not get built fast. Every line on it took years, and one of them took a counselor in an anger management class I did not

attend voluntarily, asking me the first real question anybody ever asked me about my temper. The ceilings don't come down with a decision. They come down with work, and the decision is just the first swing.

The strangest gift of the audit is what it does to gratitude. Before I sorted the box, my gratitude was vague and my resentment was specific, which is the natural human default and it's backwards. After the audit, it flipped. Now the resentment is filed and the gratitude is itemized. I don't say "my daddy did his best," which is what people say when they've never counted. I say the man showed up at halftime with a pickle and two words and won every game he ever attended. I say he handed me my decisions like a man handing over keys. I say he never once told me about his own glory days, never made his story the ceiling on mine, just built the tools and got out of the way. Audited gratitude has receipts. It's worth ten of the greeting-card kind.

Maybe your box didn't come from a father. The audit doesn't care. You inherited from whoever installed your factory settings: a grandmother, a coach, a big brother, a block, a church, a barracks. Institutions hand down code and ceilings the same way men do. If the streets raised you, you got vigilance in one column and a locked front door on trust in the other. If the church raised you, maybe you got discipline and community on the left and a fear of every question on the right. Whoever and whatever built you, the box has both columns in it. I've never met a person whose box didn't.

You've met my father now, flaws in, which is the only way worth meeting him. This week, you're going to formally meet whoever built you.

Run It

This is the Inheritance Ledger. One sheet of paper, one pen, about thirty minutes. Written, dated, checkable. Not in your head. Your head is where inheritances hide.

1. **Tonight, set up the ledger.** Take one sheet of paper and write at the top the name of the person or place that raised you. If it's more than one, use one sheet each, but start with the loudest voice. Under the name, write today's date. This is a document, not a mood, and documents get dated.
2. **Left column: THE CODE I KEEP.** List at least five things they installed in you that work. Use these prompts: What do people praise you for that nobody formally taught you? What of theirs comes out of your own mouth? What did they survive that you couldn't have survived without their moves? Then, next to each item, write one sentence on how you'll keep it on purpose. An inheritance kept by accident can be lost by accident. "His calm: I'm the one who talks last in every crisis this month" is a kept inheritance. "I'm chill like my dad" is a rumor.
3. **Right column: THE CEILING I BREAK.** At least three entries. Prompts: Where did their life stop? What did they never get to see or own? Which habit billed the whole

household? What have you sworn you'd never do that you've already done once? Next to each, one sentence on the break, and make it checkable instead of poetic. "The drinking stops with me: none in my house by the first of the month" is checkable. "I will heal what was broken" is a vibe, and you can't check a vibe.

4. **Hunt the twins.** Draw a line connecting each code item to its ceiling twin wherever you find a pair, and you will find pairs. Defiance pairs with can't-work-with-anybody. Generosity pairs with no boundaries. Charm pairs with never letting anyone know you. For each pair, write one rule that insulates the wire. Example: "I can refuse to work FOR people without refusing to work WITH people."
5. **Circle one ceiling and swing at it within seven days.** Pick the entry with the biggest bill attached and take one physical action against it this week. Open the savings account your people never had. Book the checkup your father never got. Pour out what's in the house. Put the trip on the calendar with money down. It has to happen outside the paper: an appointment confirmed, a dollar moved, a date inked. When it's done, write the action and the date next to the circle. The ledger isn't finished until something in the physical world has moved.
6. **Pay the left column out loud.** Sometime this week, thank the name at the top for one specific item in the code column. If they're living, call them and name the exact thing: "You taught me to stay calm when everything's on

fire, and it has carried me my whole life. Thank you.” Do not mention the right column. The right column is your work, not their trial. If they’re gone, say it anyway, at the grave, in the car, out loud. The code doesn’t stop being real because the giver is gone, and neither does the debt.

The Crate

The crate on the wall was my inheritance before I knew the word. A man with one room to his name looked at what he had, and what he had was never enough, and he handed it up to his son anyway. Understand what you’re holding when your people hand you theirs: every crate carries the cut of the hands that nailed it, the aim and the splinters together, because that’s the only way a real inheritance ever comes. You don’t owe the splinters your loyalty. You owe the aim. So take what they nailed up for you, keep what’s true in it, sand what cuts, and when your turn comes, hand down something straighter than what you were handed. The tree did what a tree can do. The soil is yours.

Chapter 3: Bet on the Insult

Chris Cooks found me before the game with a message. He delivered it flat, no seasoning, the way you'd hand a man a summons.

"Coach Turner said fuck you."

Bet.

That was my whole reply. One word. Where I'm from, that word is a complete sentence. It means the wager has been accepted and the window for taking it back just closed.

February 2007. Enid, Oklahoma. I was playing for Northern Oklahoma College, and Redlands was next on the schedule, ranked number one in the whole country. Their roster had Charles Bronson on it, 6 foot 8, a man I used to call a teammate. Our roster had me on it. A kid from Clarksville, Arkansas, at his second junior college, two years removed from being somebody.

Rewind those two years so you know what was sitting in my chest that night. I had been the number one basketball player in the state of Arkansas, the number 22 shooting guard in the whole country. Then five minutes in a parking lot, a story that gets its own chapter later in this book, put a felony

on my record, and the state banned me from my entire senior season. The recruiting letters stopped cold. All of them. Schools that had been writing me every week acted like I'd never existed. A year before that night in Enid, I was the eleventh man in a rotation that played eight, in a town smaller than the one I'd spent my whole life trying to leave.

So that's who caught Coach Turner's message. Not a star. A leftover. The kid nobody recruited, staring across the floor at the number one team in America.

Now I have to keep something honest with you, because this book runs on truth, not image. Before that game, my guy Jojo broke the game-day rule, and I broke it right there with him. The details stay in my memoir. What I'll give you is the exact math I used to justify it: by my math, and my dad was the human calculator, not me, we were about to lose by eighty. So the hell with the rule.

Read that back. Before anybody insulted me, I had already conceded the game. My own arithmetic had us buried before the doors opened. That's the part people miss about insults. Sometimes the message doesn't wound you. Sometimes it interrupts you, mid-surrender.

I'd love to tell you I came out blazing. I did not. I scored zero points in the first half. Not a bucket, not a free throw. Zero. Whatever that message lit in me was burning sideways, all smoke and no engine, and Redlands was handling us exactly the way the rankings said they should.

Halftime came and went. Somewhere in that second half, I changed rooms inside myself. I don't have a cleaner way to

say it. The desperation quit feeling like drowning and started feeling like aim.

The basket got wide. The rim looked like a swimming pool.

Fifteen points in the second half. Every kind of bucket, one after another, from the same man who hadn't scored all night. The gym got loud in that way where you stop hearing it, and our own athletic director was up out of his seat screaming, "GIVE YORK THE BALL!"

They gave me the ball. We milked the clock down to four seconds. Every person in that building knew where the last shot was going, including the five men assigned to stop it. I spun past my man and floated one up over Charles Bronson, all 6 foot 8 of him rising out of the lane like a drawbridge.

It hit the bottom of the net like a teardrop falling into a bucket.

Buzzer. Ballgame. The number one team in the country was leaving that gym with a loss, and the paper dated February 13, 2007, printed it plain: "Northern-Enid Sinks No. 1 Redlands."

I never sent a word back to Coach Turner. Didn't need to. Whatever he meant by that message, whatever politics sat behind it, none of it survived four seconds and a floater. The scoreboard was the reply, and a scoreboard doesn't stutter.

* * *

The Principle: I am most dangerous when I am desperate.

You've been handed your own version of that message. I'd put money on it. Maybe it didn't come through a guy named Chris Cooks. Maybe it came through a guidance counselor who slid the community college brochure across the desk while you were still talking about a university. A loan officer who smiled with the front of her face while her hands were already moving your file to the no pile. A boss who said "let's circle back" so many times the circle turned into a wall. Or a parent, and this one costs the most, somebody who loved you and still said, "People like us don't do things like that."

The message always translates to the same sentence: you're not enough. The mail runs whether you like it or not. The only thing you own, the entire thing, is the chemistry of what happens after it lands.

Some messages never even get spoken out loud. For some of you the insult came as a price tag you couldn't touch, a zip code, a last name, a waiting room chair you sat in while a stranger decided your family's month. The message doesn't need words to tell you you're not enough. It just needs to arrive. Treat the silent ones the same as the loud ones. They convert to the same fuel.

Then there's the hardest category: the messages that come from people who love you. The grandmother who says "don't get your hopes up" because her own hopes got snatched once and she's trying to spare you the fall. The uncle who laughs at your business idea at the fish fry, not because he hates you,

but because nobody at that table has ever watched a plan actually work. Love-wrapped doubt is still doubt. But hear me on this part: you burn the sentence, never the person. Cutting off your whole family because they couldn't see your vision is just weight wearing a costume. The move is quieter than that. Take grandma's sentence to the gym with you, cash the bet, then hand her the receipt at Thanksgiving and let her tell the whole table she always knew you had it in you. Let her have that. The scoreboard already knows the truth, and scoreboards don't need credit.

People ask me what drives me, and they expect the usual answers. It's not money. It's not fame. It's not even the love of the game. What fuels me is someone looking me in the face and telling me I'm not enough. That's not a comfortable engine to admit to. There's a crack in it too, and I'll show you the crack before I let you run yours on it. But it's true, and I'd rather hand you a true engine with a known defect than a clean-sounding lie.

An insult that lands on you goes one of two places. It becomes weight, or it becomes gas.

Weight is what happens when you carry the insult around whole, unburned. You know this person. You might be this person. Weight is rehearsing the comeback in the shower six years after the conversation. Weight is telling the story at the cookout so many times your cousins mouth the words along with you. Weight is checking the old boss's company page at midnight hoping the numbers dipped. The insult sits in the tank, sloshing around, and the vehicle never moves an inch.

And understand something about weight: it keeps the insulter in the driver's seat. Every hour you spend rehearsing what you should've said is an hour that man got from you for free. He spent one sentence and bought years of your attention. That's the worst deal you'll ever sign.

The cruelest part is that weight feels like loyalty to yourself. Carrying the grudge feels like refusing to let them get away with it. But check the ledger. Ten years of retelling, and they haven't lost a dollar or an hour of sleep. You've lost a decade of compound interest on your own attention. Holding the insult doesn't hold them accountable. It just holds you.

Gas is different. Gas is the insult burned in the work, converted to output. Burned means gone. Fuel that's actually been used doesn't end up in your mouth at the barbershop. It shows up as a made shot, a paid invoice, a finished certificate, a deadline hit. The insult stops being a story you tell and becomes a number somebody else has to explain.

Here's the test, and it's cold: where does your insult live, in your mouth or in your calendar? If everybody at your job knows what your ex said about you, but your bank account and your skills look the same as they did the day she said it, you're hauling weight. If nobody knows the sentence that drives you, but your output keeps climbing past explanation, you're burning gas. Quiet tank, loud scoreboard. That's the ratio you want.

Conversion is not a mood, either. It's a procedure, and it runs on a clock. Here's how I do it. First, write the sentence down cold, the exact words, the way Chris Cooks delivered

them to me. No softening it, no editing it into something more polite. The precise wording matters, because that's the wording your brain is going to replay at 5 a.m. anyway; you might as well be the one holding the pen. Second, find the scoreboard the sentence maps to. Every insult is secretly a measurement. "You'll never save a dime" maps to a bank balance. "You're not college material" maps to a transcript. That number is where the argument gets settled. Third, schedule the rep. Not the triumph, the rep. The insult doesn't get answered at some finish line years from now. It gets answered today, at whatever ugly first step is available, because fuel has a shelf life. An insult you don't burn while it's hot doesn't evaporate. It rots. Give it a month of sitting in the tank untouched and it turns into weight, and weight works for the other side. The day I heard what Coach Turner said, I didn't get to schedule my answer for some future season when conditions improved. The game was already on the calendar. Yours usually is too, in some form. There's a version of the first rep available to you within 24 hours of any insult you'll ever receive. Take it while the thing still burns.

Now let me talk about desperation, because that word scares people and it shouldn't.

My dad had a saying: a desperate man is a dangerous man. He meant it as a warning about other people. Watch the man with nothing left, because there's nothing he won't do. Daddy was right, and Chapter 6 will show you the receipts on that. But somewhere along the way I flipped his warning inward and made it mine. If a desperate man is a dangerous man, and

I'm the desperate man, then the danger is mine to point. I am most dangerous when I am desperate. Same law, aimed out the other end of the barrel.

The reason it works is simple mechanics. Desperation strips options. Most people stay weak because they're holding 12 outs and keeping every one of them warm. Half their energy goes to maintaining escape routes. The desperate man has one door, so 100 percent of him goes through it. That night in Enid, I had no scholarship offers coming and no next season promised. There was nothing left to protect and nothing to save myself for. With nothing to lose, you play free.

Now, some of you reading this have the opposite problem, and I see you too. Nobody's desperate at your house. The bills are paid, the job is fine, the couch is comfortable, and the dream is dying quietly of comfort. Fine is the most dangerous neighborhood I know, because nothing in it makes you move. If that's you, you can't sit around waiting for the wolf to show up at your door. You have to borrow desperation on purpose. Close some of your own outs. Set a deadline with a real consequence hanging off it, money you forfeit if you miss, or a class that starts whether you're ready or not. Tell the one person who will actually hold you to it, and only that one person. I'm not telling you to torch your life for motivation. I'm telling you that focus follows stakes, and if life won't supply the stakes, you supply them. A man with a comfortable fallback fights different than a man without one, and everybody in the room can tell which one he is.

But split a hair with me here, because this is where people get the principle wrong. Desperation and panic are not the same substance. Panic is desperation with no target. It sprays. Panic is the man who loses his job, fires off 300 applications with the same resume, calls nobody, sleeps till noon, and calls that hustle. Focus is desperation with one target. Same pressure, same stakes, aimed at a single point until the point gives. The pressure was never the problem. Unaimed pressure is the problem. A firehose nobody's holding just whips around the yard breaking things. The same water, gripped and pointed, cuts steel.

So when the message comes, the question isn't whether you'll feel the heat. You will. The question is whether the heat has coordinates.

Which brings me to fake fuel, because there's a counterfeit version of everything I just taught you, and the counterfeit has ruined more comebacks than laziness ever did.

Fake fuel is the revenge fantasy. It's the movie you run at night where they finally see it, where the coach who cut you is in the front row of your press conference crying into his lanyard. Fake fuel feels identical to real fuel in your chest. Burns just as hot. Here's how you tell them apart: real fuel produces receipts, and fake fuel produces rehearsals. One ends in a number on a scoreboard. The other ends with you, still in the shower, undefeated in arguments that never happened.

There's one more tell on fake fuel: it always needs an audience. The revenge fantasy has them in it, watching,

finally understanding what they had. Receipts don't require attendance. And here's a truth that stings first and frees you after: most of the people who doubted you will never check the score. They fired off their sentence and went on with their lives. They are not following your progress, and no highlight of yours is going to interrupt their dinner. If your plan requires them to witness your winning, your plan has a hole in it shaped exactly like their attention. Win for the record, not for the crowd. The record keeps everything. The crowd was never really watching.

I know the difference because I paid for the knowledge. Every time I'd been in trouble, every single time, it started with anger and ended with consequences. That's my own accounting across my own life, and I'd show you the itemized bill except it has handcuffs in it. Anger with no scoreboard put me in rooms with bailiffs. Anger with a scoreboard put me in headlines. Same fire. The only variable was whether it had a target with a number on it.

Learn the exchange rate before you spend. An insult costs the sender nothing. Words are free to mail. But answering one wrong can cost you everything you've got, and the people sending them usually understand that better than you do. Some men will hand you an insult the way a fisherman hands the water a worm, because they profit when you bite. The system they're standing in is built to make your reaction more expensive than their provocation, and that math never runs in your favor. So the discipline isn't pretending it didn't sting. The discipline is refusing to pay retail for a reaction when you

can invest the same heat somewhere it compounds. Every insult is an offer. You don't have to accept the terms written on it. You can counter.

Two days after Redlands, I got to run the cleanest experiment of my life on this exact question. We played Fort Smith, the defending national champions, a program that had passed on me. And I played that one with joy instead of rage. Loose. Free. I dropped 25 on them and stared at their bench after every single bucket. In one week, I had beaten the number one team in the country on a buzzer beater and demolished the defending national champions. The junior college people named me national player of the week. One year after I couldn't crack an eight-man rotation.

Sit with what that week teaches. Rage got me into the gym, I won't lie about that. The insult was the ignition. But joy played the games. Rage is starter fluid. You spray it, the engine catches, and then you'd better have real fuel behind it, because starter fluid burns off in seconds and eats the engine if you keep spraying. By the Fort Smith game, that stare I gave their bench wasn't anger anymore. It was an invoice.

And here's the honest cost, because every win in this book comes with the receipt attached: we finished that season 14 and 15. The floater didn't turn my life into a movie. The season stayed a losing season. But I got what I came for. Proof, printed in a newspaper with a date on it, that the message was wrong. You don't always get the fairy tale. You can always get the receipt.

People hear about that week of my life and want to make it mystical. I'll allow you the only mysticism I deal in: the universe keeps receipts. And eventually, it pays them back. But notice the mechanism before you go light a candle. The universe didn't lift that floater. Years of reps on a milk crate lifted that floater. What the universe did was schedule the meeting, put the number one team in the country in front of the one man in that gym with an insult in his chest and nothing to lose. The payback only clears if the work is already banked. That's why you keep taking reps through the quiet years, when nobody's insulting you because nobody's noticing you. You're not being ignored. You're accruing.

Let me give you one more story, because the messages don't stop coming once you leave the gym, and neither does the method.

Years later, cannabis money in my pocket, somebody at a dinner table asked me my dream car. Torch-red Corvette C7. That same weekend, I went to the dealership to get it.

The lot took one look at me, a young Black man standing next to a Corvette, and made its decision before I opened my mouth. Nobody would let me test drive it. The senior salesmen wouldn't even walk over. They sent the most junior saleswoman they had to brush me off with a smile.

Old me had options for that moment, and every one of them ended in a scene. Instead I gave them three words on my way out: "I'll be back."

I came back with a cosigner and cash, and then I did my favorite part. I dictated the terms: "She gets the commission."

The junior saleswoman. The brush-off girl. They asked why. "Because she was the only one honest enough to come talk to me."

Then I drove home and told Cassidy I'd bought a Corolla, and watched her jaw drop when she saw what was actually parked outside.

Take that story apart, because every piece of it is load-bearing. Notice what I didn't do. Didn't argue with the salesman, didn't demand a manager, didn't perform my resume for men who had already graded me, didn't stand in that showroom explaining my worth. Arguing on their lot was the weight option, free attention for people who'd insulted me. Notice what I did instead: I answered them in their own currency. A dealership keeps score in sold cars, so that's the scoreboard I posted on. Notice the commission. The one person who treated me straight got paid for it, in writing, on the deal itself, not with a compliment. When somebody's honest with you inside a building full of people who aren't, make honesty profitable for them. That's how you vote for the world you want to live in. And notice the Corolla. I didn't announce the dream at that dinner table and then narrate my revenge all week. The bet stayed quiet until it cashed. A bet announced early is a bet everybody gets to tax and talk you out of. Place it silent. Let the driveway make the announcement.

While we're on quiet bets, let me define the word all the way, because "bet" carries this whole method in one syllable. Where I'm from, when a man says bet, he isn't debating you.

He's done debating you. The word is a signature on the shortest contract ever written: terms understood, payment to follow, no further discussion required. What makes it beautiful is what it leaves out. No rebuttal. No speech about who you are and what you're about to show them. The speech is a withdrawal from the same account the work draws on, and you only have so much in there. Every minute spent telling somebody what you're going to do is a minute of doing spent on a performance for an audience that isn't coming to the show. Say bet. Say it to yourself if saying it out loud would tip your hand. Then go quiet and let the interest build.

Somebody's going to tell you this whole chapter is petty. That healed people don't need to prove anything to anybody. The somebody who tells you that usually inherited their runway, and it's easy to preach about letting go of fuel when your tank came filled. Here's my answer: fuel is fuel. The engine doesn't ask where the gasoline grew up, and neither does the work. A chip on your shoulder is only a character flaw if it never becomes a down payment.

Maybe you're reading all this thinking the principle belongs to young men with good knees. Let me close that door.

In 2024, at 37 years old, with a wife and a baby and a business, I taught myself to code. Chapter 1 already told you how ugly that start looked. When I got good enough to have proof, I did what you're supposed to do. I applied. Anthropic.

OpenAI. NVIDIA. Micron. The biggest names in the industry that was becoming my industry.

Rejections and silence. Even with an inside introduction, rejections and silence. I had forty applications' worth of live, working proof sitting on the internet under my own name, and I could not get a callback.

Twenty-year-old me would have carried that as evidence the game was rigged, and he would have carried it loud. Thirty-seven-year-old me ran the conversion I've been teaching you this whole chapter. Every rejection email got read one time and then turned into that day's reason to ship. The repos stayed public, 25 of them, stacking up while the inboxes stayed quiet. I stacked paper receipts next to the code too: Google's Python certificate, IBM's certificates in software engineering and AI, an agentic AI course out of Vanderbilt, chip design, a security certification. None of it made the phone ring. All of it made me harder to argue with. The building eventually walked me into rooms my applications never could, and Chapter 7 tells that story. The point here is smaller and harder: nobody's callback got to decide whether I kept building. A rejection email is just the modern Chris Cooks. Bad news in a flat voice, and the same decision to make once it lands.

And keep one ear open when the messages come, because some insults smuggle intel. The counselor sliding that brochure might be reading a real gap in your file. The rejection that stings the most might be pointing at the one tool you're genuinely missing, the way mine eventually pointed

me back to school. You can burn the disrespect and keep the data; those are not opposing moves. Pride refuses the information entirely. Weight memorizes the wording and learns nothing from it. Gas does both jobs at once, burns the tone and banks the lesson. The men who sized me up at that dealership had nothing to teach me about cars. The emails that told me no were telling me which wall to stop knocking on. Sorting one from the other is a skill, and the sort is simple: strip the delivery off the message and ask whether a fact remains.

One warning before I hand you the exercise, and this warning is the crack in the engine I promised you.

Spite will get you out of bed at four in the morning. Revenge will fuel you through twenty hour days. The chip on your shoulder will carry you further than most people's plans. But it's not sustainable. A life powered entirely by they-said-I-couldn't crosses every finish line and enjoys none of them, because the judges it performs for stopped watching years ago. I know men still winning arguments with a coach who's dead. The insult is ignition, and ignition is all it is. Somewhere between the crank and the highway, you have to find something to run toward, or you'll spend your whole life just running from. For me the answer eventually had a name. Zuri gave me something to run toward. I refused to become what my hometown expected me to become, at first out of spite, eventually out of love. Both fuels moved me. Only one of them left anything in the tank.

You can check which fuel you're burning with one gauge: watch what a win does to you. If a win lands and you actually taste it, if it buys you an evening of being proud around the people you love, you're running clean. If every win converts instantly into the next grievance, if the trophy is in your hand and your mouth is already relitigating some older score, that's spite in the tank, and spite reads empty no matter how much you pour in. I've had both kinds of wins. The Redlands game I remember as fire. The Fort Smith game I remember as fun. It took me years to notice which memory I reach for more.

Brian Tracy has a drill in his book *Goals!* where you write out 10 goals, make each one measurable with a deadline, pick the one with the strongest pull, and rewrite it by hand every day until your aim sharpens itself. It's the best paper-and-pen ritual I've ever come across, and I stole it without apology. I changed one thing: where it starts. Tracy starts with your ambitions. I start with your insults, because if you're the reader this book was written for, your ambitions might still be whispering, but your insults are already on file, each one with a date and a voice attached. We're going to use them.

Run It

This one is called the Bet List. You need a pen, a sheet of paper, a 3x5 index card, and 10 minutes tonight. Not this weekend. Tonight.

1. **Write the insult list.** Ten sentences, every one starting with "They said I couldn't." Real ones only, with real voices

behind them: the coach, the counselor, the loan officer, the relative, the form-letter email that decided to move forward with other candidates. If you can hear the voice when you read it back, it qualifies. Nobody sees this paper but you, so tell the whole truth on it.

2. **Convert each insult into a bet.** A bet is a measurable goal with a number and a date. “They said I couldn’t get the money” becomes “I save \$5,000 by December 1.” “They said I’d never finish anything” becomes “I hold the certificate on May 30.” If you can’t attach a number and a date to it, it’s still a feeling, so keep working it until it’s a bet. Do the converting on paper, in ink: a psychology professor named Gail Matthews at Dominican University of California studied goal setters and found that the people who wrote their goals down accomplished significantly more of them than the people who only carried them in their heads.
3. **Take the names off the bets.** Names live on the insult side of the page only. If a bet still has a person in it (“prove Coach wrong”), that’s fake fuel, so rewrite it as a scoreboard (“start every game by January”). You burn the sentence. You never chase the person.
4. **Circle one.** Read all 10 bets out loud, alone, and circle the one that makes your chest hot when you hear it in your own voice. Not the easiest one. Not the one that would impress everybody at Thanksgiving. The hot one. One circle only; the rest of the list waits its turn.

5. **Put it on the card.** Write the circled bet on the 3x5 card in present tense, number and date included: "I save \$5,000 by December 1." The card rides wherever your phone rides, pocket or purse, so every time you reach for the distraction, the bet is sitting on top of it.
6. **Rewrite it every morning for seven days.** By hand, from memory, before you touch your phone. It takes 30 seconds. If the wording comes out sharper on day four than it was on day one, keep the sharper version. After a week you'll know whether the bet is real. Keep rewriting anyway, because the drill was never about the week.
7. **Place the first stake tonight.** Before you sleep, do one physical thing the bet requires. Move the first \$20 into the account. Send the enrollment email. Or pack the gym bag and set it by the door where you'll trip over it in the morning. A bet with no stake is a wish with good handwriting.

This exercise is a test of how bad you want it. The list costs 10 minutes. The card costs 30 seconds a day. If that price feels too high, then what they sent you wasn't an insult. It was a scouting report, and it was accurate. Prove otherwise. In ink.

The Crate

A milk crate nailed to the back of a house is an insult, if you choose to read it that way. Other kids had regulation. We had a plastic square with the bottom knocked out, and every car

rolling past could see exactly what my family couldn't afford. A boy can take that two ways. He can carry it, or he can aim at it. I aimed at it. Every shot that dropped through that crate was a bet quietly paid off, and nobody driving by ever knew a wager was on the table. That's the whole secret. The world will keep mailing you its opinion of what you can't do. You don't have to answer with your mouth. Nail the opinion to the wall. Shoot at it until the streetlights come on. Let the made ones do the talking. Bet.

Crate 1: The Break

Plastic is not made for this.

A milk crate is built to hold milk. The people who made it never guessed that a ball would be fired at its mouth from first light to full dark, day after day, by a boy who does not know how to stop. The boy shoots before school. He shoots after school until the streetlights come on, and then past them. The crate takes it. Takes it and takes it.

Then one evening a crack opens beside a nail, thin as a hair. The crack runs. The plastic gives the way plastic gives, all at once, and the rim tears half loose and hangs off the wall by one nail, swinging a little in the evening air.

The boy stops. The ball sits in the dirt. He does not go hunting for the hammer, because the hammer is not his, and the nails are not his, and the wall belongs to the house and the house belongs to the man inside it. He is a boy.

He waits.

The father comes around the back of the house, sees the crate hanging crooked, and looks at it the way he looks at every broken thing, without alarm, the way a man looks at weather. Soon a new crate stands against the plywood. New

nails go in beside the old holes, and later the rain finds the old holes and bleeds thin orange streaks of rust down the gray wood.

It happens again. Every other week, near enough, the plastic gives out and the shooting stops and the boy waits and a new crate goes up. The father never says one word about it. He never charges the boy for the damage, never asks whether all this shooting is going anywhere a man can cash. He drives the nails and goes back inside.

The plywood fills with holes. A stranger could stand in that yard and read the wall and count the crates like rings in a stump.

So the boy learns a thing that nobody says out loud. Things break. Breaking is not the end of them. Somebody comes with a hammer, the ball goes back up, the game goes on.

There is a day out there, far off still, when the thing that breaks will not be plastic. When that day comes, the boy will stand in front of the broken thing and wait the way he is waiting now, and nobody will come around the corner of the house. Nobody will bring nails. He will stand in the quiet a long time, and then he will have to go find the hammer himself.

But that day is another country. Tonight the new crate is up, the nail heads are bright as coins, and the ball is back in his hands before the streetlights finish coming on.

PART II: THE FALL

What breaks you

Chapter 4: Pay the Bill Once

The officer took his time coming up the walk.

I remember that part. No hurry in him anywhere. A man with questions moves fast, because questions make him nervous too. A man with answers strolls. This man strolled, and I sat there at 17 years old doing bad math in a folding chair, telling myself the stroll meant nothing.

My dad had set out two folding chairs on the porch. He sat in one. I sat in the other. A few nights earlier, me and some boys had torn up a truck in a school parking lot, and we'd all sworn to a story, and now I was sitting next to a man who could count a pile of money by looking at it, about to find out what my story was worth.

The officer stopped at the steps and started talking.

He wasn't asking questions. That's the thing I need you to understand about that porch. He was reading back answers. The parking lot. The truck. What got broke and what got took. Who was there. He went through that night like a man reading a receipt, detail after detail, and I sat in that chair listening to a stranger recite my own life to me. He had everybody's part in it, too. Everybody's but one boy's, and it

took me years to do the math on whose part was missing and what that meant.

Then he did something I didn't expect. He stepped off the porch and gave us a minute.

My dad turned in his chair and looked at me. And here I have to stop and tell you who was sitting in that other folding chair. York Sims Sr. was a hustler out of Memphis with a math brain that should have run a bank, a man who'd been on both sides of more police conversations than he ever counted for me. If there was ever a father alive who could have coached a lie, scripted it, drilled it, cleaned it up and pressed it for court, he was three feet away from me.

Here's what he said instead.

"I'm not going to ask you what happened. Don't tell me what happened. I don't want to know. Just tell the truth. Whatever truth you tell him, I'm going to support. I'll advise you to tell him the truth. But whatever you say to that man when he walks back up here is what I'm going with. You understand me?"

I said I understood. I didn't, not all the way. But I said it.

He leaned back and gave me the rest.

"You about to make a decision. I'm not gonna make it for you. This is yours. You the one gonna have to live with it. Not me."

Then he was done. That was the whole speech. No coaching, no script, no whooping, no rescue. My father handed me my own life on that porch the same way he'd been

handing me things my whole childhood, with the wrapping already off and the instructions missing.

The officer walked back up the steps.

Now hold on to what I told you a minute ago. The man had already recited the entire night to us. He had everything. Whatever came out of my mouth next was not going to inform him of one single thing. The only question left on that porch was what kind of man I was going to be while he wrote it down.

I gave him the story. The one we'd agreed on. I looked at a man who could recite the truth from memory, and I handed him the lie, with my daddy sitting right there, having just promised to back whatever I said.

My dad went with it. Like he said he would. He backed my lie through everything that came after, and everything that came after was a lot.

And he never mentioned that porch again. Not the next morning. Not after the handcuffs. Not once in the rest of his life. He let me live with it.

I've been living with it ever since. So let me hand you the bill I've been carrying, so you don't have to carry yours anywhere near as long.

The Principle: The truth would have cost me less than the lie.

Let me back up and give you the whole night, because the night matters.

It started with a word in a Walmart parking lot. A girl we knew called us, upset, because a white boy from school had called her and her friends niggers. Five minutes of ugly in a parking lot, one word doing what that word has always done in the South, which is light a fuse and walk away whistling.

And here's the part that makes me want to reach back through time and grab my own collar: it got handled. Somebody's mama sat everybody down on a porch and talked the thing through, grown-folks style. That mediation should have been the end of the story. Apologies pointed where they needed to point. Case closed.

We didn't let it be closed.

A few nights later we ended up in a school parking lot where the boy's truck was sitting, and one of the boys had a mallet, and somewhere between the first swing and the drive home, my keys got used to pry the CD player out of the dash. A CD player I didn't even want. I put it in my memoir in one line: "Five minutes in a Walmart parking lot started this. Five minutes in a school parking lot was going to finish it."

I knew it was wrong while it was happening. I have never once claimed otherwise. But "knowing something is wrong and stopping yourself from doing it are two very different skills, and at seventeen, I hadn't developed the second one yet."

Then came the pact. Stick to the story. Everybody hold the line. All of us cosigning one loan, and not one of us read the terms.

They came for me in second period.

Handcuffs, at school, walked out the front doors past the gym where I'd been king. Understand what I was at that moment. I was the number one basketball player in the state of Arkansas, ranked among the top shooting guards in the whole country, with recruiting letters coming from schools like Oklahoma State, UConn, and Stanford. I wrote about the fall the only honest way I could: "the fall doesn't happen slowly... It's instant. One moment you're the number one player in the state. The next moment you're in handcuffs."

Watch how the consequences got handed out, because they did not get handed out by fairness. They got handed out by juice. The boy who talked got to play ball. Me and Bradley caught felonies, five years of probation, and a season ban. Then the athletic association banned me from playing anywhere in the state. "I was the number one basketball player in Arkansas, and I couldn't play basketball in Arkansas." The recruiting letters stopped that same day. Forever. Because "when a small town wants to make an example out of somebody, it doesn't pick the kid nobody's heard of."

The felony itself turned out to be more than a court date. "A wall between me and voting. Between me and certain jobs. Between me and financial aid. Between me and the life I was trying to build."

All of it. “Over a truck. Over a CD player I didn’t even want. Over a word.”

* * *

My dad was a human calculator. I mean that literally. I’m that man’s son, and I still got the simplest math of my life wrong on a porch at 17. So let me write the formula down for you the way I wish somebody had written it down for me.

A consequence is a principal balance. The moment you do the thing, you owe it. Nobody’s opinion changes the balance. Your silence doesn’t change it. Your story doesn’t change it. The truth doesn’t create the bill, either, and this is where people get confused. The thing you did created the bill. The truth is how you pay it.

But a lie is not a payment. A lie is financing.

When you lie about a thing you did, you have not touched the principal. You’ve deferred it. And deferred debt charges interest, and the interest on a lie is a specific kind of brutal. It charges you in story maintenance, because a lie is a machine with parts, and you’re the only mechanic, forever. It charges you in distance, because you can’t be all the way close to anybody who believes the story. It charges you in watchfulness, because “shame has a way of making you think the whole world is staring.” And it compounds, because every day you don’t pay, the payment gets harder to make. A truth told today is a conversation. The same truth told in a year is a confession. In 10 years it’s an excavation.

You don't need a felony for this math to find you. Look at your own ledger. The line on your resume that stretches nine months into two years. The number you told your wife the car cost. The deadline you missed and hung on the vendor, who took the heat in a meeting you sat quiet through. The "I'm fine" you've been issuing at home like a press release. Every one of those started as a one-time bill, small enough to pay standing up. But you financed it instead, and now look at your terms. You can't let the new boss call the old boss. You flinch when your wife mentions the mechanic. You keep one eye on that vendor in every meeting, because the man knows. That's interest. You're paying it this month whether you ever call it that or not.

And the group version is worse, because group lies charge group interest. That pact we made as boys, stick to the story, everybody hold the line, that wasn't loyalty. That was cosigning. When you cosign a lie at your job, in your family, on your team, you've tied your credit to the discipline of the weakest liar in the room. Ask me how that works out. The story only has to break in one place, and somebody desperate will always break it, and when it breaks, everybody pays the full balance plus everything the cover-up ran up in the meantime. The cover-up always bills bigger than the crime. That's not a slogan. That's amortization.

Now here's the wildest part of my particular loan: the lie bought me nothing.

Go back to that porch. The officer recited the whole night to us before I said one word. My lie did not protect me from

the felony. The felony came anyway. The handcuffs in second period came anyway. The ban, the probation, the letters drying up, all of it arrived on schedule and in full. The lie prevented nothing. All the lie added was itself, one more charge on top of a bill I was already going to pay. Years later I wrote the accounting down in two sentences: "The truth would have cost me less than the lie I gave. But I made the call."

Notice I don't say the lie happened to me, or that I found myself lying. I made the call. I chose those four words on purpose, because paying the bill starts with grammar. The passive voice is a hiding place. "Mistakes were made" has no return address. When you write your own bill down, and in a few pages I'm going to make you write it down, put yourself as the subject of the sentence. I lied. I took. I let them believe it. If the sentence costs you nothing to write, you wrote it wrong.

That's the trade most liars are actually making, and almost none of them know it. You think you're choosing between consequence and no consequence. You're almost never choosing that. The evidence usually exists. The other person usually knows, or will. What you're actually choosing between is a bill paid once and the same bill on a payment plan with your character as the collateral.

Learn to separate the two costs in your head, because your fear can't tell them apart. Consequences are what the deed costs. Interest is what the hiding costs. When you're standing on your own porch, scared, your mind lumps them into one

big number and swears the truth costs that much. It doesn't. The consequence is usually coming either way. The only number actually on the table, the only part you control, is the interest. Truth zeroes it out. The lie compounds it. That's the whole choice.

While we're in the ledger, let me close a loophole your brain is already reaching for. There's a move people think counts as paying, and it doesn't: transferring the balance. That's what the boy who talked did. He told plenty of truth that week, none of it about himself, all of it priced to move. On paper he walked away clean. He got to play. But a balance transfer is not a payment, and years later, when word reached me that it bothered him how that story still follows him around town, I told him exactly where the account stood: "you snitched, you made that bed, you've got to sleep in it. If it bothers you that we still talk about it, that's yours to carry." Selling somebody else's truth to get a discount on your own is not honesty. It's a different loan with a worse rate. Paying the bill once means your bill. Your part, in your words, at your expense.

Two more counterfeits before we leave the bank, because people hear "own it fast" and run off and do something ugly with it.

The first counterfeit is confession as relief. That's when you dump a truth on somebody purely to get the weight off your own chest, no correction attached, and walk away lighter while they sit there holding what you handed them. A payment includes the fix. If the truth comes with no changed

behavior, no restitution, no plan, then all you did was transfer the storage fees. Before you speak, ask yourself one thing: am I paying this bill, or am I asking them to warehouse it? If the telling serves you and only wounds them, you're not settling a debt. You're making a delivery.

Counterfeit number two is truth as a weapon. You know these people. "I'm just being honest" is their favorite alibi, and their honesty always draws blood and never seems to cost them anything. Real payment costs the payer. That's how you can tell it's real. If your honesty is a bill for somebody else and a show for you, keep it in your pocket. You cannot pay your debt with another man's skin.

One more, since we're counting: the statute-of-limitations myth. People figure if enough years pass, the bill expires. It doesn't. It goes dormant. I told that lie as a teenager, my father never said one word about it for the rest of his life, and I'm sitting here decades later writing you a chapter about it. Unpaid truth doesn't age off your report. It waits.

* * *

I want to go back to the porch one more time, because my dad ran a clinic that day and I didn't recognize it for years. If you ever have to hold somebody accountable, somebody you love, your kid, your brother, your employee, your partner, that speech is the blueprint. Take it apart piece by piece.

"I'm not going to ask you what happened. Don't tell me what happened. I don't want to know." He refused to take

custody of my decision. He wasn't going to carry my secret for me, and he wasn't going to appoint himself my judge. The weight stayed exactly where it belonged, on me, at full price.

"I'll advise you to tell him the truth." Advice, given once, plainly. He didn't campaign. He didn't repeat himself, because he never was a man who repeated himself. One sentence, on the record, and then he let it stand there and breathe.

"Whatever truth you tell him, I'm going to support." Support, promised before I decided, not after. Unconditional, and completely separate from approval. He wasn't telling me he'd agree with me. He was telling me I wouldn't stand out there alone no matter how bad I chose.

"This is yours. You the one gonna have to live with it. Not me." Ownership, placed with a surveyor's precision. Not a threat. A fact.

And then the fifth move, the one that wasn't words: the silence. He never brought that day up again. Never used it against me in an argument, never dangled it, never made me re-pay it at Thanksgiving. He didn't keep billing me, and because he didn't, I heard the invoice myself, every day, in my own handwriting. I promise you no whooping ever taught anybody what that silence taught me.

That was his whole philosophy anyway. Twice in my childhood, this same man answered the biggest doors that ever got knocked on for me by turning to his son and asking one question, do you want to, and then living with my answer. Radical autonomy plus unconditional support plus

zero rescue from consequences. Most of us, when somebody we love owes a bill, do one of two other things. We pay it for them, we rescue, we cover, we call the coach and smooth it over, and they learn that debt is free. Or we go the other way and become the repo man, bringing it up forever, charging them for the same offense at every family dinner, and they learn that payment never clears, so why pay. My father did neither. He held the door open to the truth, guaranteed me his backing, handed me the pen, and then honored my signature even though it was on a lie.

Now run your version. Your teenager wrecks the car doing something she already knew not to do. Your guy at work blows an account and you can see the cover story forming behind his eyes. The porch translates straight across. You don't interrogate, because the details aren't the point and you don't want custody of them. You give your advice once, tell the truth, and you let it stand. You promise your backing before they decide, out loud, so they know honesty won't cost them you. You hand over the decision in words they can't misread: this is yours, you're the one who has to live with it. And then, and this is the part that will test you, you honor whatever they choose, and you never dangle it over them afterward. Some of them will lie anyway. I did. Let them live with it the way my father let me live with it, because a consequence carried in full and in silence teaches what no lecture ever taught anybody.

Support without rescue. Accountability without a leash. If you get nothing else from this chapter as a parent or a leader,

take that.

* * *

The town, now. The town chose the repo-man route, and that taught me the second half of the principle.

Graduation day, they called my name and handed me a folder like everybody else. Later on I opened mine and it was empty. The school had held my actual diploma because they were afraid I'd act up at the ceremony. I had served the probation. I had eaten the ban. I sat out the season that was supposed to carry me out of Arkansas, watched the letters stop, paid every dime of principal a 17-year-old could be charged. And they kept the paper anyway, waiting for me to prove them right one more time. I never went back for it. "To this day, I have never held my high school diploma."

Here's what that folder taught me. Paying the bill once has a second half that nobody preaches: once it's paid, it's paid. Some people, and some institutions, will try to set up recurring charges on a debt you already settled. They liked having you in the debtor's chair. It made their math easy. You'll meet these people your whole life, the ones who bring up who you were as a way to bill who you are. You do not owe that invoice. There's a difference between the bill you owe, which you should pay fast and in full, and the payment plan somebody else keeps trying to sign you up for, which you should decline without raising your voice. I paid Clarksville what I owed Clarksville. The empty folder was

them trying to keep the meter running, and leaving that diploma in their drawer for 20-plus years is me declining the charge.

You've got an empty folder somewhere too. Maybe it's a family that still introduces you by your worst year. A boss who reaches for your one big mistake every time you reach for something better. An old crowd that gets uncomfortable when you act like the debt is settled, because your payment plan was working fine for them. Hear me on this: you check the ledger, not them. If there's real principal outstanding, pay it, this week if you can. But if you've served the sentence, made the amends, done the years, and somebody keeps presenting the same invoice, that's no longer accountability. That's rent, and you can stop paying rent on a debt you hold the receipt for. You don't have to fight anybody about it either. I didn't burn the school down. I let the drawer keep the paper, and I went and lived. Quietly declining a false invoice is one of the most grown things you will ever learn to do.

Pay yours once. Refuse to pay it twice. Both halves matter.

* * *

Fast forward a couple of decades, because I want you to see what this looks like in a grown man's inbox, when the porch shows up wearing business casual.

Not long ago I was deep in with a company called Togo. I'd built them something big on spec, a whole platform, and that story belongs to Chapter 7, so I'll leave it there. What

matters here is that a real seat at their table was in play, a life-changing one, and the term sheet never came. I found out I'd been passed over from a LinkedIn post. Nobody called me. I learned that the seat went to somebody else the same way strangers learned it, thumb on the screen, scrolling.

Young York would have turned that moment into a fire. You've read enough of this book to know my history with anger, and if you haven't yet, it's coming. But a LinkedIn post like that is a porch. The officer is walking back up the steps. You're about to make a decision, and you're the one who's gonna have to live with it.

Same day, I wrote Mike and Ed. I thanked them, and I meant it. And then I paid a bill in that email that I'd been dodging for years, one of those truths you owe on your own behalf. See, on paper, my resume looks like a man who can't sit still. Jobs stacked on jobs, short stints, gaps. For years I let that paper speak for me, and the paper was lying by omission, and I let it lie because the truth embarrassed me. So I put the truth in the email, plain, no violin: what looks like job-hopping was me working two and three jobs at a time to keep my family afloat. That's the whole explanation. That's who they'd been evaluating.

No groveling in that email either. I didn't ask them to reconsider. I didn't beg for the seat or take shots at whoever got it. I paid what I owed, truth and thanks, and closed the account.

Ed replied five days later. The door stayed open. Fractional work, on the table. And when the demo platform I'd built

them sunset a little while after that, my reply to the notice carried its own headline: I had enrolled for my Computer Science degree. The bill was paid, and I was already building.

Run the math on that one with me. The gracious email cost me one afternoon and a little pride, paid once. The grudge was quoting me a monthly rate for the rest of my career, because bitterness bills forever and burned bridges don't refund. One payment, account closed, door open. That's the whole principle wearing a collared shirt.

And understand what the payment actually bought, because it wasn't the seat. I didn't get the seat. Paying the bill doesn't rewind the decision. What it bought was the door. Truth keeps doors on their hinges. A lie, a flame-out, a silence held too long, those close doors so quietly you don't hear the click until the day you need the room. Five days after I paid, a door I had every excuse to slam was standing open with real work behind it. That's not magic. That's maintenance.

It works on money losses too. I lost \$25,000 promoting a concert in Omaha one time, and you'll get the full autopsy in Chapter 8. But notice what I just did. I told you the number. I put the figure in a book with my name on the cover. Owning a loss out loud, number attached, is a one-time payment, and it buys the lesson free and clear. Hiding a loss, dressing it up, rounding it down when the fellas ask, that's financing, and you'll make payments on it at every dinner table for the rest of your life. There's a business version of this that pays in reputation, too. I'd rather deal with a man who tells me he lost big and shows me the invoice than a man whose every

story ends in a win. The first man has receipts. The second man is selling something. When you own your losses with the numbers attached, people learn they can trust your wins. When I wrote my memoir I gave myself one rule for the hard parts, and I'll give it to you for yours: "Where two memories disagreed, I trusted the one that hurt more." That's what a payment looks like on paper.

Now the mechanics of paying. Four rules.

First, pay fast. The porch is smallest the first time it appears. Every day a truth sits unpaid, the conversation gets heavier, the story grows parts, the interest runs. And don't wait on the perfect wording, because people stall for weeks drafting the ideal version of a conversation that doesn't have an ideal version. You're not writing a speech. You're paying a bill. Nobody ever stood at the register polishing the twenty. Speed is mercy, mostly for you.

Second, pay specific. Name the thing in plain words. "I lied to you about the money." "I took the credit and it was yours." Vague apologies are minimum payments, they keep the account open and the interest running. "Mistakes were made" never paid a bill in the history of bills.

Third, pay without an invoice. Don't staple a demand for forgiveness to your apology. The other person's grace is theirs to give on their own schedule, and an apology that requires absolution isn't a payment, it's you billing them for your debt.

Fourth, pay once, then stop. This is where good-hearted people mess it up. They confuse groveling with sincerity. Groveling is not extra credit. Groveling is asking somebody

else to carry your shame so you don't have to, which turns your payment into their chore. Say it clean, make the correction, change the behavior, close the account. Re-apologizing every week isn't payment number two, it's a new withdrawal from their patience.

And let me be straight with you about cost, because this book doesn't do fairy dust. Sometimes the truth is expensive. Sometimes the truth is a suspension, a firing, a marriage counselor's office, a felony charge. I will not stand here and tell you the truth is cheap. What I'll tell you is that the truth is finite. Would honesty on that porch have kept the felony off my record? Probably not. The man had the whole night in his notebook before I opened my mouth. The truth is not a discount on consequences. It's a cap on them. The consequence has a bottom. The lie is a meter with no off switch. Pay the principal. Skip the financing.

Run It

Paper and pen, tonight, before you talk yourself out of it. This one only works in your own handwriting.

1. **Name the bill.** Write one sentence: the truth you haven't owned. What you did, or what you've been letting somebody believe. Plain words, no lawyering. Date it. If more than one comes to mind, pick the one that's been billing you the longest. You already know which one it is. It's the one you didn't want to write down.

2. **Run the interest math.** Two columns on one page. Left side: what paying once would cost. The hard conversation, a consequence you'd have to eat, some pride. List it for real. Right side: what the lie is charging you monthly. The topics you steer around, the people you keep at arm's length, the story you maintain, the 2 a.m. accounting sessions. List those for real too. Now look at the page. It's usually not close.
3. **Schedule the payment.** The call, the correction, the admission, whichever form your bill takes. Put it inside the next seven days, and write down who, when, and where. A payment without a date on it is a dodge with paperwork.
4. **Pay it clean.** The thing itself goes in your first two sentences. No "but." No context sandwich. Say what you did, what it cost them, and what changes now. Then stop talking. Don't ask them to make you feel better, that's a second bill, and it's addressed to the wrong person.
5. **Close the account.** Afterward, write one line under your entry: "Paid," and the date. If the other person tries to set up recurring charges, decline politely, once; their ledger is theirs to keep. And if the person still charging you is you, reread the line you wrote. It says paid.

One more thing about this exercise: it's measurable, which means you can't fog it. Either there's a dated sentence on paper by tomorrow morning or there isn't. Either the payment

has a day and a time attached or it doesn't. You can't halfway pay a bill, and by Friday you'll know exactly which one you did.

Don't wait to feel ready. Step one is a single sentence, and the porch is smallest the first time it appears. Write the sentence tonight.

The Crate

My daddy built a hoop out of a milk crate and a decision out of two folding chairs, and it was the same move both times. Here's the thing. It's yours. He'd nail it up and step back, and whatever I did with it was mine to live with. A crate doesn't lie to you. The ball goes in or it doesn't, and no story you tell the plywood changes the count. That's what he handed me on that porch, one more rim that keeps honest score. I shot it wrong that day, and the miss followed me for years, which is how I learned the rule you're holding now. Life keeps nailing up porches. When yours appears, walk up, say the true thing, and pay the man once. Then go get your ball back.

Chapter 5: Get Up Faster

The tire swing in our backyard faced away from the house, and on the afternoon of May 6, 1992, that was the most important fact in my five-year-old world.

My little brother Calvin had gotten his hands on a Zippo lighter. He wanted to show me how it worked, and the place he picked for the demonstration was a closet. I could walk you through the physics, but you already know the physics. A closet is clothes. Clothes are kindling. A Zippo does one job, and it does that job very well.

By the time the two of us relocated to the tire swing, smoke was coming off the back of the house. We sat down facing the other direction, opened a box of raisins, and committed fully to the only strategy two little boys had in stock, which was pretending.

“Is that smoke?”

“What smoke? I don’t smell smoke. Want a raisin?”

That conversation happened, more or less in those words, while our house burned down behind us. Two boys with their backs to a fire, passing a box of raisins, betting everything on

the theory that a thing you refuse to look at is a thing that is not happening.

The theory failed. The house went to the ground. Everything my family owned became a pile of ash while we finished the box.

Hold on to that date, by the way. May 6. My family's calendar has a strange relationship with May 6, and this book will keep that appointment when we get to it.

Now the part I actually brought you here for, which is the part that didn't happen.

Think about what my father was looking at. A man who had hustled and scratched for every single thing he had, and every single thing he had was now smoke over Clarksville, Arkansas, because of a cigarette lighter and a closet. If he had whooped us into the next county, no jury of parents anywhere in the South would have convicted him. I braced for it.

It never came. Not that night. Not the next morning. Not once in the rest of his life did that man punish us for the fire, or even hold it over our heads.

Years later I finally wrote down why: there's no whooping big enough for a pile of ash, and he had bigger math in front of him. So he skipped the anger and went straight to work.

Read that again, slow, because the whole lesson lives inside that sentence. He skipped the anger. Didn't swallow it. Didn't postpone it so it could leak out sideways over the next decade. Skipped it, the way you skip a stair that doesn't lead anywhere. My daddy was a human calculator, and he ran the numbers on rage in about half a second. Yelling rebuilds zero

houses. Whooping two boys puts zero roofs over anybody. Anger, standing in front of a total loss, is work with no product. He declined to do it.

Then he went to work on the math that was actually in front of him. A roof. Clothes. Food. School for boys who'd burned up their own school clothes. The Red Cross showed up. Neighbors showed up. Family showed up, because my family had a law for exactly this moment: "When a family loses everything, you help. That's the code."

Somewhere in the middle of that rebuild, a set of twins from my class gave me a \$5 shirt with plastic spiders all over it, and I'm going to tell you now that it was one of the best gifts I've ever received in my life. I wore that shirt every day. When my mama finally said enough was enough, I smuggled it to school and kept wearing it. Thirty years later, me and those twins still laugh about that shirt. I bring it up so you understand what the get-up looked like from the inside. A little boy in a spider shirt. A father working the problem. A town handing over what it could. We had lost everything, and I remember that season with a smile on my face, and both of those facts are true at the same time.

A long time after the fire, my daddy handed me the law that had been sitting underneath that whole spring. "Junior, the people who win aren't the ones who never get knocked down. They're the ones who get knocked down and get up faster than everyone else."

At the time I thought he was talking about basketball.
He wasn't.

* * *

The Principle: The people who win aren't the ones who never get knocked down. They're the ones who get knocked down and get up faster than everyone else.

* * *

Somebody sold you a story about winners. In the story, the winner is the one who never falls. The business that never craters, the athlete who never lands wrong. That story is a highlight reel with the floor edited out, and if you believe it, every knockdown in your life arrives carrying a second, heavier message: this must mean I'm not one of the winners.

Wipe that off the board. Everybody hits the floor. The knockdown is a guarantee written into the terms of being alive, which means the knockdown itself carries no information about you. None. The only number that says anything about you is the one nobody keeps track of: how long you stayed down.

Response speed is the only part of disaster you control. Sit with how true that is for a minute. You don't control the layoff; a spreadsheet in another state controls that. You don't control the diagnosis, the market, the storm, the judge, or the other driver. You don't control a little boy with a lighter and a closet full of clothes. Most of the disasters in your future have already been assigned to you by machinery you will never see, and your worrying doesn't get a vote in any of it. What

hasn't been assigned yet is your elapsed time. Floor to feet. That column is still blank, and you're holding the only pen.

In boxing they at least do a man the courtesy of counting out loud. You go down, and somebody stands over you hollering numbers so the whole building knows exactly how much time you've got. Life doesn't holler. Understand me clearly, though: the count runs anyway. The rent counts. The bank counts. Your competition counts. And the people watching your disaster count fastest of all, because an audience loves nothing more than finishing somebody's story for them. Stay down long enough and the neighborhood will write your ending for you. Part of getting up fast is getting up before the eulogy gets popular.

Flip that scoreboard around and you'll see the other half of it: a fall answered fast gets forgotten, and the same fall, sat in, becomes your first name. You've watched this run in your own town. Two men lose the same job at the same plant in the same week. One of them is working something new by summer, and the layoff shrinks down to a line in his story. The other one is still explaining the layoff five years later, at which point the layoff is the story. Same fall. Same plant. The clock wrote two different men.

Now, a word about the anger, because I need to head off a misreading before it costs you. Two chapters back I taught you to take an insult and burn it as fuel, and I stand on every word of that. But you have to know your materials. An insult is flammable. A pile of ash is not. When somebody tells you what you can't do, that's free energy, and you should run

your engine on it for a decade. When the loss is total, when the house is already gone, there's nothing left in it that burns. Rage pointed at a done deal returns nothing on the hours you feed it. My father saw that instantly on May 6, 1992. Screaming at ash is a job that pays in ash. He turned the position down, and that refusal is the reason my memory of losing everything is a spider shirt instead of a beating.

Let me be just as clear about the other ditch, because "get up faster" has been taught wrong for generations by men who actually mean "never feel anything," and those men are out here raising sons. Speed is not numbness. The tire swing taught me the difference. Me and Calvin with our backs to the fire, running our raisin routine, that was a kind of speed, wasn't it? We moved on from that fire before it even finished burning. Except we didn't move on. We just refused to look. Denial is facing away. Getting up is facing the thing, counting the damage, and moving anyway. Both of those are responses to a burning house. Only one of them has ever rebuilt one.

So here is the frame I actually live by. Grief gets a night. The plan gets the morning.

The night is real, and you take all of it. The night is for feeling the loss at full strength, with the door shut, away from anybody you'd perform for. Cry in the truck. Say out loud, to yourself, "this one hurt," because it did, and lying about that to your own chest just moves the bill to a worse address. What the night is not for is decisions. A man at the bottom of his worst feeling is in no condition to steer, and every big

choice made from that spot has a signature on it that morning-you won't recognize.

Morning belongs to paper. I mean that literally, pen and paper, because grief lives in your head and plans live on pages, and the fastest way to tell which one you're doing is to look at your hands. The first document is a damage inventory: what is actually gone, versus what feels gone. Those two lists are never the same length. The feeling always says "everything." The pen says: this, and this, and here is what's still standing. Until you've made that list, you're fighting fog, and fog doesn't lose.

I run the whole thing as a 48-hour window, and I teach it that way. First 24 hours: feel it, fully and honestly. Second 24 hours: sit down with the pen and build the plan. Hour 49: execute the first move, whether or not you feel ready, because ready isn't coming and was never scheduled. Two days. That number isn't me being cute. It comes from knowing what happens on day three. On day three, the loss starts introducing itself as you. "I lost the job" starts easing toward "I'm the guy who lost the job," and every day after that, the concrete gets harder. Losses are wet cement. Move early and you can still write in them. Wait, and they set, and now you're living next to a monument.

Now let me scale that window honestly, because I can hear somebody in the back holding up the biggest loss a human being can take, and they're right to hold it up. No, a death in your family does not get 48 hours, and I would never sit across this table and pretend mine did. Near the end of this

book I'll show you my biggest loss and what it made of me, and it did not run on a two-day clock. The window flexes with the size of what's gone. A lost client might not need the whole night. A lost marriage needs more than a weekend. What never changes is the shape: the feeling gets a container with a door on it, and the plan gets a start date. So I'm not grading you on hours. I'm asking you two questions about whatever has you on the floor right now. Does your grieving have an edge anywhere, or does it run clean to the horizon? And does your plan have a start date, or does it start "when I'm ready"? Because "when I'm ready" is not a date. It's a door painted on a wall.

Since I'm asking you to move faster than feels natural, I owe you the honest reasons, so here's what the floor charges by the day. The money keeps leaving, because disasters don't pause your bills out of sympathy. The muscle rusts, because skills you aren't using walk off the job quietly and take your confidence with them. The story sets, like I just told you. And then there's the quiet killer: the help expires. People show up hard for a fresh disaster. Casseroles, phone calls, "anything you need, anything at all." That help has a shelf life, and it's shorter than you think. Get up while the hands are still extended and they'll carry you a mile. Wait too long and the same people who would've emptied their pockets start crossing the street, because old wreckage makes folks uncomfortable. The Red Cross shows up the week of the fire. Nobody's dropping off clothes for a fire from three winters back.

I got my own pile of ash at 17.

You watched me earn it in the last chapter, so I won't run it back: a truck, a lie, a felony. The state athletic association banned me from playing ball anywhere in Arkansas for my senior season, while I was the top-ranked player in the state, and the recruiting letters quit coming for good. Basketball had been my identity and my entire exit plan since the crate went up on the wall, and one ruling turned all of it to smoke. Different fire. Same total.

Here's what the get-up looked like, and I need you to notice how little it resembles a montage. It looked like a chicken plant.

School from 8 to 2. The Tyson line from 5 in the evening until 2 in the morning. Four hours of sleep, then do it again. I stood on that line next to the parents of kids I went to school with, and the line taught me something no gym ever could. In a gym, you're special. On the Tyson line, you're nobody. You're a pair of hands in rubber gloves. The line does not care what your jumper looks like. The line cares whether your hands keep moving.

I made that line a promise, standing right there in the middle of a shift: *This is not my future.*

Watch the difference between saying that sentence and living it, though, because plenty of people say it every night for 30 years. My checks were \$530. I banked \$500 a week and lived off \$30 worth of groceries. On weekends I installed car

stereos for \$100 to \$200 cash. Every dollar was pointed at the car that was going to carry me out of that town and back toward a college court somewhere, anywhere, that would still take me. That's what getting up usually looks like. It doesn't look like a comeback. It looks like a bridge with a toll on it, crossed in rubber gloves, on four hours of sleep, with a number written on the far end.

Understand something about the floor while we're standing on it, because this is the exact spot where pride kills grown folks. When you get knocked down from up high, every available next move sits beneath the life you just lost. All of them do. That isn't a flaw in your options. That's the geometry of falling. The Tyson line was beneath the number one player in the state. It was not beneath a broke 17-year-old with a felony record, because nothing that pays honest money is beneath a man who's on the floor. I've watched people stay down for years, and I mean years, because the ladder in front of them started on a rung they felt they'd outgrown. Hear me on this: the ladder always starts below you. That's what makes it a ladder.

The promise part matters as much as the speed part, though. A bridge job with nothing written on the far end quietly becomes a destination, and there were people on that line who'd walked onto it 20 years earlier carrying my same sentence. The \$500 a week was the difference. I wasn't working the line. I was funding the exit. Same gloves. Different man inside them.

One more thing about that line, and I say it with my whole chest: the people who stay on it are not a cautionary tale. Some of the folks standing beside me had been running those hands for decades to feed their children, children I sat next to in class, and there is nothing but honor in that. So don't walk away from these pages thinking a chicken line is a knockdown. Work is never the knockdown. The knockdown is when a bridge turns into a floor without you ever choosing it, when a thing you took "for now" hardens into "forever" while you weren't looking. The line was somebody else's calling and my bridge, and both of those were true on the same shift. Your job in a disaster is to know which one you're standing on. If it's a bridge, keep a number written on the far end and your eyes on the number.

That exit eventually took the shape of an Impala and a junior college roster spot. And at that junior college, the floor found me again, because the floor is a repeat customer. My Pell Grant ran late one semester, through no fault of mine, and the bank took the car. Towed. Gone. The car I had bled a chicken line for. How I came to have that loan in the first place is a story that belongs to the next chapter, because it's really a story about who your people are. What matters here is what happened next.

My teammates got it back.

Junior college kids. Kids living on grant money and cafeteria trays, kids with nothing to spare, pooled \$1,800 of their own money and got my car back. I did not have \$1,800. My family did not have \$1,800. Left alone with that

knockdown, I don't know how long I'd have stayed on the floor. The difference between a knockdown and a knockout was other people. That's the whole sentence. Put it somewhere you can see it.

Because here's the piece of get-up-faster that the lone-wolf preachers always leave out: your recovery speed was never a solo stat. Go back to the fire. My daddy skipped the anger and went straight to work, yes, and the Red Cross showed up, and the neighbors showed up, and the family showed up with the code. Go to the repossession: my get-up that week moved exactly as fast as a locker room full of broke kids decided it would. Every fast recovery I've ever made or witnessed had other hands in it somewhere. Every slow one I've watched up close had a man in it trying to be his own ambulance.

So build the lifeline list before you need it. Five names. Sit down while your sky is still clear and write down five people or assets you could reach on the worst night of your life, and next to each one, what they're actually good for. Money is only one category, and honestly it's the rare one. Somebody on that list has a couch. Somebody has a truck. Somebody tells you the truth when you'd rather be lied to, which in a disaster is worth more than a check. Somebody knows a door. A lifeline isn't a rich contact. A lifeline is anybody whose phone you could ring at 2 in the morning without rehearsing an apology first.

Two rules about the list. First rule: you can't recruit for it from the floor. A call made from the floor arrives carrying need, and everybody can smell need through the phone.

Lifelines get built in peacetime, through deposits, through showing up at other people's fires the way my neighbors showed up at ours. Which is the second rule: the fastest way onto somebody's list is to already be on theirs. Be somebody's Red Cross this year. Full accounting of who belongs on that list, and who's only auditioning for it, is coming in the next chapter. For now, write the five names.

Put at least one asset on there too, something that isn't a person. A paid-off vehicle. A skill that turns into cash on short notice. A certification, a tool, a little account you never touch. On the Tyson line, my asset was a weekend hustle installing stereos; it wasn't much, and it moved the plan forward every single week. People are the best lifelines, but people have their own fires, and a list with an asset on it never has all its eggs in somebody else's basket.

* * *

Now let me show you the law running in my life recently, because I refuse to teach you anything I've stopped using.

Not long ago, I lost a seat I had bled for. There's a company I built an entire software platform for, unpaid, on spec, and that build gets its own chapter later in this book. The short version is that a real seat at their table was in play, a life-changing one, and it went to another man, and I found out from a LinkedIn post. Last chapter I told you what I wrote back to them and why. What I care about here is a different measurement. The clock.

That night was a genuine knockdown. I had rebuilt my whole working life around code, at an age when most men have stopped rebuilding anything, and the room I'd shipped actual product to had picked somebody else. Cassidy, my wife, looked at me that same night and said, "This wasn't meant to be, and an opportunity will come."

Plenty of spouses would have stopped at those words, and the words alone would have been a gift. She didn't stop there, and neither did I. We started a studio together, hers and mine, and we called it Caipher Studio. The first paying client came in days, not months. A discount mattress store needed its website rebuilt, so we rebuilt it, and the check cleared, and before long customers were walking into that store telling the owner they'd found her online.

A mattress store. After the table I'd been looking at, that might sound like a step down to you. Go back and read the Tyson pages again. The ladder starts below you. Every time. It started below my father in 1992 and below me at 17 and below us that night in California. We took the rung.

Run the tape of my whole life and you'll see the same law over and over. House to ash, and a man goes straight to work. Career to smoke at 17, and the gloves go on. Car towed off a college campus, and a locker room reaches into its own pockets. Seat gone by LinkedIn post at night, and a studio is open for business inside the week. I've already written the pattern down once, describing my own years: build something, lose it, build something better. Every destruction felt like the end. Every reconstruction proved it wasn't.

I'll keep it honest with you, though, the way I promised to. Some of my get-ups took a lot longer than one paragraph makes them sound, and the slow ones cost me more than anything else in my life. Speed came with repetition, same as everything else. Nobody's first get-up is fast. The first time the floor takes you, you'll lie there longer than you'll ever admit, and that's fine, because the get-up is a rep skill, and reps are exactly what your knockdowns are for. Every rebuild teaches your hands where the tools hang. By the fortieth time, you're moving before the dust settles, and people who only just met you will call it a gift. It's not a gift. It's scar tissue that learned to hustle.

The mechanism under the speed deserves one more minute, because it isn't magic and I don't sell magic. A get-up is a sequence, and sequences get faster with familiarity. First time through, you're inventing every step in the dark. What do I feel, who do I call, what do I do first, and in what order, all of it improvised at the worst possible hour. By the fortieth time, your body knows the order without being told. Feel it with the door shut. Inventory on paper. First call. First move. And the fear shrinks right along with the time, though not because the losses get smaller. Mine got bigger every decade. The fear shrinks because the unknown is the expensive part of any disaster, and once you've walked the sequence enough times, a knockdown stops being a mystery and becomes a procedure. Somewhere in those reps you'll find your own version of what I finally found in mine: I kept building because the alternative was to stop, and stopping meant

becoming what Clarksville expected me to become. Your sentence has a different town in it. Find your sentence, because it's load-bearing.

That's also the real reason I'm about to make you write your moves down before anything is wrong. Every building you've ever worked in has a fire escape map bolted to the wall by the door, and there's a reason it was drawn ahead of time: nobody draws one during a fire. The people who get out of a burning building fast are almost never the fastest people in it. They're the ones following lines that somebody traced on a calm afternoon. Your life doesn't have a map like that bolted anywhere. You're about to fix that.

My daddy is gone now. He never got to see most of my scoreboard. But when I total up my life for him, the number I'd hand him isn't a dollar figure or a headline, because he told me himself what the winning stat was, back when I still thought he was talking about basketball. The people who win aren't the ones who never get knocked down. By that measure, I know exactly what I'd say to him, and I've already written it once: "Daddy, I got up. Every single time. I got up."

That stat is available to you starting today. Not the never-falling. Nobody's offering that one. The getting up, faster every time, that one's on the table, and nobody can price you out of it.

Run It

This drill gets run before the disaster, while your sky is still clear. That's the entire trick of it. Most people plan their comeback from the floor, with a rattled head and the count already running. You're going to be the rare one who planned it standing up. Pen and paper, this week, everything dated.

1. **Name the loss you fear most.** One sentence at the top of a page, with today's date. The job disappearing. The business folding. The relationship ending. The body breaking down. Pick the one that actually keeps you up, not the one that's easy to write. Naming it doesn't summon it; storms don't read. What naming does is drag the fear out of the dark, where it's been steering your decisions without signing its work.
2. **Pre-write your first three moves.** Under that sentence, write the first three moves you'd make if it happened tomorrow. They have to be small enough to execute on the worst day of your life. The person you'd call first, by name, not "family." The money move, with a number on it. One physical action inside the first 48 hours: the application filed, the truck listed, the office packed. Test each move against this standard: could a version of you that slept three hours and cried in the car still do it? If a move needs you at your best, it isn't a first move. Rewrite it smaller.
3. **Build the lifeline list.** Five names, people or assets, each with a note on what it's actually good for: money, a couch,

a door, the truth. Then add one more column, and be honest in it: the last time you showed up for them. If that column embarrasses you, good. It's supposed to. It's telling you the list needs maintenance before it needs using.

4. **Make one deposit this week.** Call one name on that list needing absolutely nothing. Or better, show up at somebody's fire: the move, the hospital week, the bad stretch they're too proud to broadcast. Date it and check it off. A lifeline list you never feed is just five names of people who used to know you.
5. **Sign the timebox.** At the bottom of the page, write the contract and sign your name under it: "When it comes: 24 hours to feel it. 24 hours to plan it. Hour 49, I execute move one, ready or not." You're signing it now because floor-you will want to renegotiate, and floor-you is a terrible lawyer. Standing-you sets the terms. Floor-you just has to keep them.
6. **Put the page where disaster can find it.** In the drawer with the important papers, and a photo of it on your phone. Read it again whenever the weather turns in your industry, your family, your body. You're not being morbid. You're being the man with the plan already written, and on the day the count starts, that man gets up first.

The whole drill costs you one evening and a sheet of paper. The disaster it's written for will not extend you the same

courtesy. Run it this week, dated, while your sky is clear. A man who won't spend an evening preparing for his most feared loss is a man planning to meet it on the floor.

The Crate

My daddy's hoop was a thing that kept breaking. Plastic was never made for that much wanting, and every couple of weeks the crate gave out and the shooting stopped. And every time, without one word about it, a new crate went up, and the ball was back in my hands before the streetlights finished coming on. I thought I was out there learning to shoot. Underneath the shooting, I was learning the older rhythm: things break, somebody drives nails, the game goes on. My father drove those nails for me until he couldn't anymore. Somewhere ahead of you is a break where nobody comes around the corner of the house with a hammer, and that day isn't abandonment. That day is the handoff. You've watched the nails go in enough times now to know how it's done. So when your crate cracks, and it will crack, give the loss its one night. Then go get the hammer. The wall is waiting. The game goes on.

Chapter 6: Count Your Friends Twice

The worst call I ever had to make was to a man who had trusted me with \$37,000, to tell him the money was gone. I sat with the phone in my hand a long time before I dialed. There's no good order for words like that, so I gave it to him the way I'd want it given to me. Straight. Number first, no decoration on it.

I'll call him Aamir. He came in as an investor back when I was raising money for my cannabis company, and I need you to understand what his check meant, because money doesn't all weigh the same. Some men invest the way you tip a valet, off the top, no pain attached. Aamir wasn't that. His \$37,000 was belief in wire form, put on me at a stage when what I had to show was dirt, drawings, and my word that I could turn one into the other. Money like that doesn't just spend. It watches you.

Let me back up and tell you how it died.

Raising capital pulls strange people into your orbit. One of them was a mentor out of Silicon Valley I'll call Trent, the most connected man I've ever personally known, and Chapter 9 tells his whole story. All this page needs from Trent is one

audit line: for all those connections, the man never closed a single deal. Not one, not ever, not for me.

Through that world came another man, and him I won't name at all. Not to protect him. Some people don't earn the ink. What you need to know is that he was smooth. Professionally smooth. The kind where every answer arrives before you finish your question, where every deal feels closed before anything is signed, where you hang up the phone somehow feeling better about your own future. By that season of my life I'd been burned enough times to have a real vetting process. Ask around. Check paper. Watch what a man does with small things before he gets near a big one. Here's the detail that still sits in my chest: I was running that process on him when the money moved. The process had started. It hadn't finished.

Aamir's \$37,000 went by wire into that man's account.

Not into mine. Not into the company's. Into his. And once it landed there, it was gone. I chased it the way you chase anything with your name attached, with calls and pressure and hours I couldn't spare while I was building a farm out of red Oklahoma dirt. Out of \$37,000, I recovered \$7,500. That was the entire rescue. Read those two numbers slow and feel the distance between them. I paid full price for that distance. You're getting it free.

Now the part I opened the chapter for. Every dollar of that \$7,500 went straight to Aamir. No detour through my bills, no holdback against expenses. It landed and it left. Then I called him and gave him 2 percent of my company on top of it. From

then on, we were both going to win or both going to lose. His money had come chasing my word, and the loss happened inside my deal, on a road I built. I couldn't hand back what I didn't have, so I chained my future to his, in writing, so the trust between us had something structural to stand on. Not a feeling. A percentage.

People have asked why I ate that loss when I wasn't the man who kept the money. Because my word is the one asset that has worked in every room I've ever stood in, and I wasn't about to sell it for \$37,000. A man whose word comes with fine print is broke in a way no raise can fix. Backing mine cost 2 percent of a company. I got off cheap.

But underneath the money, that episode handed me something older. The smooth talker didn't beat my instincts. He beat my clock. My gut already had him in the waiting room; the wire just moved before the verdict came in. And that night, running back every time somebody close to me had cost me something, I noticed a thing that embarrassed me worse than the loss. The list was long. The faces on it were all familiar. And I had never once written any of it down. My whole life, I'd been counting my friends in my head, after the damage, one column at a time.

My daddy had handed me the sentence for this when I was a boy. I'd been nodding at it and paying tuition on it ever since.

* * *

The Principle: All your friends aren't your friends.

* * *

You nodded again just now. Everybody nods at that line. It gets said on every porch, every block, and in every barbershop chair in America, and it changes almost nobody's behavior. I'll tell you why. Everybody applies it to somebody else's friends. Your circle is the exception. Your people are solid. You can vouch for your guys. Meanwhile, somebody in your phone right now is a withdrawal wearing a deposit's face, and you can't see it because you're reading people with the wrong instrument.

Feelings are the wrong instrument. Trust isn't a feeling. Trust is a ledger.

A feeling will certify a man because he laughs right, remembers your kids' names, and never shows up to the cookout empty handed. Feelings are charm's home court, and charm is the exact weapon that got you last time. A ledger doesn't ask how somebody makes you feel. It asks what they've actually done, when they did it, and what it cost them to do it. Dates. Amounts. Receipts. Stephen Covey called this the Emotional Bank Account in *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People*, and he was right that every relationship runs a balance whether you ever read the statement or not. My addition to Covey is shorter and harder: read the statement. On paper. With the lights on.

Entries wear disguises, though, so learn to read them right. Some deposits don't feel like deposits going in. The friend who told you your plan had holes in it made a deposit. A warning is a deposit. Honest criticism is a deposit. The no that comes with a reason attached is worth more than most yeses. And some withdrawals dress real nice. Flattery is a withdrawal. So is the favor that gets brought back up at every gathering for the next decade, which was never a favor at all, just an invoice on a payment plan. Don't score an entry by how it felt going down. Score it by what it did to your life after it got inside.

Let me show you some of my withdrawal column, so you know I'm not preaching out of a clean book.

A man my father called a friend set him up on a federal case. You're not getting that name either. Here's what makes the entry teach: my daddy fed people. Everybody got a plate. Nobody left hungry. That was the standing law of his kitchen, and he housed whole families in years when we barely had room for our own. The setup still came from inside that circle, because it always does. A stranger can't set you up. A stranger doesn't know enough about you to sell you. It takes a friend to do that. Friend is a key, and a key is exactly what betrayal needs.

When I was a kid, a boy I called a friend shot me in the neck with a high-powered pellet rifle. I ran a mile and a half home holding my neck. Nobody ever answered for it. No apology, no consequence, nothing. That pellet is still in my

neck while I type this sentence, more than 25 years later. Some withdrawals live in an account. Some live in your body.

At 17, I caught a felony in a parking lot. You read about the porch and the folding chairs two chapters back, and I'm not walking that ground again. I'll add the one piece that belongs on this page instead: one of us talked. He cut his deal, kept himself clean, and got to keep playing ball that season, while me and my best friend caught felonies, five years of probation, and a ban from every court in the state. Same night. Same five minutes. His freedom got financed with pieces of mine.

Set those entries side by side and watch what they do. The pellet cost me a scar. The parking lot cost me a season, a record, and every recruiting letter that was ever going to come. The wire cost another man \$37,000 and cost me 2 percent of my company. The lesson never changed. The invoice grew. That's what happens when you won't run the count. Life teaches the same class over and over and keeps raising the price of the seat.

Now slow down with me on the why, because the why is the difference between protecting yourself and poisoning yourself.

The people who get you are almost never villains. I've met a few genuinely rotten men, and there's a strange mercy in them: the rotten ones rarely land clean, because rot has a smell. The ones who land clean are the ones with access, and access belongs to people you love. What flips them usually isn't evil. It's pressure. My daddy had a law for it, delivered

the way he delivered everything, once, plainly, like he was reading you the weather. A desperate man is a dangerous man. Back in Chapter 3 I told you I am most dangerous when I am desperate, and I meant that as an engine. My father meant the same physics as a warning. Desperation converts people. It takes a man who never stole and hands him a reason. It takes a friend who cheered every one of your wins and quietly rewrites your winning into a list of what he's owed. And it never stops to check whether the man loves you. Love doesn't disable desperation. Half the time, love is just what gives desperation your address.

Generosity won't immunize you either, and the generous ones reading this need to hear that most. You can feed a man, cover his shortfalls, answer every one of his 2 AM calls, and none of it buys protection on the day his pressure outgrows his gratitude. The deposits you made into him don't cancel the math running in his head. So stop trusting your track record with people and start watching the person in front of you, in this season, under this weight. Pressure announces itself if you pay attention. The asks get bigger and vaguer at the same time. The thank-yous get shorter while the expectations get longer. Somewhere in there, you got reclassified from friend to resource, and nobody sent you the memo. A man in that spiral isn't your enemy yet. He's not safe either. Both things are true at once, and your job is to hold both without hating him. Help a drowning man from the boat. Get in the water with him and he will stand on your shoulders to breathe, then cry at your funeral, and mean it.

Years before the wire, I paid \$30,000 to learn what vetting actually is. That story earned a chapter of its own later in this book, so here I'll only give you its shape: a room full of shine, a flight I had to catch, cash handed over to men I was still reading, and a thing I invested in that never existed. Not struggled. Not failed. Never existed. Everything about that room said wealth. It was a costume.

Between the costume and the smooth talker, I finally understood something about convincing people. The first thing you learn when you try to raise capital is that everybody's a liar. That's overstated by maybe 10 percent. Enough people are liars that you start to question everybody, and the ones who are the most convincing are usually the ones you need to run from the fastest, because convincing is a craft, and honest people rarely have time to practice it. Sincerity is cheap to fake and expensive to verify, and the fakers understand that price gap better than you ever will. So quit trying to out-read professionals. That's a game you lose. The move is to stop letting sincerity carry weight that structure should be carrying.

Which brings me to the biggest mistake burned people make. After a betrayal, the instinct is to start testing people. Loyalty checks. Little traps. Tell one friend one version and a second friend another version, then watch which one walks back through the door. Leave something out and see. I understand the instinct and I'm telling you flat: don't. A test measures charm, and charm is what already beat you. My smooth talker would've passed any test I designed, because

passing tests was his occupation. You know who fails loyalty tests? Honest people. The unperforming ones, who forget your birthday and tell you to your face what's wrong with your plan. Run your circle through a charm filter and you'll keep the actors and flush the real ones. That's not protection. That's doing your enemy's job for him.

Never make a person prove loyalty. Structure things so loyalty never gets tested.

Three rules came out of my two losses, and they've held every year since. First rule: control the money path. Money moves through accounts I can see, on rails I chose, or it doesn't move. Nobody who's still being vetted gets near a live dollar. I don't care whose guy he is or how good his stories are. The file closes before the wire opens. Second rule: everything meaningful goes on paper. Terms, dates, numbers, and what happens if it goes wrong, written down while everybody still likes each other, because that's the only moment it can be written fair. Paper isn't an insult to a friendship. Paper is a gift to it. Most blowups I've watched in other people's lives weren't crimes. They were two honest memories of one unwritten conversation, drifting apart until both sides felt robbed. Write it down and nobody ever has to find out whose memory is the creative one. When I gave Aamir his 2 percent, that went on paper too. Win together, lose together, in ink. Third rule: watch how people react to the paper, because the reaction is free information. Slide a simple agreement across the table. Your real ones shrug and sign. The performer gets wounded. He starts talking about trust, about

family, about how this isn't how brothers do business. Let him finish. He's showing you the exact move he was saving for later, and he's showing it for the price of a printed page.

Let time do the rest of your vetting. I don't close the file on anybody new until I've watched what they do with small money before big money enters the room, measured the distance between their Tuesday talk and their Friday behavior, and heard how they tell the story of their last partnership. That last one is criminally underrated. Ask a new person what happened with the people who came before you, then just listen. A smooth talker always drags a wreckage trail of former partners who supposedly did him wrong, and if you ask enough questions about the crashes, you'll eventually notice that every last one of them had the same driver.

One more piece of defense before I flip this chapter over. When the ledger shows you a name in the withdrawal column, that's not a call to war. You don't owe anybody a confrontation scene, a public reading, or a last word. Most people who cost you don't need to be thrown out of the building. They need to be moved to the lobby. Quiet demotion, no press release. The invitations slow down. The information dries up. The access shrinks until it matches the trust. Anger wants an event. Wisdom wants a distance. I've done it both ways, and the loud way always mailed me a bill afterward. And when the name in that column shares your last name, when it's family and the lobby isn't an option, you move the valuables instead of the person. Keep the dinner table. Move the business. You can love somebody with your

whole heart and still keep them away from your money, and if that sounds cold to you, it's a lot warmer than the courtroom where the other version ends up.

If I stopped here, though, I'd be lying to you with true facts, which is the most dangerous way to lie. Everything above happened. Everything above is also half the book.

* * *

Count your friends twice. The first count finds the ones who've been costing you. The second count finds the ones who've been carrying you, and the second count is the one that decides who you become.

When I finally put my whole ledger on paper instead of hauling it around in my chest, here's what I found. The withdrawal column, the one I could recite in my sleep, the one I'd been nursing like the pellet in my neck, was the short column. It wasn't close.

Read the other side with me.

Coach Freeman used to give me rides home when I was a kid, and I was so ashamed of where we lived that I had him drop me at a neighbor's house and let him believe it was mine. He knew the whole time. Never called me on it, never made my shame into a story he told, never let on at all. He waited for his moment, and then he gave it to me straight: "Don't be embarrassed about where you live. Work hard in sports and that'll be your ticket to living in a house you'd be proud to bring people to." Sit with the craft in that sentence.

He took the one thing I was hiding and handed it back to me as fuel. That's a deposit. I'm still drawing interest on it today.

Don Stimpson was the president of a bank. When I was a teenager with a record, working the chicken line and saving for the car that was supposed to carry me out of that life, my daddy made one phone call, because York Sr. knew everybody, and everybody owed him something. Don came out, inspected the Impala himself, and approved a loan no formula would've touched. Then he told me the truth about what he'd just done: "There are people within this bank that didn't want me to give you this loan, and they'll be looking for any reason to repossess it." Understand what that was. The loan was a deposit, and the warning was a second deposit stacked on top of it. A man who goes out on a limb for you and then tells you exactly how far the limb bends is on your side twice. That's a debt of honor, and debts of honor don't get paid back. They get paid forward.

The warning came true, too. My grant money ran late in junior college and the bank took the car, through exactly the kind of opening he'd told me they'd be watching for. My teammates got it back. JUCO kids with nothing to spare pooled \$1,800 of their own grant money for a car that wasn't theirs. I told you a piece of that story in the last chapter as a getting-up story, and it belongs on this page too. That was the first time I understood what a team really was. Not a group of guys who wore the same jersey. A family. Not one of those young men owed me a dime.

While you're reading that entry, learn how to size a deposit, because dollar amounts will fool you. The real size of a deposit is what share it was of everything the giver had. By that math, the \$1,800 those teammates pulled together is some of the biggest money anybody has ever put on me. Grown investors have wired me more with less love in it. A rich man's large check can be a small deposit. A broke man's twenty can be enormous. Cost to the giver. That's the number the ledger runs on, and it's the number that tells you who you're never allowed to forget.

A junior college coach handed me a scholarship when nobody else in the country would touch a kid with my record. He didn't even know what he had sitting at the end of his bench. Doesn't matter. The door only has to open once, and his was the one that did.

Andrew Silverman was my teammate in college. A party went bad one night, a fight got big, and I went for my gun. I'm not going to soften that sentence, because the deposit doesn't work unless it stays heavy. I went for my gun, and Andrew got there first and hid it, because he'd seen where the night was taking me and moved before I did. The next day I called my cousin: "Come get this thing before I get into trouble with it." Because I was going to use it. I saw it in myself. Almost only counts in horseshoes and hand grenades, and that night was an almost. Andrew is the reason. Some friends protect your money. A few protect you from your own hands, and the best ones never bring it up again.

The Thompsons took me into their home when I was a teenager so I could keep becoming somebody, and later, when I handed them a reason that was entirely my own fault, they put me out. Both entries are real, and both belong to the same people. They kicked me out of the house. They never kicked me out of the family. That's most of the honest entries in anybody's ledger, by the way. People aren't columns. People carry balances, the balance moves, and the ones worth keeping are the ones whose deposits run so deep that one hard withdrawal doesn't close the account.

And Aamir. Don't lose Aamir in all of this. His entry and the smooth talker's entry came out of the same wire. One man took \$37,000. The other one had put belief on a builder with dirt and drawings, and after everything went wrong, he stayed. One event, both columns, same day, same money. Betrayal and loyalty are usually standing in the same room. Counting is how you tell them apart.

So run my totals. Against a setup, a snitch, a pellet, a costume, and a smooth talker, I'm holding: a coach who covered my shame, a banker who bent a limb, a locker room that emptied its pockets, a teammate with faster hands than my worst impulse, a family that kept me after I gave them cause not to, and an investor who bet on my word twice. And that's the short list. I haven't counted the man who drove his carpet-cleaning van out to our house, scared to death of my daddy, to ask if he could pay my fee and drive me to games so a broke kid could play organized ball. I haven't counted the coaches who fed me or the households that made room. If I

gave you the full accounting, the deposit column would run off the bottom of the page.

For years, though, the only column I could recite was the withdrawals, and there's a reason for that. Betrayal is loud. It files charges, leaves marks, and tells its own story on a loop without your permission. Deposits are quiet. A ride. A warning. A door held open once that changed the address of your entire life. The loud column writes itself into your memory. The quiet column has to be counted on purpose, with a pen, and that's why this chapter's title is an instruction instead of a saying. Counting once is just remembering, and memory is rigged in favor of the wound. Counting twice is an audit.

Pride shortens the second count too, and I'll own my share of that. A man building his legend wants the story to be him against the world. Nobody helped. Look what I did all by myself. It makes a better movie. It's also a lie by omission. I needed a van, a loan, a locker room, a teammate's fast hands, and more mercy than I ever earned. Writing the second column doesn't shrink you. It sizes you honest. The self-made man is a bookkeeping fraud, and I say that as somebody who spent years trying to be one on paper.

The savior side of your ledger needs maintenance too. Deposits keep coming to the people who show what deposits built. When somebody bets on you, report back. Tell the man who made the call what the call turned into. Show the people who covered you what the covering became. Not to perform gratitude. To close the loop. Folks double down where they

can see the harvest, and the quiet ones who carried you almost never get shown one.

Bitterness is what happens when a man reads one column and calls it the whole book. It walks around calling itself wisdom, chest out, bragging that it can't be fooled again. Maybe not. It also can't be helped, funded, partnered with, or loved right, and it seals out exactly the wrong people. A sealed-off man doesn't keep out smooth talkers. Working sealed-off men is their specialty, because flattery slides under any door. What he keeps out is the next Freeman, the next Don, the next Andrew. You will not be saved by people you've decided don't exist. If a betrayal takes your money and then takes your ability to receive, it beat you twice, and the second beating is the one that lasts.

Run the count again every time your life changes altitude, too. When you're down, the counting mostly does itself. A hard season pours your circle through a sieve, and only the real ones come out the bottom. Winning is what scrambles the books. Start winning in public and watch your phone fill up with brand-new old friends, people who love you in exact proportion to whatever you just announced. Raising money taught me that arithmetic better than anything else ever has. The bigger the number attached to your name, the friendlier the strangers get, and the harder they work at feeling like family. So audit after every win, every raise, every headline. The friends you could afford when you had nothing are the ones you can trust when you finally have something.

Last thing, because somebody reading this is halfway to the wrong conclusion. Counting isn't coldness. I still feed people. My daddy's plate law outranks every rule in my kitchen, same as it did in his. A ledger doesn't make you stingy. It makes you accurate. I can be generous on purpose, with my eyes open, because I know what's in the accounts. The most generous people I've ever known were never the most trusting. They were the most clear.

Run It

You need a pen, one sheet of paper, and about an hour of honesty. Fold the sheet down the middle so you've got two columns. Step one happens tonight, while you've still got the nerve. This hour buys you the difference between seeing your life and just feeling it.

1. Write the two ledgers tonight. Twenty minutes

minimum. Left column, DEPOSITS: every person who put something real into you. Name, what they did, the year, and what it cost them to do it. Right column,

WITHDRAWALS: every person who cost you something real. Name, what they took, what it cost you. Receipts only. Real events, dates where you can remember them, no vibes. If a person belongs in both columns, write them in both columns. Most of the important people in your life will show up twice. That's not a flaw in the exercise. That is the exercise. Date the sheet when you're done.

2. **Answer the audit question in writing.** Which column could you already recite from memory before tonight? If it's the withdrawals, and for most burned people it is, write this sentence under your totals, in your own hand: "I have been counting once." Date that too. It's the before picture.
3. **Make one structural fix inside seven days.** Find the one place in your life where the most money or the most damage is riding on feeling instead of structure. The loan with no terms. The handshake partnership. The shared account with no agreement. The person still being vetted who's already near your money. Pick the riskiest one and put structure on it this week: a written agreement, a corrected money path, or a boundary said to the person's face. Write down which fix you chose and the date it'll be done by. If somebody gets offended by the paper, add it to their column. That's an entry, not a fight.
4. **Pay one deposit this week.** Pick one name from the left column. Call them or stand in front of them. No text, no DM. Name the specific thing they did, the year they did it, and what it cost them, then thank them plainly. If their deposit built something, tell them what it built. It takes two minutes and feels like jumping into cold water. Do it anyway. Gratitude said out loud is how the savior side of your ledger stays alive, and keeping it alive is how you stay somebody worth saving.

5. Write your standing money rules at the bottom, and sign them. Three questions, answered in your own words: where does money move, what goes on paper, what happens if it goes wrong. Sign it like the contract it is, and keep the sheet where you keep your money. Before anything meaningful moves again, in cash or in trust, read it. If the honest answer to any of those questions is “trust me,” the answer to the deal is no.

The Crate

The crate went up on a nail I didn't drive. That's the piece the boy never thought about. He counted his makes and his misses and never counted the man who checked the wall, saw the plastic starting to give, and hung a fresh crate without saying one word about it, every other week, for years. The biggest deposits in your life are being made the same way right now, quietly, by hands that don't announce themselves. Somebody is holding up a backboard you think is just nailed to the sky. Find out who. Thank them while they can hear it. Put paper around everybody else. All your friends aren't your friends, and knowing that will guard your pockets. But the crate teaches the older truth: some people keep hanging hope on your wall and never once send a bill. Count them twice. Then go be that hand on somebody else's wall.

Crate 2: The Dirt

Now there are two boys.

The second one is the brother, younger, built low and strong, and he does not like losing any better than the first one does. Where there was one pair of feet under the crate, there are four. Where there was one boy's breathing, there are two, and the sound of a body hitting a body, and the argument about the score, which never ends because there is nobody to end it.

Under the crate the grass dies first, where the misses land, a bald patch the size of a washtub. Then it dies where the boys plant their feet to shoot, and where they cut toward the wall, and where they scrap for the ball when it comes off crooked. By the middle of summer the whole back of the house is bare ground, packed hard as a barn floor and swept clean by shoes. One boy's shoes are more glue than shoe. The game does not stop for that.

Rain comes. They play in it. The ground turns to mud and the mud takes the print of every jump and every fall, and the ball comes up heavy, wearing a skin of grit. They wipe it on their shirts and shoot. Cold comes, and they can see their own

breath hanging between them and the crate, and they play. Dark comes, and they play into it until the ball is a sound instead of a thing.

There are no lines painted on this court. No free-throw stripe, no key, no scoreboard, no whistle. Nobody has ever measured the height of the crate, and nobody ever will.

The mouth of the crate forgives nothing, so their shots learn to be true. The dirt throws bad bounces, so their hands learn every crooked thing a ball can do. The wall sits close, so their touch learns to be soft. Everything wrong with this court is teaching them something, and the court is wrong everywhere.

Somewhere in town there are gyms. Glass backboards, painted lines, heat in the winter, a man with a whistle and a clipboard writing names on a sheet. The boys are not in them. No league would sanction what happens behind this house. No referee would set foot in that mud. If a man with a clipboard ever saw this court, he would shake his head and drive away, and he would be right about the court and wrong about everything else.

Out of that mud a game is coming that nobody can guard. A shot that needs no net to say it went in. A handle built on ground that never once gave an honest bounce. Legs that have jumped out of dirt for so long that hardwood, when it finally comes, will feel like a trampoline.

The rain keeps falling. The boys keep playing. The dirt keeps score.

PART III: THE BUILD

How you make something

Chapter 7: Build It Before They Believe You

Togo asked me to review their platform.

That was the whole assignment. They had software, the software had problems, and they wanted my eyes on it. Look it over, write up what was wrong, send the notes. The ask came with a lane already painted on the road: be the consultant, deliver the memo, then wait politely by the phone to see if the memo turned into anything.

Understand where I was standing when that ask landed. I was two years into teaching myself to code. No degree, no bootcamp, no badge from anybody's company. I had felonies on my record old enough to rent a car. I had been applying to the biggest names in tech and collecting rejections and silence, even with working proof of everything I claimed sitting live on the internet. The front door had made itself real clear. Togo was a side door, cracked open maybe an inch, and the polite move was to slide my memo through the crack and hope somebody read it.

I looked at their platform, and I thought about the memo I was supposed to write. The longer I sat with that assignment, the clearer I could see what a memo really is. A memo is talk.

Dressed-up talk, talk in a collared shirt, but talk all the same. Every memo ever written says the same thing underneath: here's what I would do if you ever let me. And I already knew what rooms do with what I would do. A cover letter is just a memo in church clothes, and I had a stack of unanswered cover letters to show how far those travel.

So I made a different call. Instead of telling Togo what was wrong with their platform, I built them a new one.

Not a sketch of one. Not a deck with arrows on it and a roadmap slide. A platform. Full stack, front to back, deployed, live on the internet where a stranger could touch it without me standing there narrating. Nobody asked me to do it. Nobody was paying me to do it. I did it because I had finally learned the law, and I'd learned it the long way, across basketball courts and boardrooms and a whole lot of rooms that smiled at me and picked somebody else.

When it was done, I sent them the link with a message about as long as a stop sign:

"Here's your new platform. Log in."

Look at what that message doesn't do. It doesn't request a meeting. It doesn't list qualifications. It doesn't explain my record or announce that I'm passionate about excellence. There's no version of "I believe I'd be a great fit." Either the link holds or nothing else I could say matters.

The next call was a different animal. On the earlier calls, the language had been careful. They were thinking about bringing me on. Thinking about it, the way you think about

getting the roof looked at eventually. After they logged in, the language changed. The new word was partnership.

Sit with the distance between those two phrases for a second. People who get brought on are overhead. People who become partners get cut in. On that call I heard about their managing-partner model, about peers in seats like the one being discussed pulling \$350,000 a month. I grew up in a house where the brand of beer in the fridge told you whether the bills got paid that week, so you can imagine what that number sounded like in my ear. And here's the part I need you to hold onto: nothing about me changed between those two calls. Same record. Same missing degree. Same resume with the same holes in it. The only new fact in the universe was the artifact.

Burned as many times as I've been, I didn't float into the next conversation on the good feeling, either. Before anybody talked terms, I wrote my questions down like a man studying for a test: who owns what, who can walk away, and what it costs to leave. Keep that pairing in your pocket, because it's the full posture. Build like a believer. Negotiate like a skeptic.

One more thing before we go on, because this book runs on receipts and receipts cut both ways. This story does not end with me in that seat. I'm going to tell you exactly how it ended, and it stings, and I'm telling you anyway because the law still holds. What happened between those two phone calls is real, and it works even when the deal doesn't.

* * *

The Principle: Don't tell them you can build it. Build it. Put it in their hands. Let the work do the arguing.

* * *

Every room you're trying to get into is drowning in talk.

The investor has heard a thousand pitches and watched most of them evaporate. The client has hired three freelancers who swore they were different and weren't. The hiring manager is staring at a stack of resumes where every human on earth is a passionate self-starter. When I was raising money for my cannabis company, I got to sit on the other side of the table, and I already told you the ugly thing it taught me: enough people are liars that you learn to question everybody. Now flip that around, because that's what the room is thinking when you walk in. They don't hate you. They've just been lied to so many times that your words come pre-discounted, marked down to about what they cost you to say. Which is nothing.

Claims are free. That's the whole problem. Anybody can claim anything, so rooms price claims at zero and wait to be shown.

Nobody teaches you this, by the way. School trains you the other direction. Years of raise your hand and describe your strengths in five paragraphs, and you come out believing the person who talks about the work best gets the work. Then the interview process doubles down: tell me about a time, walk

me through your weaknesses, where do you see yourself in five years. Talk auditions, every one of them. So the average person walks into every important room carrying one tool, self-description, and can't figure out why the room won't move. It's not a character flaw. It's training. But understand what you're up against: the room has been described to death. Description is the one thing every liar who came before you was also good at.

An artifact is the answer. An artifact is a real thing that works when you're not in the room. A live link. A working demo. A finished sample. A rebuilt version of their own broken thing. The test is simple: can a stranger touch it without you standing there explaining it? If it needs your voice next to it to make sense, it's still a pitch, just wearing a lab coat. If a stranger can use it at midnight while you're asleep, you've got an artifact.

Before you tell me this is a tech thing, it's not. If you bake, the artifact is a box of exactly what you sell showing up on the cafe owner's counter with your card taped to the lid. If you keep books for small businesses, the artifact is a one-page cleanup of a prospect's mess that took you an evening and shows them their own money more clearly than they've ever seen it. If you cut hair, train dogs, weld, design, coach, or cook, there is a version of your work small enough to hand over and real enough to end an argument. The medium changes. The law doesn't.

Three things happen when you put an artifact in somebody's hands, and every one of them moves the room.

First, the burden of proof changes teams. When you make a claim, the other side has to imagine you succeeding, and their imagination is where your claim goes to die, because it's crowded with every liar who got there first. When you hand them a working thing, doubt has to do the work now. The thing is up. It runs. They'd have to argue with a login screen, and I have never once seen a login screen lose an argument.

Second, your category changes. Applicants ask. Partners offer. The minute you hand over finished work, you stop being a request in somebody's inbox and start being an asset in their building. Togo's language went from bringing me on to partnership in one phone call, and no amount of interviewing was ever going to move that word. Words don't promote you. Work does.

Third, an artifact carries information no claim can carry. It shows your speed, because the thing exists while everybody else is still scheduling calls about maybe someday. It shows your judgment, because what you chose to include and what you chose to leave out is sitting right there on the screen. And it shows follow-through, which might be the rarest metal on earth. The world is buried in projects that are 80 percent done. A finished thing, even a small finished thing, puts you in a different species.

Underneath all three, something else happens that you'll only notice after a few reps: the artifact does its arguing without your nerves in the room. I don't care how confident you are, your mouth can have a bad day. Your demo can't. It says the same true thing at 9 a.m. and at midnight, to the

junior guy and to the boss, whether you slept or not. And for those of us who didn't grow up speaking boardroom English as a first language, that matters more than anybody admits. The work speaks the room's language even on the days you don't.

Basketball taught me this law long before business did, because sports run the last honest proof economy left in America.

Back in Arkansas I went to a tryout for the Arkansas Wings, one of the elite AAU programs in the state. Nobody in that gym knew my name. I was a country kid from Clarksville, a town most of those city players couldn't have found on a map, and no reputation walked through the door ahead of me. I didn't hand out a flyer about my potential. On the first whistle of the tryout, I threw down a 360 dunk. After that moment, I was an Arkansas Wing. One play. No debate, no committee, no follow-up interview. The dunk made the argument and the gym accepted it, because a gym has no choice. The rim doesn't check pedigree. The scoreboard doesn't care where you're from, what your daddy did, or what a piece of paper says about you. Years later, in the biggest game of my life, a floater at the buzzer over the number one team in the country said more about me in four seconds than every recruiting letter that never showed up. That story lives back in Chapter 3 and I'm not retelling it here. I'm just pointing at its shape: nobody argued with the ball going in.

Here's the problem, and it took me years to name it. Most rooms you walk into as a grown person don't have a rim. No whistle, no clock, no score. A conference room keeps no stats, so talk fills the vacuum, and the best talker wins by default. You can spend your whole life mad about that. I spent some of mine mad about it. Or you can do what I finally learned to do, which is bring your own rim. That's all an artifact is. It turns their conference room into your tryout, and the demo is the first whistle.

My father ran his entire life on this law and never explained it once. He wasn't a talker about work. He didn't do words the way other dads did words. Chapter 1 showed you the whole economy of our house: the work, then the look, then the nod. You didn't argue your case to York Sr. You showed him a finished thing and waited, and the finished thing did your talking. He gave the world the same treatment in reverse. The man almost never told anybody what he could do. He showed you a plate of food that made the whole neighborhood line up. He put up a hoop for his boys out of what the situation offered and let a decade of jump shots explain his reasoning. Clarksville never read his resume out loud, and Clarksville knew exactly what he was. That's the destination I want for you. Be known by your artifacts. Let people who've never heard you say a word about yourself already know what your work does.

To be clear, this is not a personality thing. My dad was a showman. I'm a showman. I'll talk all day and enjoy every minute of it. The law isn't "never talk." The law is about

sequence. Build first, then talk about what exists. Talk after the artifact is promotion. Talk before the artifact is prayer. My father could hold a whole domino table hostage with his mouth, but notice that he did it while winning, with the bones laid out on the table where everybody could count them. The mouth was seasoning. The work was the meat.

Now, people hear this principle and wreck it in one of two directions, so let me put some guardrails on it.

The first wreck is building forever and shipping never. The garage is full of geniuses. Somewhere right now a man is on year six of a project nobody has ever touched, polishing it like a stone, telling himself he's holding it back because of standards. Perfectionism talks like high standards, but most of the time it's just hiding with a work ethic. This principle has two halves, and people love to skip the second one: put it in their hands. Proof that stays home isn't proof, it's a diary. A demo nobody has logged into is a rumor. Ship at ugly. I've shipped software so ugly it looked like it time-traveled here from 1985, and Chapter 1 already told you who replied when I posted a screenshot of it anyway. The piece that belongs here is this: the ugly artifact went public, and the public artifact pulled a room toward me that I could never have knocked my way into. Ugly and live beats polished and imaginary, every day of the week and twice on Sunday.

While I'm on it: shipping doesn't always mean shipping to one room. Some artifacts you set out in the open and let them fish for you. That terminal screenshot was one. I wasn't pitching anybody. I put the work where strangers could trip

over it, and a stranger with weight tripped over it. A public artifact works every room at once, including rooms you don't know exist yet. The repo public instead of private. The before-and-after posted instead of filed. The sample on the counter instead of in your trunk. You'll feel naked doing it, because public work can be publicly judged, and that's exactly why so few people do it, and exactly why it works. Doors you never knocked on start opening from the inside.

Wreck number two runs the other way. People hear "build it first" and turn themselves into free labor with no floor. There's a whole economy out there built on strip-mining hopeful people. Take-home projects that are really unpaid sprints. Clients who need just one more sample before they can decide. Rooms that collect free work like trading cards and never write a check. Spec work is a bet, and you don't survive betting without rules, so here are mine.

Rule one: you pick the scope, and you keep it small. An artifact is a proof, and a proof only has to be big enough to remove doubt about you. One room's worth. If it can't ship in about 30 days on the side, it's not an artifact anymore, it's an investment, and unpaid investments in other people's companies are how you go broke feeling productive. Cut the scope in half. If it still can't ship, cut it again.

Second rule: it stays yours. Build it on your own accounts, your own tools, your own name, and keep it there until paper and payment say otherwise. I built Togo a whole platform, but I built it where I could point at it afterward, and you're

about to see why that mattered more than anything else in this story.

Third rule: negotiate awake. Free work buys you the conversation. It does not obligate you to a bad contract, and it doesn't excuse you from homework. I walked toward that partnership conversation with every one of my questions already on paper, because a warm room is still a room, and I've shaken hands with people who were reaching for my pocket with the other one. If a room happily takes your free build and then gets foggy the minute you ask about paper, that fog is information, and you just got it at the cheapest price it will ever be offered.

I want to talk straight to some of y'all for a minute. The ones with a record. The ones with a gap in the resume that can't be explained in polite company. The ones with no degree, the wrong zip code, a last name the filters were built to catch. I'm one of you, so hear me.

When I went at the tech industry, I learned fast that the filter isn't *can you build*. The filter is the degree, the pedigree, the unbroken resume. I don't have any of those. There are two kinds of paper in this world: the paper institutions issue you and the paper you print yourself. Degrees, pedigrees, clean background checks, that's issued paper, and if yours is missing or stamped wrong, you can spend your whole life asking the filter to make an exception. Filters don't make exceptions. Filtering is the only thing a filter knows how to do. My proof was already live on the internet under my own name, working applications any stranger could click, and it

could not get me one callback. Read that sentence twice, because half the hustle gurus will tell you proof beats everything, and that sentence is me telling you it doesn't.

Here's the thing about issued paper: it mostly measures your past. Where you were allowed to enroll, who could afford to keep you there, what you got caught doing at seventeen. Printed paper measures your present. What you can put in somebody's hands this month. If your past is your strong suit, run the front door and God bless. Mine isn't. For people like us, every day spent begging an issued-paper room to overlook the past is a day not spent printing the kind of paper that makes the past shrink. The record stops mattering the moment the receipts start stacking. Not to every room. To enough rooms.

What proof actually does is different, and you need the difference. Proof doesn't beat the filter. Proof goes around it. A hiring portal will never click your link. A human being with a problem will, out of nothing more than curiosity. So stop aiming artifacts at machines and start aiming them at humans. That was the whole play when I built VitROS. I didn't email labs asking whether they'd be open to a conversation about their workflow. I sent demo logins, cold, straight to tissue-culture labs. A pitch can be deleted without effort. A login sits in the inbox daring somebody to try it.

Pay attention to the note that travels with the artifact, too, because the note is part of the craft. Two lines. What it is, and how to touch it. The temptation is to wrap your build in an essay, your story, your credentials, your apology for existing,

and every extra sentence drains blood out of the thing. A long note says please. A short note says here. Rooms can smell the difference from the subject line. You spent a month making work that can speak for itself. The worst thing you can do at the finish line is talk over it.

This is the credibility ladder for people like us. You can't climb theirs. The bottom rungs are sawed off for people with our paperwork. So you build your own, artifact by artifact. One artifact makes a human curious. A few make you interesting. A stack of them makes you undeniable to anybody who actually looks, and the ones who refuse to look were never your door anyway. There are 25 public repositories sitting under my name right now that anybody on earth can audit. That's not a resume. That's a record, the good kind, the kind I printed myself, and no institution can withhold it from me the way institutions have withheld their paper from me my whole life.

Now the ending I owe you.

The term sheet never came. The partnership talk stayed talk. And the way I learned the seat had been filled wasn't a phone call or an email. It was a LinkedIn post. Somebody else's good news, scrolling past me like weather.

Say it plain: the spec build still lost the job. The best free work of my life, work good enough to flip the language of a phone call with one login, did not convert into the seat. I built it, I put it in their hands, I let the work do the arguing, the work argued beautifully, and I lost anyway.

Let me hand you the honest bill too, because every win and every loss in this book comes with one. That platform cost real hours nobody was paying for, hours that came out of the margins of my life while the rest of my life kept charging full price. And the scroll cost something on its own. You don't build a man his platform for free and then find out about his new hire the same way you find out about a stranger's birthday, without feeling it in your chest. I'm not going to pretend the artifact made the no painless. It didn't. It made the no survivable. There's a difference, and the difference is the whole reason I'm still telling you to do this.

I could've left that part out. The chapter reads cleaner without it. End it at the word partnership and roll the credits. But then I'd be selling you a slot machine: build the thing, win the seat, every time. That's not the law. Here's the law with all its teeth: proof gets you the table. It does not always get you the seat. There are forces at some tables that no artifact overrides. Timing. Politics. A relationship you never knew existed. Somebody's cousin. You can set the best thing in the room down on that table and watch the room choose comfortable. Build long enough and it will happen to you. It has happened to me more than once, and it stung every time.

And yet I'm still telling you to build, because of what's left on the ground after the loss. When a pitch fails, you're holding nothing. A slide deck nobody will ever open again, a "great meeting you" email chain, and a lesson about the room if you were paying attention. When a build fails, you're holding a building.

RenderOS, the platform I built Togo for free, lost me that seat and then went right to work for me anyway. It became the thing I point to when a stranger asks what I can do: a full platform, built alone, on spec, deployed. It became the proof sitting underneath Caipher Studio, the agency my wife and I run now, where the clients are smaller than Togo and they actually pay. The skills compounded too. The stack I learned building their platform is the same stack I sell today. Togo never paid me a dollar, and that build has been paying me ever since. The demo itself sunset on May 6, of all the dates on the calendar. If you've been reading in order, you know what May 6 does in my family. Even my endings rhyme. But sunseting a demo doesn't repossess the evidence. An artifact compounds even when the answer is no. A pitch compounds into nothing no matter what the answer is.

I want you to see the compounding mechanically, because people say "it compounds" the way they say "trust the process," like a bumper sticker. It works like this. Every build cuts the price of the next one, because the learning stays in your hands: the second platform costs half the sweat of the first, and the fifth one costs a weekend. Every artifact recruits for the next, because finished work travels without you; something you shipped last year gets forwarded into a room you've never stood in, and the room forms an opinion of you while you're asleep. And the stack quietly changes your own math, because once you're holding receipts, one no stops being a verdict and becomes a data point. The first artifact is

the most expensive one you will ever build. Every one after that is on sale.

There's one more thing a shut door gives you, if you let it, and I first told you back in Chapter 3: even the doors that stay shut are data. They tell you which walls to stop knocking on, and which tool you're still missing. For me, the missing tool had a name, and part of my answer to that LinkedIn post was finally enrolling to get my computer science degree, on my terms, for my reasons. Losing with an artifact in your hands is a different species of loss than losing with nothing. One is a setback standing on a foundation. The other is just zero.

The world tells people like us to wait. Wait for the credential, wait for the callback, wait for somebody with authority to believe in you, and then build. That order is backwards, and the wait is rigged. Belief is a lagging indicator. It shows up after the evidence, sometimes years after, sometimes never, and you cannot schedule it. What you can schedule is the evidence. I watched my father get the nod from a whole town that never once read his paperwork. I watched a gym full of strangers change their minds in the time it takes to finish a dunk. And I watched a company change its vocabulary in one login and still hand the seat to somebody else. All three are the same law seen from different angles. The work argues. Sometimes it wins the whole room, sometimes it only wins you the next room, and either way it never stops being yours. You do not need permission to build something great. Build it before they believe you, because if you wait for belief you'll die waiting. And somewhere around

your fifth artifact, something quiet happens: their belief stops being the thing your life runs on. That's the real prize. Not the seat. The stack.

Run It

One artifact. Thirty days. One room. Paper and pen, and I mean actual paper: write it, date it, keep it where you can see it.

1. **Name the room.** Write down the one room you most want into in the next 90 days. A client, an employer, an investor, a partner, a program. One room, not five. Then write the name of the human in that room. If you don't know the human's name, your first job this week is finding it, because machines don't click links and rooms don't open themselves. Date the page.
2. **Find the standing problem.** Every room has something broken, slow, ugly, or missing, and the people in it complain about that thing at lunch. The strongest artifact is a rebuilt version of something they already have (that's what I did to Togo's platform) or a working sample aimed dead at their problem. Write this sentence and fill in both blanks: "They have . *I will put* in their hands." If you can't fill in the first blank, you don't know the room well enough to build for it yet, and your first week is study, not construction.

3. **Scope it to ship in 30 days.** The artifact must work without you standing next to it, and a stranger must be able to touch it: a link, a login, a sample, a finished piece. Build it on your own accounts, your own tools, your own name. Now look at your scope honestly. If it can't ship in 30 days out of the margins of your life, cut it in half. Still can't? Cut it again. Small and live beats big and imaginary. Write the ship date on the page and put it on a calendar you actually look at.
4. **Schedule the reps.** Artifacts get built in scheduled hours, not leftover ones. Find your margins this week, mornings, nights, lunch breaks, whatever your life gives you, and block them like shifts you'd get fired for missing. Miss one, make it up within 48 hours. If you can't find five hours this week for a room you claim to want, be honest with yourself about what you actually want, then either want it for real or pick a different room.
5. **Ship it with a two-line note.** Line one says what it is. Line two puts it in their hands. Mine was "Here's your new platform. Log in." Yours might be "I rebuilt your booking page. It's live here." Or "I made a sample run of what I'd sell in your shop. Where do I send it?" No resume attached. No life story. No apology. If your note needs a third line, you either built the wrong thing or you're still talking.
6. **Log it, shelf it, aim it again.** Whatever comes back, even if it's silence, write down the date, what you shipped, and

the response. Then put the artifact where the next room can find it: your site, your portfolio, your public repos, the shelf behind you on video calls. Pick the next room and point the same artifact, or the next one, at it. One artifact is a sample. A stack is a body of work, and a body of work is the one resume nobody can withhold from you.

Thirty days. If that feels like too much to spend on a room you say you want, then what you want isn't the room. It's to be believed without evidence, and I checked: they're sold out of that everywhere.

The Crate

The crate never asked to be believed in. Nobody in Clarksville looked at a milk crate nailed to plywood and saw a future, and the crate did not care. It went up before there was one shred of evidence the boy could shoot, and then it hung there, day after day, collecting the evidence one shot at a time. My father didn't tell his son what he might buy him someday, and he didn't tell the neighborhood what his boy was going to become. He built what the situation allowed, put a ball in a kid's hands, and let the work start arguing. Shot after shot argued. The belief came later, from coaches, from crowds, from whole towns, and by the time it arrived it was only paperwork, confirming what the crate already knew. Belief always comes later. The building comes first. That order has never once run the other way.

Chapter 8: Treat Every Loss Like Tuition

The backpack is the part I can't forget.

We're backstage at an arena in Omaha, Nebraska, on the night of a show my partner and I paid \$25,000 to put on, and one of the promoters is walking around with a backpack on his shoulder. Not a bag of cash. Not contracts, not wristbands, not anything useful. A backpack full of tickets. Our tickets. Stacks of them, crisp and unsold, zipped up like homework nobody turned in.

My daddy was a human calculator. I'm not. But you didn't need his brain to run the math in that hallway. Every ticket in that bag was a seat with nobody in it, and every empty seat was money that had already left my account.

Let me back up.

This was my music era. Or, if I'm keeping it real, this was the era when I was paying to be in the music business, which feels exactly like being in the music business right up until the accounting starts. My partner and I saw what looked like a real move: book Lil Boosie for a show in Omaha. A real artist with a real catalog, in a real arena. We put up \$12,500 apiece.

That's \$25,000 of our own money committed before one single ticket sold.

The show came with promoters. Local guys, plugged in, supposed to know the market. Their entire function was printed right there in their title. Promote.

I assumed the promoters were promoting. I assumed wrong.

You want to know what their marketing operation actually amounted to? One of their big promotional pushes was a run to a strip club. And look, on paper that's the correct building. If there is one room in America where a Boosie show sells itself, that is the room. Except the dancers at that stop didn't even know there was a show. That is how little promoting was going on. The marketing run was a night out with a receipt attached.

Show night came. Boosie showed up and did his job. The city did not, because nobody had told the city. The arena sat 75 percent empty. If you've never stood in a big room built for noise that doesn't have enough bodies in it to make any, I can tell you what it sounds like. It sounds like your money, echoing.

Then came the settling up. When everything got counted, the ticket money weighed against the bills, I was not made whole. I was not half whole. I was out my \$12,500 and another \$500 on top of it. Read that again. I paid an extra \$500 for the privilege of losing \$12,500.

Before I left, the man who owned the arena found me. He didn't laugh at me, which I appreciated, because he would

have been within his rights. He said, “The blame lies on your promoters.” Then he did me a favor I was too fresh off the loss to appreciate. He handed me business cards. Other promoters, he told me. Men who had sold out this same arena.

The next night.

With a cover band.

Sit with that the way I had to sit with it on the drive home. Lil Boosie, a man with real records and real fans, played to a building three quarters empty. Twenty-four hours later, a band playing other people’s songs packed that building. Same city. Same building. Same seats. Same ticket-buying public. The thing on the stage was never the problem. The machine selling it was.

For a while, all I had from Omaha was the hole in my account. The education didn’t show up until I quit telling the story like a victim and started telling it like an accountant.

* * *

The Principle: It was the most expensive class I ever took. But I only had to take it once.

Here’s the accountant’s version of that night. I didn’t lose \$25,000 in Omaha. I spent it. The whole distance between those two words is whether you walk away holding something, and I eventually walked away holding a rule I have never once broken since: verify the work, not the title. A promoter is not a man with “promoter” in his bio. A promoter is a man who can show you tickets moving. That one rule has

saved me more than \$25,000 several times over, which means that on a long enough timeline, the Boosie show turned a profit.

That's what tuition is. Tuition is money you pay for something you get to keep. A loss is money you pay for nothing. And here's the part nobody tells you: it is the same event either way. The empty arena doesn't care what you call it. The money is gone in both versions. The only thing that decides whether your worst night was a robbery or a class is what you do in the weeks after it, and most people do nothing. They nurse the wound, curse the names involved, and walk into the same wall the next year wearing a different jacket.

You have already paid tuition. That's the first thing I need you to hear, because most people think tuition means the losses coming down the road. No. Whatever your version of the backpack is, the marriage that ended, the business that folded, the money you lent somebody you love, the years you gave a job that gave you a plaque, you already paid it. The money is gone either way. The years are gone either way. The only live question is whether you collect the education you paid for. Most people never do. They pay full price and leave without the degree. Think about how backwards that is. You'd never pay for a class, sit through every painful session, and then skip the one day they hand out what you came for. But that's exactly what a man does when he takes a beating from life and refuses to look at it straight.

Collecting is a specific act. It is not a feeling. It is not saying “I learned so much from that season,” which is usually what people say when they learned nothing. Collecting has exactly one form: a rule, written down, one sentence long.

The one-sentence part matters. If your lesson takes a paragraph, you’re still in class. A paragraph means you’re still explaining, still defending, still telling the story with the good lighting on your side. A sentence means you found the mechanism. “Verify the work, not the title” is a sentence. I can hand it to a stranger and it will change how he hires a contractor tomorrow morning. That’s the test of a real rule: somebody who wasn’t there can use it.

Let me give you a few more, so you can hear the shape, because your losses won’t all be business losses. If the loss was a marriage, the rule is not “love is a scam.” It might be “I don’t ignore what a person shows me in the first year because I like what they say.” If the loss was your health, the rule might be “I don’t trade sleep for work two nights in a row.” If the loss was lending money, it might be “I only give what I can afford to lose, and I call it a gift out loud, so the relationship survives either way.” Hear it? Each one is specific enough to use Monday morning, and none of them require you to become a colder person. A real rule almost never does.

Writing it down is not optional, either, and I want to be plain about why. People keep receipts for a \$40 toaster and keep nothing for a \$25,000 loss. The rule that lives in your head gets soft. It bends when a smooth talker leans on it. The rule that lives on paper stays the same size no matter who’s in

the room, and you can read it before you sign anything, the way a pilot reads a checklist he already knows by heart. He doesn't read it because he forgot. He reads it because the day he skips it is the day it mattered.

Rules compound, too. One rule saves you one deal. A page of them changes what kind of operator you are. Mine is the cheapest education I ever got, which is a funny thing to say about a page that cost north of \$55,000 to write, but that is the point. The losses already happened. The writing already happened. The only free part of the whole system is the extraction, and the extraction is the part people skip.

And the autopsy has to be honest, because a wrong rule costs as much as no rule. People hear the Omaha story and jump straight to "the music business is dirty" or "never do shows." That's lazy surgery. Look at what the arena owner handed me. Same room, sold out, the very next night. The demand was real. The product was fine. My process was broken in one specific spot: I paid for a title and never checked for the work. So the rule is not "stay out of music." The rule lives at the exact break point and nowhere else. When you run your own autopsy, keep cutting until you find that point. Was it the thing you were selling, or the way you sold it? Was it the person you picked, or the paper you didn't have? Was it the idea, or the timing? Was it the plan, or the size of the bet? Different answers write different rules, and only one of them is true.

Notice something else about that night in Omaha. The correction was in my hand before I got to the parking lot. The

arena owner handed me the fix, actual business cards with the names of men who did the job right, while my loss was still warm. That happens more than you'd think. The loss usually arrives with its own lesson taped to the bottom, and the only reason we miss it is that we're too busy bleeding to flip it over.

I'll show you a second class, because I paid for it around the same stretch of my life, and the lesson hides in the details. This one cost \$30,000.

A former college teammate of mine was living like money. BMW. Rolexes. His daddy presented himself as an international businessman, the kind of man who mentioned countries the way other men mention counties. The play was a nursing home. An investment. Get in early, get paid for years, do some good for old folks while you're at it. It sounded like the kind of grown money I was hungry to sit next to.

I showed up to the investment meeting and noticed something that should have turned me around at the door: I was the only man in the room who had actually brought money. Everybody else brought presentation. I brought \$30,000 in cash.

Now here's the detail that still makes me shake my head at my younger self. The only reason I handed that cash over that day, instead of sitting with it another week and asking harder questions, was that I had a flight to catch. I did not want to fly with \$30,000 on me. So I left it with them. That is the entire amount of due diligence that decision received. A departure time.

There was no nursing home. There was never going to be a nursing home. The receipts trickled in later, the way receipts do. The daddy, the international businessman, had been hitting up high schoolers for money. High schoolers. And my teammate's whole glittering setup, the car, the watches, turned out to be recycled financial aid. It looked like money. It was a costume.

Two rules came out of that class, and I paid full retail for both. First: cash meant there was nothing to sue over. No wire, no paper trail, no contract. When it went bad, there was not one thread for me to pull. So the rule reads paper or no deal, every time, with everybody, and especially with people you like, because the people you like are the only ones who can talk you into skipping it. If a man bristles when you bring up paperwork, that's not friction. That's information. Second: vet the source of the shine. A BMW tells you a man has a BMW. It tells you nothing about where the payments come from. Financial aid can drive German. Ask what feeds the lifestyle before you feed it yourself.

One more thing about that \$30,000, because it matters to the math. I never chased that man down. I never made it a feud. Not because I'm soft, but because a feud is how a one-time payment becomes a payment plan. The money was gone. The only thing still up for grabs was my time and my peace, and I wasn't putting those on the tab too. When you let a loss become a war, you keep paying for a class you already finished.

Since I'm being honest about that stretch of my life, here's a smaller class from the same campus, because tuition isn't always about what somebody took from you. Sometimes it's about what you owe after the loss. Early in my time around the cannabis business, a man fronted me product on nothing but my word. I lost it. All of it. I paid him back, he fronted me more, and I lost that too, \$2,500 in the hole on product I no longer had. Nobody would have blamed me for disappearing. Broke men vanish over less every day of the week. I paid back every dollar instead, and it hurt, and it took a while, and it turned out to be some of the best money I ever spent, because the people around that business watched me pay on a loss. That's the reason doors kept opening for me in rooms where trust was the only currency anybody accepted. The rule from that class: pay what you owe on your losses, because your name is the one asset that walks away from every wreck, and it's worth more than whatever the wreck cost.

Now let me show you how people pay for the class and still skip the education, because I'd bet money you're doing at least one of these right now. I have done every one of them.

You can hear the difference at any cookout. Listen to how the people around you tell their loss stories. A beating story ends with what somebody else did: she left, he lied, they folded, the market crashed. A tuition story ends with what the teller does differently now. Same pain in both. The last sentence tells you who collected and who didn't. And when you catch your own story ending on somebody else's name,

that's your cue that the education is still sitting at the window, unclaimed.

Renaming the loss is the first move. Bad luck. Haters. The economy. Wasn't meant to be. Every one of those names has the same job: protecting your ego from the autopsy. I understand the instinct, because the autopsy hurts. Mine said a grown man handed \$12,500 to an empty arena because he never asked one follow-up question. But a loss you rename is a loss you will re-buy. The universe doesn't accept "wasn't meant to be" as proof you completed the course. It just schedules the retake, and the retake always costs more.

Fake tuition is the second move. This is the motivational poster crowd. "Everything happens for a reason." "It made me who I am today." These folks sound healed, and I used to envy how fast they got over things, until I noticed they never change anything. Ask them what the reason was, specifically, and they can't tell you. Calling a loss a lesson without extracting the rule isn't wisdom. A lesson you can't say in one sentence is a bumper sticker, and a bumper sticker never stopped anybody from crashing the same car twice.

Overpaying is the third move, and it's the sneaky one, because it looks like learning. This is when the loss hands you a rule that's too big. The man who gets cheated once and decides "never trust anybody again." The woman whose business folds and decides "people like me aren't built for business." That is not a rule. That is a scar, and the difference matters: a rule changes your behavior, a scar changes your size. After the \$30,000, there was a rule available to me that

read “never invest in anything again,” and notice how much poorer I would be today, in money and in life, if I had written that one down. I have kept investing in people and projects ever since. I just stopped doing it without paper. A rule protects the next deal. A scar cancels it. If the lesson you pulled from a loss makes your life smaller, get back in there and keep cutting. You extracted the wrong organ.

Robert Kiyosaki makes this point plainly in *Rich Dad Poor Dad*: winners lose, learn, and keep playing, while the fear of losing keeps everybody else from ever really playing at all.

Everything hangs on one distinction. Tuition gets paid once. A subscription bills you monthly.

Tuition works like this: you pay, you extract the rule, you own it forever, and the class never charges you again. Omaha is settled. The nursing home is settled. Stamped and filed.

A subscription is what a loss becomes when you skip the extraction. Same charge, same story, forever, on autopay. You know these people. The man whose fourth straight business partner cleaned him out, and every single one was “the last person I ever thought would do me like that.” The woman on her third relationship with the same man in different clothes. The brother fired from four jobs, and all four times it was politics. The names change. The plot doesn’t.

And before you think I’m up here clowning anybody, let me keep it a buck about my own billing history. Omaha and the nursing home were cousins. Different rooms, same weakness: I treated my read on a person as due diligence. I believed I could look a man in the eye and know. That

subscription billed me \$25,000 in Nebraska and \$30,000 in a meeting room before I finally saw it for what it was and canceled it. Sometimes you don't spot the subscription until the second invoice shows up and you recognize the handwriting.

Run the math on a subscription sometime, because the numbers are uglier than any single loss. A \$25,000 class, paid once, is survivable. The same weakness left on autopay for 20 years will quietly cost you more than college, and unlike college, it doesn't come with a degree at the end. It comes with a story you tell at family functions about how you can't win for losing. You can. You just haven't canceled anything yet.

There's a good chance you're enrolled in a class right now, too. Something in your life is charging you every month, a deal you know is lopsided, a habit with a price tag you refuse to total up. You already suspect what the rule is going to be. That little flinch you feel right before you do the thing again, that's the syllabus trying to get your attention. The difference between paying tuition and paying a subscription usually comes down to half an hour of honesty and a pen.

Finding yours is simple, and it stings. Tell the story of your last three losses out loud, to yourself, in the car. If it's the same story with different names in it, you're subscribed. Listen for the rerun.

Canceling takes two moves, and neither one is a vow. "I'll be more careful next time" has never canceled anything in the history of losing. The first move is the written rule, which

we've covered. The second is structure: one physical change that keeps working on the days your discipline doesn't. Paper where the handshake was. The accounts separated. The card taken out of the phone. The dollar limit announced out loud to the family so nobody has to renegotiate it in a crisis. Structure doesn't get tired or lonely, and it doesn't get talked into things at 11 at night. That's why it beats willpower every time it suits up.

Companies figured this out a long time ago. When an employee walks out the door, they sit him down for an exit interview, because the company wants the education it already paid for. Give your losses the same courtesy. Every L gets 30 minutes across the kitchen table from yourself: what happened, where exactly did it break, what's the one-sentence rule, what structure changes this week. Half an hour. That's the entire cost of converting a loss into tuition, and grown folks skip it for decades.

There's also interest to think about, because unextracted losses don't sit still. A loss you never converted keeps charging you in a second currency: confidence. Every unexamined L whispers the same thing, that maybe you're just a man things go wrong for. Convert the loss into a rule and the whisper stops, because the story changes from "something is wrong with me" to "something was wrong with my process, and I fixed it." I can't overstate what that does for how you walk into the next room.

Bitterness is the other interest charge. A man carrying unconverted losses doesn't teach his kids rules. He teaches

them warnings. Everything becomes “watch out for this” and “don’t trust that,” and he calls it wisdom when really it’s just his unpaid balance, passed down with the family name. I’ve known men like that my whole life, men whose entire curriculum was suspicion, and I understand now what I couldn’t see back then: every warning used to be a wound that nobody sat with long enough to turn into a lesson. Don’t hand your people your balance. Hand them your rules.

Somebody always asks me the same question when I get going on this: how do you know whether the losses are telling you to quit or whether you’re just at the hard part? It’s the right question, because losses don’t come labeled. Here is how I sort mine.

Start by checking whether you’re watching a rerun or a new episode. New losses at higher levels are a curriculum. When each L teaches you something you genuinely did not know, you are advancing through the grades, and that is exactly what the hard part feels like from the inside. The same L on repeat is a subscription, and if it keeps arriving no matter what you adjust, either the behavior has to go or the whole venture does.

Next, figure out whether the no came from the market or from your machine. I call this the cover-band test. The same arena sold out the next night, so the demand was provably there and my process was provably broken. That reads: adjust, don’t quit. But flip it. If you have rebuilt the machine over and over and the room stays empty in every configuration, the market itself is telling you no, and a market

no that survives every process fix is the one no you should obey. Quit is the correct answer to that one. It is the wrong answer to almost everything else.

Your version of the test won't involve an arena, but it's the same check. If your food truck is slow while the truck across the lot with worse food has a line, the market isn't rejecting food trucks. It's rejecting your machine, your location, your hours, your sign, and machines can be fixed. But if every truck in town is starving, including the good ones, that's the market talking, and you want to hear it before it raises its voice.

Last, check whether you can afford the next semester. Tuition only educates the living. Part of the reason I could treat Omaha like a class instead of a catastrophe is that I could still eat afterward. If one more loss would take the lights out at your house, the answer isn't necessarily quitting the dream. It's shrinking the bet until the tuition fits your budget. Never pay tuition with rent money, and never pay it twice with anything.

One warning on all this: don't let your feelings cast the deciding vote, because from the inside, the hard part and the dead end feel identical. Both feel like embarrassment. Both feel like everybody watching. The feeling can't tell you which one you're in. The paper can. That's why the autopsy gets written down instead of felt through.

And about the size of the bet. Before you start anything new, write down the honest answer to a single question: what is the most this can cost me? Not the likely number. The full

number, the one where everything goes wrong at once. If that number takes food off your table or years off your marriage, you don't need a smaller dream. You need a smaller first bet. Classes come in levels for a reason. Nobody walks into the hardest course on day one, and the tuition system only works for people who stay enrolled.

Years later, raising money for a farm in Oklahoma, I heard no so many times I could have wallpapered the house with them, and I'll tell you what all that rejection confirmed: the nos teach you more than the yeses ever will. A yes tells you that you did enough. A no, if you make it itemize itself, tells you exactly what was missing. Same rule, smaller denominations. Every no is a little class with free tuition, which makes it the best deal in the building.

My daddy knew all of this at a domino table before I knew it anywhere. The table filled up every afternoon at 4:30, regular as a shift whistle, and I watched him do something for years before I understood it. He would lose. Early, small, on purpose. Drop a hand or two, let some loud cousin get to feeling rich, and the trash talk took care of the rest, because a man who's up and loud doesn't leave his seat. Then my daddy, the human calculator, would collect it all back with interest. Those early hands weren't losses. They were the cost of keeping the customer at the table. He understood the difference between losing money and spending it before I was old enough to see over the dominoes. Half of what I'm teaching you here, that man ran every afternoon without writing down a word. The difference between him and me is

the ledger. His rules lived in his head, and the only ones that survived him are the ones he installed in his kids by repetition. Mine go on paper, because paper is how you hand a rule to somebody who wasn't at the table.

The most recent class I took didn't cost dollars. In the last chapter I told you about the platform I built on spec for a company, the working product I put in their hands, and the seat I still didn't get. I never saw a dime for that build. For a minute, that one burned worse than Omaha, because Omaha only took money.

Then I ran the autopsy on it the same way I'm teaching you to, and the accounting flipped. What did I pay? A serious stretch of unpaid work. What did I get? The exact trade my wife and I sell today at our own studio: take a real client's real problem, scope it, build the whole thing, ship it, put it in their hands. The first client we ran that trade for paid us. The company that ghosted me turned out to be the school that trained me for the customers who wouldn't. That build was tuition too. It just invoiced me in hours instead of dollars.

Losing is a skill, and I've had more practice than most. That sentence used to embarrass me. Now it reads like a transcript. Every expensive class I ever sat through is on there, the arena, the meeting room, the platform, and next to each one is the rule it bought and the money that rule has saved me since. Your transcript reads the same way, whether you've ever looked at it or not. You've been walking past a pile of prepaid education for years. Time to go collect it.

Run It

This one is called the Tuition Ledger. You need a pen, one sheet of paper, and one honest hour. Do it this week, not “soon.” Soon is where lessons go to die.

1. Write “Tuition Ledger” at the top of the page and today’s date under it. List your three most expensive losses ever. Money counts, and so do years, a relationship, your health, your name in somebody’s mouth. Put a real number on each one where a number exists: the dollar amount, the months, the years. If two losses feel tied for a spot, pick the one that still tightens your chest when it comes up. That’s the expensive one.
2. Under each loss, write the rule it taught you in one sentence. One. If you can’t get it into a sentence, you haven’t finished the class, so keep cutting until you find the exact break point (the person, the paper, the timing, the size of the bet) and write the rule there. Then test it: if a stranger who wasn’t there couldn’t change how they act tomorrow using your sentence, it’s a story, not a rule. Rewrite it until it works on a stranger.
3. Check every rule for scar tissue. A rule tells you how to do the thing right: “no deals without paper.” A scar tells you to quit doing things: “never trust anybody.” Any sentence that shrinks your life instead of sharpening your process is a scar. Rewrite it until it protects your next move instead of canceling it.

4. Find your subscription. Read your three losses out loud and listen for the rerun, the one you have paid more than once with different names attached. Circle it. That one is still on autopay, and it has a renewal date coming whether you plan for it or not.
5. Cancel the subscription with structure, not willpower, inside seven days. Write one concrete move next to the circled loss and date it: the agreement put on paper, the accounts separated, the card taken out of the app, the limit said out loud to the people who need to hear it. Then make the move. And from here forward, keep the ledger alive. Every new loss gets its line and its one-sentence rule within 48 hours, before the story hardens and your ego starts renaming things. The loss is not over until the rule is written.

The Crate

The crate kept breaking. That's the part of the story people skip. My father put it up, I shot until it split, and he replaced it, every other week, no complaint, no speech. If you only counted crates, the man was losing steadily. He wasn't losing. By the time each crate gave out, it was full of made shots, and the shots stayed in my hands long after the plastic hit the trash. He wasn't buying crates. He was paying installments on a shooter, and he understood something I've spent this whole chapter trying to hand you: the equipment is the fee.

The education is the asset. The crate broke again and again.
The lesson never broke once. Pay the fee. Keep the asset.

Chapter 9: Always Have Your Own Ticket

The line at the California Classic was moving like cold syrup, and for once in my life I didn't mind. Summer basketball. I was there to watch a kid named Darius Acuff play, ticket already bought, nowhere to be except the seat I'd paid for. I wasn't working the room. I wasn't sliding business cards. I was a grown man going to watch a game with his own money, and if you've never had a season of your life where that sentence would've sounded like a fantasy, I'm happy for you.

Then somebody yelled my name.

I turned around, and it was Trent.

You don't forget the face of a man who once cost you money and months of your life. He still had it, too. That easy, expensive energy, like the building ought to be thanking him for showing up. Same smile. The smile that opens every door and closes nothing.

I need to back up.

During the Elite Eighth years, when I was out raising money to build a cannabis company on Oklahoma dirt, Trent came into my orbit the way men like Trent always do,

glowing with other people's success stories. Silicon Valley guy. Mentor energy. Knew everybody, and I mean actually knew everybody. This wasn't a costume. One afternoon he got Dame Dash on speakerphone like he was ordering a pizza, and I sat there listening to a man I'd grown up watching on TV talk business in real time, and some part of my brain whispered, *this is it. This is the room.*

Trent offered to raise \$3 million for 40 percent of my company.

Sit with that number the way I sat with it. At that point I was grinding out my raise in five-figure pieces, one kitchen-table pitch at a time, hearing no in every accent America makes. Now here's a man with Dame Dash on speed dial saying he can deliver the whole thing in one move. All he wants is a piece of what you built. You'd have listened too. Don't lie.

So I waited on him. Meetings that led to meetings. Calls that ended with everybody excited and nobody wired. Introductions to impressive men who introduced me to other impressive men. And slowly, expensively, I learned the truth about Trent, the same truth I'd eventually learn about a whole category of people: he could get anyone to the table, but he couldn't close a goddamn deal. The table was always set. The food just never arrived.

The months he cost me, I never got back. He cost me dollars too, through doors he opened, but I already counted those dollars back in the chapter about counting your friends twice. This chapter isn't about what Trent took. It's about

what happened years later, in a slow line at a summer basketball game, when a voice I hadn't heard in years called my name.

There was that half-second. Anybody who's ever been burned knows the half-second I'm talking about, where both of you decide what this run-in is going to be.

I hugged the man.

A real one, too. Bro hug and everything. Hand clasp, shoulder bump, good to see you. And here's the part some of y'all won't believe: it was good to see him. I didn't have to perform anything. Whatever Trent cost me had been paid off a long time ago, and I'd quit carrying the receipt around waiting on a refund that was never coming.

We caught up right there in line, a few minutes of it, asking about each other's families like regular people. He was doing what Trent does. Big names, big plans, tables getting set somewhere even as we spoke. I nodded along, genuinely entertained, the way you'd watch a magician whose trick you already know. And then he made me an offer. A courtside seat to watch the Kings. And for once the man didn't stop at talking. He texted me the ticket right there on the spot, standing in that line.

Courtside. From the man whose promises I once built months of my plan around.

I thanked him, and I meant the thanks. We did the see-you-around thing. And then I went and sat in the seat I'd already bought for myself. Nobody's mood put me in that seat. Nobody's memory of who I used to be to them, nobody's

guilt, nobody's generosity. My money, my name, my seat. It wasn't courtside. It was mine. And I watched basketball from it in a kind of peace I can't fully describe to you.

Somewhere in the middle of that game, the whole thing settled into words. Everything the last decade of tables and promises and evaporating money had been trying to teach me came out three sentences long.

* * *

The Principle: Stay cordial. Carry no hate. And always have your own ticket.

* * *

That creed sounds simple. Most true things do. But every one of those sentences took me years and cost me real money. The third sentence is the one that changes your life, and most people never make it past the first two.

Your ticket is the part of your plan that doesn't need anybody's yes.

Look at whatever you're building right now. The business, the move, the degree, the escape from the job that's eating you. Somewhere inside that plan, there's probably a sentence that starts with "and then when he calls back" or "once she approves it" or "as soon as the money comes through." I want you to find that sentence, because that sentence is a leash. It might be a comfortable leash. It might be held by somebody

you love, somebody who really does know Dame Dash. A leash held by a good person is still a leash.

Here's the distinction that took me too long to learn: a door is something you might get to walk through. A plan is something you can execute. People spend whole decades of their lives filing doors under plans. The callback that never comes gets penciled in like revenue. The rich uncle's "I got you" gets spent before it exists. The promotion somebody hinted at in a hallway becomes the reason you didn't apply anywhere else for three years. None of that is planning. That's waiting with paperwork.

Learn the vocabulary while you're at it, because the words matter. A promise is something they hold. An option is something you hold. Promises get revoked by moods, mergers, cold feet, and Tuesday afternoons. Options don't care how anybody's feeling. The whole third sentence of this creed is the slow work of converting promises into options, one at a time, while things are still calm, so that no single human being on this earth can cancel your plan by changing his mind.

I see it everywhere now that I know what to look for. The artist sitting on finished songs because a man with connections said he'd make a call. The entrepreneur whose whole company is one whale client who could leave a voicemail tomorrow and end everything. The cousin who won't take the job because the settlement is supposedly coming. Every one of them will tell you they have a plan, and every one of them is actually holding a door, and doors don't

owe you anything. A door doesn't even owe you the courtesy of closing loudly. Most of them just quietly stop being mentioned.

Trent never lied to me, exactly. That's what makes his kind dangerous. A liar you can catch. A table-setter believes his own menu. He walks into every room certain the food is coming this time, and his certainty is contagious, and you catch it like a cold. The problem was never his access. His access was real. The problem was that access and outcomes are two different sports, and I was scoring him in the wrong one.

So here's how you spot a table-setter before he costs you a year. Don't count who he knows. Count what he's closed. Ask the quiet question: what has this man actually finished? Deals die in every business, that's normal, but a man with a phone full of legends and a resume full of almosts is telling you his stats. Run a 30-day test on him. After the exciting meeting, the one that has your heart racing on the drive home, write down the date and watch what actually moves. Documents or excuses. Wires or weather reports. The excitement isn't evidence. Movement is evidence.

And understand the takeaway here, because people get it twisted. The lesson is never "avoid charming people." Charming people are useful, and God knows they're fun, and some of them will genuinely open doors you can't open alone. Keep the relationship. Take the meeting. Enjoy the table.

Just eat before you come.

Now the creed itself, piece by piece, because each sentence is doing a different job.

Stay cordial. Burning a bridge feels incredible for about a week. I know the feeling well, because I spent a good chunk of my twenties setting fires and calling it self-respect. But every industry is a small town, and every small town is a smaller town than you think, and the man you torch today will be seated next to your next opportunity, guaranteed. Cordial costs you almost nothing. A hug on a concourse. A reply to a text. A “congratulations” you didn’t strictly feel. Meanwhile cordial keeps every door on its hinges without obligating you to live behind any of them.

Where I come from, cordial was survival technology. My daddy could turn a domino-table dispute into a full standoff one week and be laughing at the same table with the same men the next, because he understood something the internet forgot: conflict doesn’t have to end the relationship. You can clash with a man on Tuesday and pass him a plate on Sunday. He knew everybody, and everybody owed him something, and half of that network existed because he never let a beef harden into a wall.

I’ll tell you what cordial costs, though, since I promised you receipts. It costs you the speech. Everybody who’s ever been burned has one, the monologue you polish in the car during imaginary arguments, the one where you finally say it all and they finally have to hear it. Cordial means the speech

dies unperformed. There was a season when I had one of those speeches loaded for Trent. By the night of the Classic it was gone, and that's how I knew the rest of the creed had already done its work on me.

Understand what cordial is not, either. Cordial is not trust. I hugged Trent with my whole chest, and I would not hand that man a dollar or a deadline if he showed up with the Pope co-signing. Both of those facts live in me comfortably, no contradiction, no static. That's the skill. Warmth on the surface, receipts in the vault.

Carry no hate. This one's harder, and I want to be straight with you about why it matters, because it isn't about being a good person. It's about arithmetic. Hate is a second leash. If I'm still hating Trent, then Trent still owns hours of my week. He's renting space in my head and paying me nothing. He's in the car with me on my drives, in the shower arguing with me, at my dinner table going over old meetings. The man cost me months when I depended on him. Hating him would've let him keep billing me for years after we stopped doing business.

I told you back in the chapter about betting on the insult how I burn disrespect for fuel, so let me be precise about the difference, because they look alike from a distance. An insult is gasoline. You pour it into the work and it moves you forward. Hate at a person is you parked in their driveway with your engine running, going nowhere, burning your own tank. Fuel converts. Hate just idles. When I saw Trent in that line, I had nothing in my chest but a little amusement and a

lot of freedom, and that freedom was the proof that the lesson had finished with me.

Practice came years before the concourse, back in my cannabis days. A man I'll call Yusuf sold a building out from under a legal build-out I'd poured my time and knowledge into. He didn't tell me. He just sold it. The old me had a whole menu of responses ready, and every item on that menu ended in consequences I'd already sampled. Instead: I took a breath. I felt the anger come. I let it pass. And I started over. Four little sentences that took me three decades to learn how to live. The building was gone either way. The only question still on the table was whether my next six months would belong to Yusuf or to me, and I decided they'd belong to me.

Hate is paying interest on another man's debt. Stop making the payments.

Always have your own ticket. The third sentence is the discipline, and it's where I want to spend the rest of this chapter, because cordial and hate-free are attitudes, but the ticket is a practice. You build it with your hands.

* * *

I learned it in high school, before I had any words for it.

At the time I was living with another family, good people from my own town who'd taken me in so I could keep chasing basketball with some stability under me. They fed me, drove me, treated me like a son, and I'm grateful to them to this day. They also grounded me once, which I want on the

record as the first grounding of my entire life. I'd been raised by a Memphis hustler and a mother who walked us five miles in the dark when home wasn't safe. Grounding was a thing I'd only ever seen on television.

Something in me clocked the arrangement for what it was, though. Everything I had in that house could be taken back, because none of it was mine. So without announcing it to anybody, I started building an exit before I needed one. I pocketed cash instead of spending it. When people offered to buy me shoes, I asked for the money instead. Quietly, politely, one crumpled bill at a time, a teenager was assembling his own ticket.

Then came the day it got tested. One of the sons, Jake, got mad and threw the roof over my head in my face, in front of the team, like a card he'd been saving. The roof, the rides, the whole arrangement, all of it weaponized in one sentence to put me in my place.

What Jake didn't know was that my bags had been packed for a week.

I called the bluff the same day. And when the household demanded the gifts back, I handed back every single gift, every shoe, every stitch, and walked. I didn't need their stuff. I needed my family. The stuff was always borrowed. The self-respect was mine outright.

Here's the part that makes the story worth telling, though. Those same people never stopped showing up for me. The relationship survived because I left cordial, no hate, on my own ticket, instead of leaving in flames. Not long after, the

father in that family bought me a car to keep me playing at Clarksville, and I accepted it with love, and I still made sure the title was in my hand first. Once I had it, he couldn't take it back. That's not paranoia. That's paperwork. You can be grateful and packed at the same time. Anybody who tells you those two can't coexist is usually somebody holding your leash.

Notice what that teenager never did, too. He never announced the exit fund. No threats at the dinner table, no "I don't need y'all," no dramatic previews. A ticket you talk about is a threat. A ticket you hold is peace. The loudest person in any room about leaving is almost always the one with nowhere to go, and the person who could actually walk is usually the calmest one at the table, for the exact same reason. Build yours in silence and let it show up only in your posture.

A favor that can be repossessed was never yours. Love the people. Title the assets.

* * *

Scale that up to grown-man money, because the same law runs a capital raise that runs a teenager's roll of crumpled bills.

When I raised capital for Elite Eighth, the total came to about \$1.2 million. It took three years, through a pandemic, in dozens of yeses and hundreds of nos. Not one institutional check in the pile. No fund, no bank, no smooth \$3 million wire

from a man with famous friends. Kitchen tables. Living rooms. People who believed in me in amounts that would make a venture capitalist laugh, stacked until the stack was real.

You already know from the friends chapter what raising capital teaches you about liars, and that the most convincing ones are the ones to run from. Conviction is the cheapest thing to counterfeit. Early in my raise I had somewhere between \$250,000 and \$400,000 in verbal commitments, grown adults looking me in my eye saying “I’m in,” and nearly all of it evaporated into excuses when the wiring instructions went out. I stopped being surprised by it somewhere past the hundredth no. A verbal commitment is weather. It looks like something real until you try to stand on it. Money in the account is the only yes that holds your weight.

Even the signed yeses will teach you the lesson. My biggest investor, a woman I’ll call Maureen, came in for \$500,000. The wire landed five months late and half-sized, restructured on her terms: \$250,000 now, \$50,000 a month after the license. I’m not painting Maureen as a villain, because she wasn’t one. She was capital, and capital has opinions and timelines, and her timeline became my operating reality whether I liked it or not. Now run the math on the version of me who’d made Maureen the whole plan. Five months of delay with no alternate route doesn’t slow that company down. It kills it. The only reason the delay was survivable was that no single yes in my whole raise was load-

bearing. Every promise sat on top of the structure. None of them held it up.

That's what option-building actually is, and I want you to hear it as a discipline and never an accident. You build alternates when you're calm, because you can't build them when you're desperate. Desperate people accept any terms and wire money to men they're still vetting. The whole point of the ticket is that you assemble it on a Tuesday when nothing's wrong, so that on the terrible Friday you're the one person in the room who doesn't have to say yes.

A raise built out of dozens of small yeses is harder to assemble than one big check, and I won't pretend otherwise. It's also impossible to yank. One institutional investor changes his mind and the whole building comes down. A hundred small bricks don't change their mind all at once. Slow money that stays beats fast money that leaves, every time they race.

* * *

Maybe you're reading all this thinking it's a founder's problem, all wires and cap tables, nothing to do with you. It has everything to do with you. If you have a job, you have one customer, and that customer is your employer, and they're 100 percent of your revenue. One reorg, one new manager, one bad quarter you had nothing to do with, and your whole economy shuts down overnight. I'm not telling

you to quit. I'm telling you to look at your own setup with the same eyes I had to learn to put on a raise.

A working person's ticket gets built out of ordinary pieces. Some months of expenses put away where you can't reach them casually. A skill the market pays for that rides with you when you walk. A resume you update while you're happy instead of while you're panicking. Some income, however small, that doesn't come out of the same building as your paycheck. None of that makes you disloyal. You can give an employer your best work with your ticket sitting quietly in your pocket. Matter of fact, the version of you holding a ticket does better work, because scared money makes bad decisions and scared employees make worse ones. Desperation negotiates terribly. Options walk into the annual review standing all the way up.

Skills are the piece I'd grab first, because skills are the one ticket nobody can repossess. That's half of why I taught myself to code at 37 with a wife, a baby, and a business already on my plate. They can take the job, the title, the funding, the building itself. They can't take what you know how to do. Old folks have been teaching this creed forever in smaller words. Keep your own cab fare. Same law, different century.

Make the option-building a standing practice while you're at it, calm and boring, like flossing. Once a month, look at every load-bearing name in your life and write one alternate next to it. Second supplier. Second client. Second route to the

same money. Most of those alternates will die unused, and that's fine. Nobody buys the spare tire hoping for the nail.

* * *

There's a second half to the ticket discipline, and I got it from my daddy.

He had a rule: never walk into a room empty handed. The way he lived it was literal enough. His kitchen fed the whole neighborhood a plate at a time, because that's how he kept score. But somewhere along the way I realized the rule was bigger than plates. It was a whole philosophy of how to enter rooms.

Most networking advice makes your skin crawl because most of it is secretly teaching you how to need people more efficiently. Work the room, collect the cards, follow up, extract. Everybody can smell it, which is why everybody hates it. My daddy's rule runs the opposite direction. Don't enter needing. Enter carrying. Show up with something the room wants, and you're never the beggar at the table, no matter how much bigger their numbers are than yours.

Deep into my tech years, a company called Togo brought me into a partnership conversation. I'd already built them an entire platform they never asked for, and that story belongs to another chapter, so I'll leave it there. What matters here is the room I had to walk into next: partnership talk, real equity, a table where the existing partners were doing monthly numbers I'd only ever read about while I was the new name

in the building. A younger me walks in there needing, and everybody smells it, and the terms write themselves accordingly.

Instead I did two things. First, burned enough times to have a system, I wrote every question down before anything got signed. IP ownership. Non-compete. Buyout math. The unsexy questions that men who've been robbed learn to ask before the handshake instead of after. Second, I went looking for something to carry, and I found it in a federal contracting program called 8(a). My background qualifies me for it, and I want you to sit with that for a second, because the same past that made front doors slam was the key to this one. The program opens a lane to sole source federal contracts up to \$4.5 million, no competitive bidding, in a country where agencies spend billions a year on exactly the kind of software this company builds. I did the homework on the registration and the certification, and I walked in carrying a revenue channel that nobody else at their table could open. The 8(a) play was my way of walking into that room with a gift bag.

Let me define the gift bag before somebody starts bringing muffins to job interviews. A gift is specific, and it costs you something real. Research hours nobody paid you for. An introduction that spends your own capital on their behalf. A finished sample of the work before anybody asked for one. A channel to money they didn't know existed, like the 8(a) lane. Flattery is never a gift. Your availability is never a gift. "Let me pick your brain" is the opposite of a gift, a withdrawal wearing a visitor's badge. Before your next big room, answer

one question on paper: what do these people need that they don't have and I can carry in the door? If you can't answer it yet, you're not ready for the room, and it's a lot better to find that out at your kitchen table than in their lobby.

Now the honesty, because this book runs on receipts: that room still told me no in the end. The gift bag is not a guarantee. Nothing is a guarantee, and any book promising you otherwise should be returned for store credit. Here's what the gift bag did do. It changed who I was while I was in there. I asked my questions like a man with options, because I was one. And when the no finally came, I walked out whole, still owning everything I'd carried in: the research, the skills, the artifact, the play itself. A gift bag is a ticket wearing a bow. When the deal dies, the beggar leaves with nothing. The man who came carrying leaves with everything he brought.

* * *

People butcher this creed in a few predictable ways, so let me save you the tuition.

Some folks hear "own ticket" and turn it into "I don't need anybody." That's a wound talking, and I understand the wound, but it's the wrong lesson. I've been saved by phone calls I didn't earn and money my teammates didn't owe me, and I'd be dead or done without a long list of people who showed up when they didn't have to. You need people. The creed doesn't remove people from your life. It removes single points of failure from your plan. There's a difference between

a village and a leash, and the difference is whether you can survive any one of them saying no.

Other folks confuse waiting with loyalty. They'll sit on a promise for years and call it being a good soldier, like the waiting itself earns interest. It doesn't. There's no account anywhere collecting your patience, no ledger where the years of holding your breath convert into a payout at the end. Listen to me on this one. The man whose call you're waiting on is not watching your clock. He's living his whole life, setting other tables, sleeping fine, and if you asked him about the promise he'd need a second to remember which one you mean. Waiting isn't loyalty. Waiting is unpaid work, and you've been doing it without a contract. Building your alternate isn't a betrayal of anybody. It's just you declining to be the only person in the arrangement who's all in.

And some folks build the whole plan around one big swing. One investor. One job. One client. One man's promise, weighing more than everything else they own combined. I don't care how good the swing looks. A plan with one name where the foundation should be isn't a plan. It's a leash with extra steps.

I owe you the cost, too. The own ticket is expensive. It costs money you'd rather spend on something fun, stacked into boring accounts and filing fees and alternates you might never use. It costs nights, because you build the second route after the first route's business hours. And it costs ego. The seat I bought was worse than the one Trent texted me. Let's not pretend otherwise. Courtside is courtside, and mine had me

up in the stands with the regular folks. But his seat came with him attached, with the tab open, with the table set one more time. My seat came with nobody attached. I've sat in both kinds over the years, and I'm telling you the worse seat with no strings beats the better seat with strings, every time, and it doesn't feel that way until the day the strings get pulled.

One clarification before we run it, so nobody takes this creed further than I mean it. You can accept the courtside seat sometimes. People will hand you real generosity in this life, no hooks in it, and refusing all of it is its own kind of sickness. I've been carried by generosity I could never have paid for. Take the gift when it's a gift. Refuse it when it's your plan. The test fits in one question: if this disappeared tomorrow, does my life still work? If yes, enjoy the seat and say thank you twice. If no, go buy your own.

Insurance looks like waste right up until the morning it's the only thing you own.

Run It

This one's called the Ticket Audit. Pen, paper, date at the top. It takes 30 minutes and it's due this week, because your leash doesn't get looser while you think about it.

1. **Write the leash sentence.** Finish this on paper: "My plan only works if _____ says yes." Sit with it until the true name shows up, a person, a company, a bank, a promise. Most people discover they have exactly one name for that

blank. Write the name down. Looking at it in ink is half the medicine.

2. **Price the wait.** Under the name, write what waiting on that yes has already cost you. Months elapsed. Dollars not earned. Doors you never knocked on because you believed this one was open. Real numbers, dated, no feelings. If the bill shocks you, good. It's supposed to.
3. **Build the alternate.** Write one route to the same goal that needs nobody's permission, and make it checkable: a second client by a named date, a second application sent, a license in your own name, a dollar amount saved. One sentence, one number, one deadline 30 days out. This is your ticket, and it counts on paper before it exists in the world.
4. **Buy one ticket this week.** Make the smallest self-funded move on the board: the filing fee, the account opened with \$50 in it, the course enrolled, the title transferred, the seat purchased with your own money. Circle this step. Of everything on this page, this is the one you finish before Sunday, because a ticket you paid for teaches you something a plan you wrote never will.
5. **Pack the gift bag.** Find the next important room on your calendar, whoever it's with. Write down one thing those people need that they don't currently have, then spend an evening preparing it: the introduction, the research, the sample, the channel. Something you can hand over free, no invoice attached. Enter carrying.

6. **Send the cordial message.** One text or email to somebody who wasted your time. Two sentences, warm, expecting nothing back. You're not reopening the account. You're proving to yourself the hate is gone and the door still has hinges. Send it, then get right back to work on step 3.

The Crate

The crate was the first own ticket I ever saw. My daddy didn't petition the town for a regulation goal, didn't wait on a paycheck that could cover one, didn't ask a single soul for permission. He looked at what was in his hands, knocked the bottom out of a milk crate, and nailed a boy's whole future to the back of the house. Nobody issued it, so nobody could revoke it. The world will offer you courtside your whole life, on its schedule, at its price, with its names attached, and some nights that offer will glitter. Take the hug. Keep the peace. Then go home and nail your own hoop to your own wall, where no man's mood can reach it, and shoot until the streetlights call you in. The seat that's truly yours is the one nobody can walk over and take.

Crate 3: The Empty Wall

Years go by the way years go by, slow in the living and all at once in the counting.

A man drives an old road in an old town. The town has not grown. He has. The fields hold still and the water tower says the same name it has always said. He slows where the road bends, and through a gap in the trees he can see the back of a house he knows better than any house he has ever paid for.

The house is quiet. The yard is empty. The crate is long gone, and so is the ball, and so is the boy who chased it.

Weather has grayed the plywood, thirty years of it. But the holes are still there. Rows of them, some rimmed with rust, and under the rust, thin orange streaks running down the grain where the rain kept finding the old nails long after the nails had nothing left to hold.

Grass has come back. It grew over the bald patch and the packed dirt and every footprint, and now it moves a little in the wind like nothing ever happened back there. Grass does not remember. That is what grass is for.

He does not get out of the car. He sits with the engine running.

The father is gone too. Not gone like the crate is gone. No hammer hangs in that house now. There is no road a man can drive down and slow up and see him through the trees.

His eye goes to one spot on that gray wall, a spot no different from any other spot, and finds it without hunting. Right there. That is where the mouth of the crate hung. He could stand blindfolded in that yard, thirty years out of practice, and put a ball clean through a rim that is not there. His feet know the distance. His wrist knows the arc. The dark taught him, and the dark does not give lessons back.

Every crate that ever hung on that wall broke. Every single one. The plastic split, the rim sagged, the shooting stopped, a new crate went up, and that one broke too. None of them lasted a month. It never mattered.

What the wall held was never the crate. It was the aim.

The crates are in a landfill somewhere, or in the dirt, or wherever plastic goes when its work is done. The plywood will fall one winter and the house will follow it, the way houses do when nobody is left to drive nails into them. The wall stays where walls stay.

Then the man checks his mirror and pulls back onto the road. The aim goes where he goes. It always has.

PART IV: THE HANDOFF

What it is for

Chapter 10: Keep the Crate, Change the Game

Concrete does not care who you used to be.

I learned that on a piece of raw land in Rancho Tehama, California, watching a stranger on YouTube pour a foundation, then walking outside and trying to do with my own two hands what he'd just done on a screen six inches wide. The land had no water. The land had no power. There were no neighbors close enough to hear me cussing, which was good, because there was a lot of cussing.

The project was a farm. The crew was me.

Clearing land alone. Pouring foundations alone. Raising greenhouses by hand on 16-to-20-hour days, with a phone propped up somewhere playing the next tutorial. My professors were strangers with power tools and comment sections. Office hours were whenever I had signal. Not the motivational poster version of building something from nothing. The real version: torn-up hands, a back that woke up angrier than I did, and nobody coming to check the work but me.

Let me back up, because you need to know how a basketball player ends up out there in the first place.

Basketball didn't die on me in one night. I could have handled one night. One night is a buzzer, a locker room, a cry, a haircut, a new life. What I got instead was slower and meaner. A torn meniscus. A cortisone shot. A knee getting drained so I could keep playing on it, because I'd rather play on one leg than watch from two. That sentence sounds tough until you price it out. A second surgery eight months after the first. Coaches who needed my body more than they needed my future. The career I'd been chasing since the milk crate was dying, and there was nothing to point at. Just a gradual dimming of the light, season by season, until the thing that had defined me since I was four years old was barely flickering.

There's a specific cruelty to a slow ending. A fast ending gets a funeral and a casserole. A slow one just gets quiet. You keep showing up to a schedule that used to mean everything, waiting for a season to feel like the old seasons, and it doesn't, and nobody around you can name the day it stopped. My knees knew before I did. Knees usually do.

Nobody prepares you for that part. Basketball gave me structure when my home had none. It gave me an identity when I didn't know who I was. So when the game dimmed out, it didn't take a hobby with it. It took the structure and the identity both. It took my answer to the question "what do you do?" And when a man loses his answer to that question, he will do almost anything to get one back.

Here's the honest bridge, because this book is about truth, not image. My stomach was eating itself in those years. Stress ulcers, the kind a doctor describes with a straight face while telling you to "manage stress," like stress was a rowdy employee I could sit down for a talk. Cannabis stopped the burning. Cannabis didn't get me high. It got me *well*. And I did what I've always done with anything that works: I studied it. Not strain names and smoke-session trivia. The actual biology. The endocannabinoid system. The plant as a system with inputs and outputs. Which is how, some years and some hard lessons later, I ended up standing on raw dirt in Tehama County with YouTube professors and a plan.

Now come back to the land with me, because this is where everything I'm about to tell you happened.

Somewhere in the middle of those long days, hauling and hammering and learning, I caught myself doing something familiar. I was up before I had to be. I was running the same circuit of tasks in the same order, every day, adjusting one variable at a time and watching what changed. I was studying film at night, except the film was a stranger teaching me the next piece of the build. I was doing reps that nobody watched, keeping a score nobody else could see, pushing through soreness for a payoff that was months away. I stopped in the middle of a row one day, sweat in my eyes, and it landed on me all at once.

I was in the gym.

The ranch was my gym. The plants were my teammates. The harvest was my championship. Every skill basketball had

beat into me for 20 years showed up on that land wearing work boots. The discipline of daily practice. The obsession with getting one percent better. The ability to be alone with the work for hours and not go crazy. The refusal to skip a day, because skipped days show up later on the scoreboard whether anybody saw them or not. For the first time in my life, I was building something that was entirely mine. Mine mattered. Every team I'd ever played on belonged to somebody else, and every playbook I'd ever run was somebody else's playbook. On that land, if a thing stood, it stood because I raised it, and if a thing broke, I fixed it, and I'm telling you, both of those felt like the same privilege.

And I'll keep it a buck about the cost, because every win in this book comes with a receipt. It wasn't legal. Permits didn't exist yet. I paid for that season in risk, the kind that could have cost a man with my record everything, and when I built again later, I built it licensed and aboveboard in Oklahoma. So don't hear this as a weed story. The plant is not the point. The point is what happened to the athlete.

I had spent years grieving basketball like the best of me got buried with it. Then I stood in a greenhouse I raised with my own hands and realized nothing got buried. The game wasn't over.

The game had changed clothes.

* * *

The Principle: Same crate, different game.

Your game is going to end.

I don't care what your game is. The knee gives out. The plant closes. The industry packs up and moves. The store that had your name on the door goes dark. The kids you organized your whole life around walk across a stage and drive off. The body that could do the thing stops doing the thing. Every game ends, and the ending almost never asks your permission first.

I'm not saying that to scare you. I'm saying it because I've watched what endings do to people, and the ones who get wrecked all get wrecked the same way. They believed the game was the point.

The game was never the point. The game was the container.

Basketball did not make me disciplined. Basketball was where my discipline lived. Basketball did not make me competitive, or obsessive, or capable of practicing alone in the dark. It gave those muscles an address. And when the eviction came, I made the mistake almost everybody makes: I thought I was losing the muscles when all I was losing was the address. Read that again. The muscles were mine before the game and they stayed mine after it. The game just held them, the way a crate holds whatever gets dropped in it, and containers are replaceable in a way that contents never are.

Look at what actually came with me when the game left.

The reps muscle came with me. I knew how to show up every single day for work nobody claps for. There's no crowd in a greenhouse. There was no crowd for most of my practices as a kid either, and I'd been doing solitary reps since before I could spell the word practice. The farm didn't teach it to me. The farm just hired it.

So did the scoreboard muscle. Competitiveness doesn't retire when the season does. It needs somewhere to live, and if you don't give it a scoreboard, it will go find one on its own, and it will usually pick something dumb. Arguing with strangers on the internet. Keeping score against your cousin's car payments. Reliving 2007 for people who weren't asking. I gave mine a harvest instead. Weight, quality, yield, timeline. A scoreboard is a scoreboard. Your drive doesn't care what the numbers measure. It just needs numbers, and you'd better feed it good ones on purpose, because a starved scoreboard will feed itself junk.

Film study came with me too. An athlete who's watched film knows something most people never learn: performance is a system, and systems can be studied. A jump shot is inputs and outputs. So is a greenhouse. So is a business. So is software. I taught myself farming off YouTube the same way I'd learned opponents off game tape, and later I taught myself harder things the same way. You already know the rule. Be willing to be bad at it first. And before you tell me you never played a sport, understand that film study wears a hundred uniforms. If you ever worked a register long enough to predict the rush, or ran a household budget that had no

business balancing but balanced, or learned a supervisor's moods well enough to time your asks, you've watched film. You already know how to study a system until it gives up its secrets. All you're missing is a new opponent worth studying.

Then there's the bad-at-it-first muscle, and listen to me, this one might be the most valuable thing your old game ever gave you. Anybody who has ever been a beginner in public, missed in front of a crowd, gotten embarrassed and come back the next day, owns something the credentialed world can't sell. Starting before I'm ready and staying in it when I'm lost. That's my whole toolbox. It was built in one game and it has fed me in every game since.

Coachability came with me too, and I almost left it off the list because people confuse it with obedience. It's the ability to hear a true thing about yourself without dying. At my lowest point on a junior college bench, ready to quit, a teammate named Marvin Kilgore told me the truth to my face: I was too proud to ride the bench. It stung the way truth stings. It also saved my career, and it has saved every venture since, because every new game comes with a bench season, and the people who can't hear the truth about theirs never get off it.

Now here's what did NOT come with me, and you need to hear this part just as clearly. The trophies stayed behind. The status stayed behind. Nobody in Tehama County cared what I did in a gym in 2007. Not one plant grew faster because I used to be ranked. The muscle transfers. The medal doesn't. And the people who blow the transition are almost always trying to move the medal instead of the muscle. That's the guy at the

end of the bar telling strangers about high school. He's not lying about the highlights. He's just trying to spend currency from a country that doesn't exist anymore.

I want to sit with the grief for a minute, because the self-help shelf loves to skip this part and I won't.

Losing your game hurts. It's supposed to hurt. I mourned basketball like a person, because to me it was one. It raised me as much as anybody with a birth certificate claim on the job. If your game just ended, or ended ten years ago and you still feel the hole, I'm not going to clown you for grieving. Grieve. But hear the difference between two funerals. One funeral buries the game. The other buries the muscles with it. The first funeral is healthy. The second one is a robbery, and you're both the victim and the guy driving the getaway car.

Say this one out loud. Losing the thing you love most is not the end of your story. It is the middle. And the middle is where everything interesting happens.

People ask how long the grieving takes. I can't give you a number, and I won't pretend mine was quick. I'll give you a rule instead: grieve moving. Grief and reps can share a day. You can cry about the old game at nine in the morning and take the new game's first rep at ten, and neither one cancels the other. The grief that demands you sit still until it finishes isn't grief anymore. It's a stall wearing black.

Some people handle the ending by erasing. They burn the photos, dodge the old teammates, refuse to touch anything that smells like the old life. "That was another me." I understand the instinct. It's still amputation. You're not

cutting off the loss, you're cutting off the training. Reinvention doesn't require erasure. You don't start over. You re-aim. Everything you did in the old game was practice for a game you haven't seen yet, and you only get to keep the practice if you keep the practitioner. My jump shot still lives in my body. I don't apologize for the years that built it, including the ones that ended on an operating table. Every rep I ever took is still on my side. That's the deal you make with your past when you stop asking it to be your future.

There's a stretch I skipped between the dimming and the dirt, and I owe it to you, because the timeline is the lesson. Basketball didn't hand me the farm the next morning. Years sat in between, and they were some of the worst years of my life. The muscles didn't disappear in that stretch. They sat there unemployed, and unemployed muscles don't stay neutral. My discipline turned into brooding. My competitiveness went looking for opponents and found strangers. The fire kept burning with nothing productive to cook, and you already know my pattern from the first half of this book: anger in, consequences out. That's what the vacuum years bought me. I'm telling you about them for one reason. The space your game leaves behind will not stay empty. Something always moves in, and you either choose the tenant or the street chooses it for you. So when people ask how fast they should go find the next game, I tell them faster than feels respectful. Not because the grief doesn't deserve time. Because the muscles don't sit still while you grieve.

They freelance. And some of the jobs they take without your permission cost more than any ending ever did.

Let me flag the traps I've watched swallow people mid-transfer. First trap: the day-one comparison. Your new game will not feel like your old game felt, and it isn't supposed to. You were 20 years deep in the old one. You knew its smells, its rhythms, its people, its language. Of course year one of the new thing feels thin next to year 20 of the old thing. That's not a sign you chose wrong. That's arithmetic. Nobody falls in love with reps on the first rep. Give the new game long enough to show you whether your muscles work there, because that's the only question on the table. The feelings catch up behind the reps. Mine always have.

Respectable is the second trap. When a game ends, everybody in your life suddenly has a suggestion, and the suggestions are usually about what sounds good at church, not what runs on your muscles. I've watched born performers take quiet jobs because the title sounded stable, and I've watched builders die slow in meetings because somebody told them management was the next rung. Respectable is about other people's comfort. Resonant is about your crate. When the two line up, beautiful, take the job. When they don't, at least know exactly what you're trading.

Borrowed crates are the last trap. Your cousin's shape is not your shape. The internet is full of folks renting out their obsessions like they fit everybody, and a game that runs on muscles you don't have will keep you a beginner forever, with none of the compounding. My transfers worked because I

never chased another man's pattern. I ran mine through new arenas and let the arenas do the changing.

The farm proved the muscles transferred once. Then the muscles transferred again, and that second jump is the one that should interest you, because it proves this is a pattern and not a lucky bounce.

On the Oklahoma farm, my legal build, I ran into a problem. Growing at commercial scale lives and dies on a number called VPD, the math between temperature and humidity that tells you whether your plants are drinking the way they should. The commercial systems I could buy couldn't measure it the way I needed. The old me would have called that a dead end. The athlete-farmer me heard a whistle. I built my own sensor. And standing there holding a working thing I had made because the market wouldn't sell me one, I asked myself the question that rearranged the rest of my life: if I can build this, what else can I build?

That question became a rule. Any expense over \$20,000, we built it ourselves instead. Every problem was a product waiting to get built. The rule outgrew the farm, the way rules do, and in 2024 I started coding for real. Two years of shipping, not studying. I stacked certifications the way I used to stack game tape, because when the pedigree is missing, the receipts have to do the talking. And the wildest part is that it never felt like starting over, because it wasn't. I had been coding my whole life without calling it coding. Time to call it what it was.

Trace the whole line with me now. I didn't go from one to the other. I went from one through the other. Cannabis taught me how to build a business. Business taught me how to solve problems. Solving problems taught me how to code. Milk crate to floater. Raw land to greenhouse. Terminal to Togo. The tools change. The pattern does not. Three games deep on one set of muscles, and I'll tell you something I found out along the way: once you learn to build, you cannot stop building. The muscles don't want to retire. They want a schedule. And catch what the pattern means for you. If the muscles survived one ending, they will survive them all. The scariest ending of your life is the first one, because you don't have proof yet that you exist outside the container. After your first transfer, endings lose their teeth. I don't fear losing games anymore. I've walked out of more than one with the goods.

* * *

Now, finding yours. The method is simpler than you want it to be.

Your crate is the shape underneath all your obsessions. Not the obsessions themselves. The shape they have in common. Lay out everything you've ever gone all-in on, from childhood forward, and squint. On the surface, my list looks random: a ball, a plant, a codebase. Squint and the same shape sits under all of them. Take nothing and make something. Do reps alone until the reps compound. Keep a score. Ship the

result where people can see it. That's my crate. It was never basketball. Basketball was just the first thing I ran through it.

Yours will look random too. Maybe your list is a nursing career, a church kitchen, three rowdy grandkids, and the best-organized garage on your street. Squint. Maybe the shape is that broken things calm down around you. Maybe the shape is that every room you enter ends up gathered around your table. Maybe you're the one who explains things until the light comes on in somebody's face, and you've been that one since fourth grade. Maybe you turn chaos into a list, and you've never met a messy room you didn't quietly fix. The surfaces retire. The shape doesn't. You don't pick your crate. You notice it. It's been sitting in plain sight your whole life, holding one game after another, waiting for you to catch on.

If squinting doesn't do it, run the Saturday test. Go back to what you did as a kid when nobody assigned you anything. Not what you got signed up for. What you defaulted to. Left to myself, I shot on a crate until the streetlights came on, and in kindergarten my best friend Bradley and I harvested cafeteria napkins, stacked them like dollar bills, and counted our fortune every single day like two tiny accountants. Hooping and counting. Building and keeping score. The shape showed up before I lost my first tooth. Yours did too. Ask your mama what you did every Saturday morning when you were eight, and she'll describe your crate to you without ever knowing that's what she's doing.

I keep the evidence three feet from my desk.

In my office in California there's a milk crate. My office, present day, laptop and monitors and a man in his late thirties who types for a living. The crate sits there full of books. I don't play much anymore. So now the crate holds the other inheritance: I read, I study, I keep feeding the mind my daddy handed down. Same crate, different game. Clarksville knew him as a hustler. I knew the human calculator, the sharpest mind I've ever been around, and I say that without hesitation. The hoop was one thing he handed me. The mind was the other, quieter gift, and the same plastic crate has now carried both. Think about that. The crate went from milk to basketball to books and never once had an identity crisis about it. No farewell tour. No bitter phase. It just held what the house needed next. That crate has handled its career changes better than most grown men I know.

My daddy made a transfer of his own, and I didn't fully see it until I started writing this chapter. He rolled into Clarksville a stranger, his Memphis life closed behind him. The hustle didn't die in Memphis. It changed clothes. The same math brain that could count a money pile without counting it ran a kitchen, ran a domino table, ran every little side play that kept us fed. I'm not romanticizing the man's whole ledger, and Chapter 2 already handed you both columns. I'm pointing at the mechanism. His muscles moved with him. Muscles always do.

There's a book that says this better than I can. In *The Alchemist*, Paulo Coelho tells the story of a shepherd boy who sells his sheep and crosses a desert chasing treasure he

dreamed about, and after the whole ordeal, the treasure turns out to be buried back home, under the tree where he first had the dream. People read that as a story about travel. I read it as a story about inventory. The treasure was at home the whole time. Mine was. The crate was never about basketball. What my daddy nailed to the back of that house was a way of moving, and I have carried it into every arena I've entered since. The desert doesn't give you the treasure. The desert teaches you to recognize what was buried in your own yard.

That's why I don't flinch anymore when a game starts ending. I won't claim I like it. I'm saying I've stopped confusing the end of a container with the end of me. Somewhere in you there's a thing that has survived every version of your life so far. It survived the schools and the jobs and the moves and the losses, and it will survive this too. The fastest way to meet it is to lose a game and take inventory of what's still standing.

Now let me talk straight to you, the one whose game already ended.

Maybe it was a uniform. Maybe it was a title on a door, a company that folded, a plant that closed after you gave it 22 years, a body that used to do things on command. Maybe age took it slow or a phone call took it fast. The door the ending came through doesn't matter. What matters is the two questions you ask next, and most people never ask either one. First: what did that game actually train in me? Not what did it pay me, not what did it cost me. What did it train? Second: where does that training play now? Answer those two

questions honestly and the ending stops being a wall. It becomes a trade deadline. You're not done. You're changing teams.

I'll say a word straight to the athletes, because they find me the most. Somebody clocked you at 22 and told you the best part of your life was already over. They were describing the container, and about the container they were right. The milk ran out. Milk does. Nobody clocked the crate. The same discipline that made you all-conference will make you a problem, in the best way, in a sales bullpen, a trade school, a server room, a kitchen. The only athletes who never recover are the ones who spend their whole lives trying to get the old game back instead of asking what the old game trained.

And a word for the ones who gave a place 20 or 30 years before it closed on them. What you're grieving is real, and no book fixes it. But you didn't spend those decades earning a title. You spent them running 10,000 small systems that place couldn't run without you, and every one of those systems is a muscle with your name on it. The building kept the title. You kept the training.

Which brings me to the last move, and it might be the one that matters most, because it happens in your mouth before it happens in your life. Stop introducing yourself by your loss. The most dangerous syllable in the English language after an ending is "ex." Ex-athlete. Ex-manager. Ex-owner. The minute you lead with "ex," you've made the loss your employer, and that job pays nothing and never promotes you. Rename yourself by the muscle, not the sport. I don't tell people I'm an

ex-baller, and I don't tell them I'm an ex-cannabis guy either, even though both are technically true. I tell them I'm a builder. Builder was true on the dirt court, true on the farm, true in the code, and it'll be true in whatever game comes after this one. The sport was one address. The muscle is the resident. Introduce the resident.

Hand this gift to your people while you're at it. When your daughter quits the team, tell her what the team trained into her, so she walks away with cargo instead of a scar. When your boy loses the job, ask him what the job built before the world convinces him it built nothing. Most people go their whole lives without hearing their muscles named out loud. Be the one who names them. It costs you a sentence.

Then get a pen, because we're about to put this on paper.

Run It

You need a pen, real paper, and about 40 minutes without your phone. Write the date at the top of the page. This is the inventory nobody ever ran on you. You're about to run it yourself.

1. **List your games.** Write down every game you've ever been all the way in on, childhood forward. Not every job. Every obsession. The thing you did until the lights got shut off, the hobby that turned into a second language, the role you gave a decade to. Five to 10 entries. If one of them still stings to write down, write it down anyway. That sting is data.

2. **Extract the muscles.** Under each game, write the two or three specific capabilities it trained into you. Be exact or this doesn't work. Not "discipline," but "I can do boring reps every day with nobody clapping." Not "people skills," but "I can talk a stranger into something in five minutes." Not "organized," but "I can run a schedule for six people without dropping a ball." Now circle every capability that shows up under more than one game. Read what you circled. That repeating shape is your crate. Look at it for a minute. You've been carrying it your whole life. If you get stuck naming muscles, call the person who's watched you the longest and ask them. Other people can see your shape easier than you can. You're standing inside yours.
3. **List three new games.** Write three arenas, available to you in your actual current life, that run on the muscles you circled. Rules: at least one must cost nothing to start. At least one should scare you a little. None of them earn extra points for sounding respectable at a family reunion. You're matching muscles, not shopping for status. If your circled muscle is explaining things until the light comes on, your three might be tutoring, training new hires, or teaching what you know on camera. Match muscle to arena and ignore the rest.
4. **Schedule the first rep.** Circle ONE of the three. Put the first rep in your calendar within the next seven days: the day, the hour, how long. Keep it small enough that you can't

talk yourself out of it. One hour counts. And know the difference: a rep is doing the thing, not researching the thing. I built a farm off YouTube, so I love a tutorial, but those videos only counted because I walked outside afterward and got my hands dirty. Watch one video if you must. Then go outside.

5. **Rename yourself.** At the bottom of the page, write one sentence: "I am a ____." Fill the blank with the muscle, not the dead sport. Present tense. No ex, no former, no used-to-be. Tape it where you brush your teeth. The next time somebody asks what you do, lead with that sentence instead of the obituary, and pay attention to what it does to your own chest when you say it.

Keep the page. Date it, fold it, put it where you'll find it in a year. The games on that list will change again. The circles won't. And if you can't find 40 minutes for this, be honest with yourself about what that answer means. The crate only works for people willing to pick it up.

The Crate

The crate came into the world stamped for one job: carry milk. It carried the milk, and the milk ran out, and by every label on its side the crate was finished. Then a man with a hammer looked at it and saw a rim, and for years it held every shot a boy could throw at it. The boy grew, the game ended, and the crate should have been finished twice. Instead it sits three feet

from a desk, holding books, feeding a mind, working its third career without complaint. Nothing about the crate ever changed. Only the game did. You came stamped with labels too, and some of your milk has run out, and somebody may have already called you finished. They're reading the stamp. They can't see what you hold. Keep the crate. Change the game.

Chapter 11: Be There, Not Just in the House

The baby monitor sat on my desk for two years, right next to the keyboard.

I want you to hold that picture, because for a long time I thought it proved something good about me. There I was, a 37-year-old man teaching himself to code in a home office in Folsom, California. Wife in the next room. Daughter down the hall. Monitor glowing on the desk so I could hear my little girl breathe while I built our future one commit at a time. A man at home. A man providing. A man who, unlike his own daddy, was right there under the same roof as his family every single day.

That office produced. I'm not going to pretend it didn't. You got the totals earlier in this book, the worn-out computers, the 40-plus applications sitting live on the internet under my own name. By every scoreboard a builder keeps, that room was winning.

Now let me show you the invoice, because obsession always bills somebody, and the bill never comes addressed to the obsessed.

There was a stretch, six months, give or take, where I was spending too many hours in that office and not enough being Daddy. Follow the chain, because chains like this one are probably running in your house right now. Me in the office meant Cassidy was carrying more of Zuri than she should have been. Cassidy carrying more of Zuri meant her own work wasn't getting done during the day. Her work not getting done during the day meant she was staying up late every night finishing it while I sat one door away with the code.

Here's how I finally saw it. Not a blow-up. Not an ultimatum. Nobody slammed a door. I came out of the office late one more night and the kitchen light was still on, and there was my wife at her laptop, grinding through work that should have been done at two in the afternoon. Work that would have been done at two in the afternoon if I had been a father at two in the afternoon. I stood there and ran the math I'd been refusing to run for half a year: her late nights were my late nights, relocated. The house was quietly subsidizing the office, and the house never once sent me a bill.

That's the thing you have to understand about this particular debt. The people who love you absorb the cost before they ever mention the cost. Cassidy didn't file a complaint. She picked up the slack, because that's what love does, right up until it can't. By the time somebody in your house says something out loud, the interest has been compounding for months.

And I'll tell you the part that stung the most. I was becoming an absent man while sitting down the hall from my daughter, with her breathing piped straight to my desk in real time. I could hear my whole family. I just wasn't in it. That monitor let me feel present while I was gone. Technology is slick like that. It'll sell you the audio of your life so you can skip the attendance.

From inside the office, understand, none of it looked like neglect. It looked like sacrifice. That's the costume this thing wears. I wasn't at a bar. I wasn't running the streets. I was right there in the house, building products with our name on them, and every hour had a story I could tell myself. This app is her college fund. This client is our margin. This rep is the difference between me and every man who quit. Each story was even true, and that's exactly what makes it poison. Nobody in the history of the office has ever needed help justifying one more hour. The hours don't need a defense. They need a bedtime.

So I took a step back and got my priorities in order: husband first, Daddy first, code after. One sentence. It cost me real output and I'll get to that, because this book doesn't do wins without receipts. But I need you to know why I caught it at six months, because I want zero credit for the catch. The only reason I recognized what I was looking at is that I grew up inside the uncaught version, and I watched it run for decades.

* * *

The Principle: I didn't build all this to become another man who was in the house but not home.

* * *

My daddy was present in my life. I'll give him that. He was *there*. But he wasn't really there.

Understand what I mean, because the distinction is everything. The household was handled. Roof, food, safety, and God help whoever touched one of us. But he wasn't checking homework. He wasn't asking about my day. He wasn't showing up to games unless it was a championship. You already got the pickle story and the two-games-attended, two-titles, undefeated-as-a-spectator math earlier in this book. Now run the two-games math from the other direction: everything that wasn't a championship, he missed, and almost nothing is a championship. The man could sit at his domino table steps from our back door every afternoon at 4:30 and still be, for all practical purposes, somewhere else.

I'm not digging my father up to whip him. I've done the full audit on the man and both columns are long. I'm showing you the mechanism, because the mechanism almost got me, and it is coming for you. My daddy confused providing with being there. He hit every providing number a broke man could hit, and he genuinely believed, I'd bet anything, that the providing WAS the being there. Money where he could find it.

Food on the stove every Sunday. A hoop on the wall. In his mind, what else could a man owe?

Plenty. That's the answer. A man can go perfect on the provider scoreboard and still leave his kids raised by his absence.

Now, before anybody uses this page to put their broke father on trial, let me say something in defense of men like mine, because part of this deserves grace. When you're poor for real, providing takes everything. Every hour, every calorie of attention. Some parents are absent chasing a bigger boat. Some are absent keeping the water out of the one they've got, and those are not the same absence. If yours were the second kind, let the anger go and keep the lesson. But here's why I still can't hand the mechanism a full pardon: presence is the one thing poverty doesn't get to repossess. It would not have cost my daddy one dollar to ask me about my day. He had the hours. He was close enough to holler. What he didn't have was the software, because nobody had been there for him either. That's how this thing rides down a family line. Not as a decision. As a default.

Watch what the default installs in the kid, too, because this is the reason I opened with my six months instead of his decades. I never decided to become an office ghost. I defaulted to one. The blueprint I grew up studying was a working man in the house and out of reach, so when my turn came, too many hours behind a shut door didn't register as a betrayal. It registered as normal. Whatever your blueprint was, your hours are tracing it right now, and the tracing

doesn't announce itself. You have to catch it on paper. We'll get there.

* * *

Providing is the entry fee. Presence is the game. Most ambitious people, and I mean women grinding double shifts the same as men building companies, get those two backwards, and here's the mechanical reason why.

See, providing has a scoreboard. Bills paid is a number. Revenue is a number. Square footage, GPA you're funding, commits pushed at 2 a.m., all numbers. Presence has no scoreboard at all. Sitting on the floor at a tea party produces no metric. Nothing ships. Nothing posts. And builders go where the scoreboards are. It's in our wiring, it's what makes us dangerous at work, and it's exactly what makes the office beat the living room every single open hour, by default, unless you rig the game on purpose. I'll show you the rigging in a minute.

First I have to take apart the sentence that keeps the whole con running: "Everything I do, I do for this family."

I said a version of it. My daddy lived a version of it. You've probably got a version loaded right now. And it's half true, which is what makes it dangerous, because the half that's true buys cover for the half that isn't. Here's the test that cuts through it: while you're doing everything FOR them, what are they doing? They're doing life WITHOUT you. Dinner without you. Homework without you. The scary dream at 2

a.m. without you. “For” is how it looks from inside the office. “Without” is how it looks from every other room in the house. Same six months, two completely different books getting written, and your kid is only reading one of them.

And the cruelest part of the mechanism is who it selects to pay first. The bill goes to the strongest person in your house, because the strongest person is the one who can absorb it without buckling. In my house that was Cassidy. She carried the extra weight for six months and never once threw it at me, and I’d love to tell you that’s rare, but it’s the standard play. The people with the most love absorb the most cost, quietly, for the longest. The kids feel that something’s off but don’t have the words to bill you for it either. Which means the man in the office gets exactly zero warning shots. Silence is not a receipt that everything’s fine. Half the time, silence is the sound of somebody carrying your share.

Don’t think you need a startup or a second job to end up in the house but not home, either. The modern version fits in your pocket. Body on the couch, thumb on the screen, man somewhere in an argument on the internet. Your people can tell the difference between a parent in the room and a parent renting space in it. Kids especially. Kids don’t keep highlight reels of the big moments you starred in. They keep attendance records, and they will mark you absent with your body fully present.

If you want to know whether this is you, don’t ask yourself. You’re compromised. Check the mechanics instead. Where does your phone sit during dinner? Face up on the

table is an answer. When your kid starts a story that's going nowhere (kid stories are always going nowhere, that's what makes them kid stories), do you ride it all the way to the end, or do you make the uh-huh sounds while you finish a thought that pays better? When your wife talks to you from another room, do you move toward her voice or holler "what?" from the chair? Small mechanics. That's where presence actually lives, and that's where it quietly dies.

* * *

Now the fix, and I need you to hear it exactly, because it sounds cold and it's the warmest thing in this book.

Presence is a schedule, not a feeling.

You love your family. I know you do. Feeling the love costs nothing and runs constantly, like a pilot light. But nobody in your house can see a feeling. What they can see is attendance. Time, in blocks, with your phone in another room. Love, as experienced by the people you love, is mostly a calendar phenomenon. That's not romantic. Neither is rent.

Nobody plans to be absent, either. No man ever wrote "miss her whole childhood" on a whiteboard. Absence isn't a decision. Absence is what the calendar does when you leave it unsupervised, because work expands to fill every hour you don't defend. Money taught me a long time ago that the goalpost moves, that it's harder to stop making it than to start. Hours obey the same physics. There is always one more email, one more bug, one more client, and every one of them

comes with a scoreboard, which is more than your daughter's bedtime can say.

So you flip the order of eating. Most people put work in the calendar first and let the family have whatever's left, and what's left is a tired man at 9:40 p.m. asking a seven-year-old how school was, 11 hours after she wanted to tell him. Flip it. Put the people in first. Let the work eat what's left. The work is a better scavenger than your family will ever be; it will find the hours, believe me. Stephen Covey spent half a book on putting first things first, the big rocks in the jar before the gravel, and your people are the rocks.

I already know what some of you are thinking, because I thought it too: scheduling your own family feels cold. Love is supposed to be spontaneous. Sure it is, and how has spontaneous been performing at your house lately? Spontaneity is a luxury item for people with empty calendars, and you don't own one of those, and neither do I. Here's the reframe that got me right. The block is not the love. The block is the fence around the love. Inside the fence, be as spontaneous as you want. Wrestle, take the walk, burn the dinner, do absolutely nothing together on purpose. The fence just guarantees there's ground where spontaneity can happen. Tear the fence down and the office grazes that ground instead. The office always grazes.

Then defend the blocks like they're client meetings, because here's an ugly truth about people like us: we already have a category of appointment we never blow off. You would not no-show a paying client three weeks running.

You'd fire yourself first. But your son's slot gets bumped every time something comes up, and something always comes up, because bumping him is free. No invoice, no angry email. Just a kid quietly updating his attendance book. So move your family into the category you already respect. A block with their name on it can move inside the week if it has to. It cannot vanish from the week. Reschedule, maybe. Cancel, never.

While we're rigging the game, let me hand you the two numbers you're actually managing, because in a minute I'm going to make you count them. Every week of your life splits into hours in the house and hours home. In the house means under the roof: body present, door shut, mind elsewhere, phone doing the parenting. Home means available: reachable without an appointment, interruptible without a sigh. Most people have never once counted the second number, and they're walking around with a guess that flatters them. I was walking around with one. My guess said I was home plenty. The kitchen light at midnight said otherwise, and the kitchen light had the receipts.

One more trap before I tell you about the best two months of my life: "it's just a season." Maybe it is. Seasons are real, and there are stretches, a launch, a harvest, a bar exam, where the house genuinely has to carry you for a while. But a season has a printed end date. A season with no end date is a lifestyle wearing a costume. If you're in one right now, do the one thing a real season allows: put the end on paper where your people can see it. I can tell you the difference from both sides,

because I've lived both. Oklahoma was a season. It had a finish line Cassidy and I drew together, and when the line came, I crossed it and went home. The six months in the code office was not a season, and I can prove it with one fact: nobody had ever seen an end date, including me. That's your test. If your family can't name the day the sprint ends, you're not in a season. You're in a pattern with good PR.

* * *

Two months before Zuri's due date, I came home.

Packed up Oklahoma, drove back to California, and turned my attention from building greenhouses to building a nursery. Baby-proofing the house. Assembling a crib. Buying things I did not know existed on this earth. A wipe warmer. Babies need their wipes *warmed*? Apparently they do, and apparently I'm the man in aisle seven reading the box like it's a term sheet.

For two months, I was just a husband. Present. Available. Walking Cassidy through the last stretch of a pregnancy. It was the first time in years I wasn't grinding toward something, and I have to be honest with you about how it felt: strange. Itchy. Like a car idling in the driveway with a full tank.

And being there, I realized, was its own kind of work. The hardest kind.

I mean that literally. Sixteen-hour days on the farm were easier for me than sitting still in the right room, because farm

days end with something you can look at. Presence ends with nothing you can look at. No harvest, no deploy, no scoreboard. For a man wired like me, work with no scoreboard barely registers as work, which is exactly why I'd been dodging it my whole adult life without knowing I was dodging anything.

Then Zuri came, and the hospital kept Cassidy a few extra days to recover from the C-section, and my wife looked at me and told me to take our three-day-old daughter home and start the routine. By myself.

I drove home at approximately 11 miles an hour, checking the rearview every four seconds. Got home. Closed the front door. Looked at Zuri. She looked at me. Just us. A grown man from Clarksville, Arkansas, and a brand-new girl from Folsom, California, and no manual for either one of us.

Those first nights alone with her are some of the most important nights of my life, and here is their entire highlight reel: I fed her. I changed her. I held her when she cried. I watched her sleep and counted her breaths like each one was a small miracle, because it was. Nothing dramatic happened. The most important nights of my life were important BECAUSE nothing dramatic happened. That is the résumé of presence. It never reads like much. It just turns out to be the thing everybody remembers when they total up a childhood.

And somewhere in that quiet I found the thing I'd been chasing through every gym and every grind since I was four years old. Peace. Not the absence of noise. Not the absence of

stress. Real peace. I was supposed to be right here. Holding this baby. Being this father. Living this life.

I'm telling you about those nights for one reason. Presence will never produce anything you can post. If you need visible output to feel like your time counted, the office will beat the nursery every day of the week, and you will optimize yourself right out of the best nights of your own life. The only fix is to decide, on purpose, in advance, that the invisible thing counts. And then schedule it like it counts.

What counts changes shape as your people grow, by the way, but the law underneath never does. A newborn needs you counting breaths at 3 a.m. A three-year-old needs you on the floor, all the way down on the floor, being served invisible tea like it's real. A teenager needs something sneakier: availability at the odd hours, because teenagers don't talk on schedule, they talk at 11:15 p.m. in the car, and you have to already be there when the window opens. A spouse needs attention with no agenda stapled to it, time that isn't the leftover scraps of your best energy. Different shapes. Same law. None of it can be phoned in, and all of it goes to whoever's actually in the room.

* * *

There's a second half to this principle, and it's the half that separates the men who white-knuckle it from the ones who actually build a home: stop building past your people and start building with them.

Before Oklahoma ever broke ground, Cassidy drew me a line. “When you do this project, I have no interest in moving to Oklahoma. For any period of time.” Now, a younger me hears that as a lack of faith. The me who’d already paid tuition on a decade of losses heard it as what it was: a design constraint from the most honest person on my cap table. So I didn’t build the marriage around the company. I built the company around the marriage. Fly-in leadership, point A to point B, a real finish line on the calendar. That agreement gave me something ambition never gives anybody on its own: an end.

I’ll be straight about the limits of my record out there, too, because intensity doesn’t only bill your family. It bills everybody standing near you. On that farm I assumed the whole crew could run at my pace, and I pushed harder when I probably should have paused and checked in. Some of those guys wore down and checked out, and a piece of that is mine to carry. The same man who ghosts his living room will grind his people into the ground and call it standards. If you run hot, and if you’re still reading this book you probably do, the presence problem doesn’t stop at your front door. Check the pulse of every room you lead.

These days the construction runs even closer to the house than that. Zuri is three. No preschool, no babysitter. Me and Cassidy raise her ourselves, every day, all day, and I am in full girl dad mode. The tea parties. The dress-up. *Frozen* on repeat until I can recite every line in my sleep, and I’m not going to lie to you and say the songs haven’t grown on me. That

arrangement has a price and I'll name it straight: it costs output. I would ship more code from a monastery. I am never going to live in a monastery. Trade accepted, every morning, eyes open.

And when the tech industry finished ghosting me and it came time to build the next thing, I didn't disappear into another office to build it despite my wife. We built it together. Caipher Studio. Me on code, Cassidy on business, and when the first client's check cleared, that wasn't my win to carry down the hall and show her. Our first win. Cassidy's and mine, together. Learn the difference between building FOR your people and building WITH them. "For" leaves them outside the thing that owns you, holding the bag and waving at your taillights. "With" hands them the pen. Same ambition. Completely different house.

Fatherhood rewired the underlying math, too, and I'd be leaving money on the table if I didn't show you the wiring. Before Zuri, I was building for myself, and the fuel was mostly spite. Every hustle was York against everybody who ever counted me out. Spite is not sustainable, and it points you at the office by default, because the office is where the proving happens. Then Zuri came, and now every decision runs through one filter: what kind of world am I building for her? Ask that question about an ordinary Tuesday night and watch what it does to your calendar. A man proving a point works late. A man building a world for somebody goes and sits on the floor at the tea party, because the tea party is the world.

I'll give you one more, and it's my favorite, because it proves presence can be engineered across any distance you can name. Cassidy and I got married on October 11, 2021. October 11 is my daddy's birthday. That was on purpose. He was there the only way he could be. Sit with that for a second. I found a way to schedule a dead man into my wedding. You can find a way to schedule your living daughter into your Tuesday.

Because here's what all of it adds up to, the boundary and the tea parties and the studio and the date on the marriage license. I told you earlier in this book about the nights we slept with our shoes on as kids, ready to move. In my house, nobody sleeps with their shoes on. Nobody's braced. That's what home actually is. Not the address where your family lives. The place where nobody has to brace, because the man who said he'd be there is where he said he'd be.

* * *

Before I put the pen in your hand, let me clear out the three ways people take this principle and bend it wrong.

The first wrong turn is batching. The Disney World play. A man goes months as a ghost, feels the guilt pile up, and tries to settle the account with one giant deposit: the big vacation, the grand gesture. And listen, take the trip, make the memory. But presence doesn't accept lump sums. It runs on drip. Ten minutes a night at the kitchen table with your phone in another room will outperform a week at a resort with your

face in your email, because your kid isn't pricing the experiences. She's counting the days you showed up. Three hundred ordinary nights beat five magical ones and it isn't close. And the drip pays compound interest in a direction you can't see from here. The kid who gets the nightly ten minutes grows into a teenager who still talks to you at the table, because the channel never closed. You're not buying tonight with tonight's ten minutes. You're buying age 15. You're buying the phone call at 22. You're buying the version of the future where your grown child calls you on purpose, and no vacation package sells that.

Wrong turn number two is the guilt spiral. Some of you are reading this with a brick sitting on your chest because you've been the office man, or the office woman, for years, and you're hearing all this as a verdict. It's not a verdict, and I can prove it with my own family. My daddy went decades in the house but not home, and I still built half a book around the man, because the attendance he did give me counted, and because I came to understand what he was carrying and what he'd never been handed. Your people are at least that generous, and they're grading on a curve you can still move. The attendance book has blank pages left in it. You don't fix years of absence with a speech, and please don't try, because announcing the new you is just one more performance. Announce nothing. Start marking yourself present, this week, in small blocks, and keep doing it until the calendar makes your argument for you. Your people will believe a pattern long before they believe a promise.

The third wrong turn is the overcorrection, and I want to slam this door hard, because self-help loves to swing an axe where a screwdriver goes. This chapter is not telling you to shrink. Read my sentence again: husband first, Daddy first, code after. AFTER is a real word. The code still got written. The apps still shipped, the clients still got served, and I still enrolled in the degree. I didn't quit the work. I reordered the work, and here's the piece nobody tells you: the work got sharper. When Zuri owns the early evening, the late session has a blade on it, because a hard stop is the best project manager alive. Ambition was never the enemy. Unsequenced ambition is the enemy. Your family doesn't want a smaller you. They want the same dangerous, building, dreaming you, showing up in the right order. Get the order right and you don't lose the builder. You lose the ghost.

Run It

This one is called the Presence Audit. It takes one week, one pen, and more honesty than you'll want to spend. Do it on paper, and put dates on everything, because a dated page is a witness and your memory is a defense attorney.

1. **Run the log for seven days.** One sheet, two columns: IN THE HOUSE and HOME. "In the house" means under the roof: body present, attention elsewhere, office door shut, phone in hand at dinner. "Home" means available: phone in another room, door open, doing something with your people or where they can interrupt you without an

appointment. Every night before bed, write the honest hour counts in each column. Don't fix anything yet. Week one is surveillance, not repair. Expect the first column to bury the second, and know that the log is usually kind compared to what the family would report.

2. **Ask the question.** Sometime this week, ask each person you love one question: "When do you feel like you have me?" Then close your mouth and write the answer down word for word. No defending. No explaining. No "yeah, but." The answers will be small and specific, and some will sting. A kid will name something that costs you 15 minutes. A spouse will name something you quit doing three years ago without noticing. Every answer is intel, and it's worth more than anything in this book, because it came from your actual house.
3. **Build the standing blocks.** Take those answers and put one recurring block per person into your real calendar, with the person's name, the what, and the when: "Floor time, 6:00." "Thursday night, no phones." Then defend each block at the client-meeting standard: it can move inside the week, it cannot vanish from the week. Keep the blocks small enough to survive. Thirty minutes that always happens beats a Saturday that sometimes happens, every single time. And tell each person their block exists. A block works double once they know about it, because now it's a promise with a witness.

4. **Write your order.** One sentence, your version of mine: husband first, Daddy first, code after. Name your people ahead of your work, in sequence, in your own words. Date it. Sign it. Tape it where you work, at eye level, so it's staring at you at the exact hour you're most likely to steal from them.
5. **Re-run the log in 30 days.** Mark the date on the calendar now. Same sheet, same two columns, same seven days. Compare the numbers. Your feelings will tell you you've changed. My feelings swore I was fine for six months straight. Believe the log. The log has no reason to lie to you, which makes it the only party in this exercise you can fully trust.

The Crate

My daddy nailed a crate to the wall and went back in the house. That was the shape of his love, and I've spent this whole book telling you it was enough to build me. It was. Nails are real love. But I've stood in that backyard a thousand evenings, and I can tell you what the crate never did. It never watched. It fed the fire and missed every shot. So keep the crate, all of it: build for your people, provide, maintain, replace what cracks without complaint. And then do the one thing the crate couldn't do and my daddy wouldn't. Stay in the yard. The hoop teaches the shot. The witness teaches the kid that the shot matters. Build the hoop. Then stay for the game.

Chapter 12: Leave Them the Ocean

In the spring of 2018 my phone rang, and my father said, “Son, you really need to come home this time.”

You need to understand who was talking. York Sims Sr. did not ask for things. I had heard that man declare, dare, negotiate, cook, and provide for 31 years, and I had never once heard him ask me for anything. And this sentence had two small words riding on the end of it. This time. Which meant there had been other times, other calls, other soon's, and he knew it, and he knew I knew it. He wasn't asking me to visit. He was telling me the clock had run out on soon.

I went home.

The house filled up the way Southern houses fill up when somebody's dying. Aunts in the kitchen, uncles on the porch, cousins appearing from three states, and food arriving from everywhere, because in my family, grief and gravy ride in the same car. My father lay in the middle of all of it, and everybody took turns sitting with him.

Two days before he died, it was my turn, and I decided not to spend it on weather talk. My whole life I had listened to that man. What I had never done, one time, in three decades

as his son, was ask him what he wanted. So I pulled my chair close to the bed and I asked him the real questions, the kind you only get a few chances in a whole life to ask.

What do you wish you'd done differently. What do you wish you'd seen. What do you wish you'd done.

My father took the questions seriously. He took his time. And the answer that came back was not about money, and it was not about business, and it was not about any of the things I would have bet on.

He wished he could have seen the ocean.

Not seen it again. Seen it. My father was born in Webb, Mississippi. He survived Memphis. He landed in Clarksville, Arkansas, and he lived and worked and cooked and provided for decades, and in all of that time the man never stood on a single beach. Never watched a wave come in. Never got his feet wet in saltwater. The ocean was out there the whole time, a tank of gas and a long day away, and for his entire life it might as well have been the moon.

"He gave us everything he had, and what he had wasn't enough to ever see the ocean."

I wrote that sentence years later, and it is still the truest accounting of my father I know how to give. Everything he had came down the line to us. The food, the tools, the hoop, the code. He never saved anything for himself. Early in this book I told you what poverty takes after it finishes with your wallet. It takes your horizon. Sitting next to that bed, I watched that stop being a line I say and become my father's face.

There wasn't one thing I could do about it, and that's the part that had me by the throat. I had hustled up money before. I had solved problems that had no business being solvable. This one had no move. The ocean wasn't coming to Arkansas, and he wasn't leaving that bed. All I could do was sit there and hold the answer he'd given me.

Two days later, he was gone.

* * *

The Principle: Your past is not a prediction. It is a preparation.

* * *

Deathbeds run on stories. While my father was dying, the kitchen stayed full of his brothers, and the stories ran day and night, and that week I learned two things about him that 31 years under his roof had never shown me.

The first one explained the cooking. You already know about the white towel and the Sunday pots. What I learned at his deathbed was where they came from. As a boy in Mississippi, my daddy, Bing to his people, stole beans and rice so his little brothers and sisters could eat, and he learned to cook because feeding people was his job long before it was ever his joy. "It wasn't a gift. It was survival." Every meal that man ever made us was an act of love that started in poverty and ended on our plates. My whole life I thought my father had a talent. He didn't have a talent. He had a scar that

learned to feed people. A talent gets shown off. A scar gets handed down quietly, dressed up as skill, and if nobody ever tells you the story behind it, you'll go your whole life thinking the man was just good with a pot.

And the second one, my Uncle Rusty dropped like it was nothing: "your daddy used to be a *hell* of a basketball player. Until he got that hip injury."

I stood in that kitchen doing arithmetic I'd never had a reason to do. The man who knocked the bottom out of a milk crate and nailed it to plywood for his four-year-old had been a hooper. A real one, until his hip took the game away. And through my entire career, the championships, the rankings, the headlines, the surgeries, all of it, he never said one word about his own game. Not one story. Not one "back in my day." Not one correction of my form delivered in that tone men use when they're really talking about themselves. He watched his son chase the exact thing his own body had stolen from him, and he never once made my chase carry his loss.

"He never led with his own story." He just built us the tools and let us figure it out.

Some inheritances come with the giver's name engraved on the side. The best ones come anonymous. My father had been preparing me my whole life with materials I didn't even know he had, and I didn't find the receipts until he was two days from gone.

Do yourself a favor while you still can. Look at the people who raised you and ask what their skills cost them. The

cooking, the sewing, the ability to stretch a check to payday, the way your mother reads a room in half a second flat. Some of what looks like personality is preparation somebody paid for in a childhood you never saw. You are surrounded by receipts nobody has read out loud. Go ask for the stories underneath the skills. I got mine with two days to spare.

* * *

We lost my cousin Richard on May 5. We lost my father on May 6. We lost my Aunt Viola the day after that. Three funerals in three days. The family argued about where to bury him, because grief doesn't make a family gentler, it makes it louder, and that's all I'm going to say about that.

May 6. If that date itches at you, it should. It's the same date the fire took our first house when I was five. My life keeps appointments on May 6 whether I make them or not.

Nobody tells you this about losing your father: the grief doesn't hit all at once. The funeral comes with a program and a schedule, and the schedule holds you upright like a back brace. The real grief comes later. "It hit me the first time I reached for the phone to call a number that nobody would ever answer again."

Here's what I did with mine.

You know what Budweiser meant in my house growing up. The good-week beer. The we're-doing-fine beer. So for the first couple of years after he died, on his birthday and on May 6, I drove to the ocean. I stood where the water comes in, and

I drank a Budweiser for him. His beer. Not mine. I took my time with it, and when it was done, I didn't throw the can away. I carried it back to the car and took it home. I kept every one. There's four of them now.

Four empty beer cans on a shelf in my office, and I know exactly what they are. They are the only piece of the ocean my father ever got. He couldn't come to the water, so I carry him there, one can at a time, and I bring the evidence home.

You already know from last chapter that Cassidy and I got married on his birthday. My family keeps its dates on purpose.

I'm telling you about the cans for a reason. Grief needs a container, or it floods the whole house. A feeling fades and then calls itself healing. A standing appointment doesn't fade. If you've lost somebody, stop waiting until you feel like honoring them, because the feeling is unreliable and the calendar is not. Pick the date. Pick the place. Keep it like a game day.

If ritual sounds soft to you, look at what it's made of: a date, a place, a repeatable act, a receipt you keep. That's operations. Nobody ever taught my father a container for what he carried, so he used the ones he had, a kitchen, a domino table, a beer. The scheduled Budweiser at the water is me taking one piece of his script, the beer itself, and giving it a better job. Same can, different work.

Now for the part that's about you, because everything in this book eventually is.

The world reads your past like a prediction. Every system you will ever touch is betting that you'll repeat yourself. The background check isn't curious about what you learned; it's forecasting. The credit score is a forecast. The felony box is a forecast. The algorithm feeding you the same stuff you clicked last year is a forecast. And it's never only systems. Hometowns forecast. Families forecast. There's a cousin at every gathering issuing forecasts free of charge. Worst of all, you do it to yourself. You read your own record and publish your own weather report: this is who I am, because this is who I've been.

A prediction and a preparation read the same file. That's what makes this sneaky. Same record, same rap sheet. The prediction reads it and tells you what you're going to do. The preparation reads it and tells you what you're now equipped for. One verb apart, a whole life apart. And I'll tell you which reading feels safer, because I've lived in both. The prediction feels safer. A prediction asks nothing of you. It lets you sit inside a story you already know the ending to and call that realism. Preparation puts a bill in your hand, because if the past was training, then somewhere out there is the game it trained you for, and you're supposed to go play it.

I wrote one sentence at the end of my memoir that I believe harder than almost anything else I've ever put on paper, and I

have been walking you toward it for 11 chapters. Your past is not a prediction. It is a preparation. "Everything that happened to me, every fight, every arrest, every betrayal, every broken bone and broken promise, was preparing me for something I couldn't see yet." And the part I need you to carry out of this book with you: "Nothing was wasted. Not a single moment. Especially the bad ones."

Run my tape if you doubt it. A milk crate prepared me to build with whatever's in reach. A statewide ban and a chicken line prepared me to work with nobody clapping. My felonies prepared me to run a licensed cannabis company, because I knew that plant and that system from the wrong side first. "The same plant, the same product, the same high, but a different zip code and a different skin color meant the difference between a prison sentence and a business license." A \$25,000 concert prepared me to verify everything myself. The betrayals prepared me to put paper on every deal. The rejection emails prepared me to stop auditioning and build with my wife instead. Eleven chapters of receipts. One pattern.

And if you want to know how far the principle stretches, stretch it over this chapter. The worst afternoon of my life was the one next to that bed, holding an answer I couldn't fix. Even that was preparation. The afternoon became the ritual, the ritual became the promise, the promise became my daughter's beaches, and all of it together became the pages you're reading right now. I'm not glad it happened. I'm telling you nothing was wasted, including the afternoon that broke

me. If the principle can hold that one, it can hold whatever you're carrying.

Three warnings, though, because this principle gets mishandled all the time.

First: preparation is not automatic. The same past that prepares one man buries the man standing next to him, and the difference isn't luck. It's extraction. Raw material does not refine itself. You wrote tuition rules out of your losses back in Chapter 8, and that's the machine that turns a past into a preparation. If you skipped that work, this chapter can't save you. Go back.

Second: calling your past preparation is not the same as calling it good. My record prepared me, and the system that hung it on a teenager was still wrong. Hold both. You're allowed to extract every ounce of value from a thing and still stand up in court against it. Redemption doesn't require amnesia.

Third, and this is the one that connects back to the man in the bed: the deadliest predictions are the ones that get installed inside you. My father's ocean wasn't a road problem. The trip was drivable. What wasn't drivable was the distance between what poverty had told him was for him and what actually was. Poverty makes its forecast early: men like you don't get horizons, you get obligations. He took the forecast as fact. Someday quit being a plan, then it quit being a comfort, and then it became a thing he said out loud exactly once, two days from the end, because his son finally asked. That's what

a swallowed prediction does. It doesn't kill you. It just quietly cancels your trips.

* * *

Stephen Covey had a name for what I decided to become instead. In *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People*, Covey writes about the transition person: the one member of a family line who stops a damaging script from being passed to the next generation, who catches what got thrown at them, the temper, the absence, the addiction, the small horizons, and refuses to throw it forward. He counted that among the most important work a human being can do. So do I. It's the only title I've ever wanted that can't fit on a business card.

Three generations of men in my family never met their grandchildren. Read that again. Three generations. Nobody drew that play up on purpose. Nobody had to. A script like that hands itself down at funerals, quiet as a folded flag. When Zuri was born, I said it out loud: "The pattern stops with me."

Here's what people get wrong about the job. They think it runs on contempt. They think breaking the family script means burning the family down, listing your parents' failures in chronological order, and calling the bitterness boundaries. I understand the temptation. But if you break a script out of hatred, the script is still giving the orders. The old man is still your compass. You've only flipped which end of the needle you follow.

I started there myself, so no judgment. “I refused to be that person. At first out of spite. Eventually out of love.” Spite got me moving. Love is what made it permanent. Because here’s what that kitchen full of uncles taught me: the man who handed me a small-horizon script was the same man who stole beans and rice so children could eat, built his son a hoop out of a milk crate, and kept his own dead basketball dream in his pocket his whole life so it would never weigh on mine. You can audit a man’s lessons and love him with your whole chest at the same time. If you built your ledger back in Chapter 2, you already know which parts of your inheritance you’re keeping and which ceiling has your name on it. The transition person is that ledger standing up and walking around.

People imagine the job comes with a dramatic scene, some table-pounding declaration at Thanksgiving. It almost never does. Being the transition person mostly looks boring from the outside. It looks like the first passport in the family. The first sober holiday. The first apology a child in your line ever hears come out of a grown man’s mouth. The first argument your kids ever watch that ends with two adults still in the same room, still talking. Nobody claps for any of it, because the script you broke is invisible to everybody who never had to live under it. The greatest thing you ever do may look, to the people watching, like nothing happened at all. Let it look like nothing. You’ll know what it took.

And I won’t pretty up the cost. When you refuse a script, the people still running it can hear your refusal as a verdict on

their lives. Some of them will say you think you're better now. Some of them will wait on you to fail so the old forecast can be right. You don't argue with any of it. Arguing is just the script trying to get you back on the payroll. You break it quietly, daily, in front of witnesses too young to know they're witnesses. The pay for this job is real, but it's deferred, and it deposits into an account that belongs to somebody else. That is the whole point. This code, all 12 rules of it, aims at a handoff. A code that dies with you was never a code. It was just a personality.

Look at how my father did his. He couldn't say his code out loud, that wasn't in him, so he built it into things. A hoop. A pot. A swept parking lot. A question asked once and honored forever. The handoff doesn't require a speech. It requires a habit, a tool, a promise kept where small eyes can see it. What you've figured out was never only yours. You're just the one holding it between generations.

* * *

Which brings me to the title of this chapter, and to your ocean.

Your ocean is the specific thing your people never got that you are going to put in reach of the people coming after you. Specific is the load-bearing word. My father's ocean was the literal ocean: water, sand, salt, a horizon with nothing man-made on it. Yours might be a passport with stamps in it. A last name called out loud at a graduation. A house nobody can put your family out of. A childhood where no kid learns to sleep

in their shoes. A little girl who never goes quiet when the power clicks off mid-cartoon, because nobody ever taught her what that click means. Some oceans cost money. Some cost habits. Every one of them gets measured the same way: something that was never in reach, put in reach.

One warning about picking yours: the ocean is for them, so keep your highlight reel out of it. There's a version of this exercise that goes wrong, where a man picks a flex and calls it a legacy. A bigger truck is not an ocean. Courtside seats are not an ocean. The test is simple. Does the thing end a script, or does it decorate one? My daughter standing in saltwater ends a script that ran through my family for generations. A designer stroller parked next to her would decorate the same beach and correct exactly nothing. Money can carry a correction. Money can also do an impression of one, and the impression photographs better. Check which one you're funding.

Finding yours takes listening. The deferred wish leaks out of people in small talk if you pay attention. It hides inside "I always wanted to" and "we never could," and in the way somebody's voice drops half a step while they're looking at somebody else's vacation photos. My father's wishes hid in plain sight for decades. The man cooked for the whole neighborhood every Sunday and never got the restaurant. I watched it happen and didn't see it, because kids read their parents as furniture, permanent and settled, instead of as people running out of time.

Here's something else about oceans: you've probably already made one of these promises without ever naming it. I told you in the introduction about the backseat where I learned there were two Americas, watching a friend's mother hand over \$20 for a t-shirt without blinking. What I didn't tell you is what I did with that moment. Sitting in that backseat, I made a quiet vow: one day, my kids were going to ask for twenty dollars and I was going to hand it to them without thinking twice. I was a kid myself. I had no language for generational corrections. I just knew what I intended to put in reach. That vow ran silent underneath decades of my hustle before I ever wrote it down. Somewhere in you there's probably one like it, made in a backseat or a waiting room or a checkout line where you watched your mother count change. This chapter is where it stops running silent.

Listening is the slow way, though. The fast way is asking. Ask the questions I asked my father, and ask them early. What do you wish you'd done differently. What do you wish you'd seen. What do you wish you'd done. I got my father's truth two days before the end, which was soon enough to hear it and too late to do anything about it for him. A deathbed will make people honest, but a deathbed is late. A kitchen table works better, and the questions taste the same there. Ask while the answer can still become a plane ticket instead of a shelf of cans. And know that two things happen when you ask. You find your ocean. And the person answering gets witnessed while they're still alive to feel it, which might be the last real gift a grown child has to give.

Hear me on one more thing: some oceans are free. Presence was one of mine, and it got its own chapter. Not every correction is a purchase. But every correction is a decision, and a decision that stays in your head has the life expectancy of my father's beach trip.

* * *

I want to tell you how my promise started, because it didn't start at a desk.

A few years after my father died, I was driving the dirt road out to my farm in Oklahoma when I looked over and saw a baby in my passenger seat. I know how that sounds. I'm telling you what happened. A laughing baby girl with a head full of curls, riding shotgun like she'd been there the whole trip. When it passed, I realized my face was wet. I'd been crying and never noticed I started. I called Cassidy right there from the road.

"You ain't pregnant, are you?"

"No."

All right then. I chalked it up to long days and dirt roads. Two weeks later I came home to California, and Cassidy handed me a shoebox that weighed nothing. Inside was a pair of peach gym shorts, and underneath them, a pregnancy test with two lines on it. She had known since the day I called her from that dirt road. She sat on the biggest news of our lives just so she could hand me a box and watch my face. There is

video of me going absolutely insane, and no, you can't see it. "The vision wasn't a hallucination. It was a preview."

People ask me how fatherhood changed me. "The real answer is: it didn't change me. It *completed* me." My entire childhood I'd been taking notes on fatherhood, and most of them were notes on what to never do, and it turns out those count double. "I'd been training for this role for thirty six years." Every chapter you've read in this book is a page out of the training log. Even the anger counted, once it stopped being the engine. Spite will get you out of bed, but you cannot raise a daughter on it. "Zuri gave me something to run toward."

I can tell you the exact moment I knew the preparation had landed. You stood in it with me a chapter ago: the first nights at home alone with a three-day-old, counting breaths in the dark. A man built out of sirens and buzzer-beaters sat still in a quiet room and felt, for the first time in his life, peace. Every explosion I'd ever survived turned out to be tuition for one quiet room.

So I made my daughter a promise, and I built it the way this book has taught you to build everything: specific, present tense, with a name in it. Zuri gets the oceans. Every beach I can get her to, as early and as often as I can get her there, until saltwater is so normal to that child that the sentence "he never saw the ocean" will need explaining. Her great-grandfathers never met their grandchildren. Her grandfather never met her, and never saw a wave. My father saved nothing for himself and never stood on sand, and his granddaughter is

going to lose count of beaches. I call it what it is. Not a vacation plan. A correction. “A generational correction, decades in the making.”

Zuri is three now. She has two hoops, one inside the house and one outside, and a shot with real form on it already, which nobody her size has any business having. My job these days is rebounds. Best job I ever had. There’s one more scene in this book with her in it, and I’m saving it for the last page, because it’s the best thing I own and you’re almost there.

One more thing before the pen comes out. I gave you the Gail Matthews study back in Chapter 3, the Dominican University research showing that people who write their goals down achieve significantly more than people who carry them in their heads. In Chapter 3 that was about goals, and it was useful. Here it’s about wishes, and it’s heavier. My father carried his ocean in his head for an entire lifetime, and it surfaced exactly once, two days from the end, because one person finally asked him a real question. Unwritten wishes wait. Written promises move. I don’t lean on the study anymore. I’ve stood at both endings, and I keep the cans from one of them on a shelf.

Run It

This one is called the Promise. You need a pen, real paper, one quiet hour, and, if you still can, one conversation. Write today’s date at the top of the page.

1. **Ask upstream.** This week, get to the oldest person in your line you can reach. In person beats the phone, and the phone beats nothing. Ask them the three questions: What do you wish you'd done differently? What do you wish you'd seen? What do you wish you'd done? Then go quiet and write the answers down word for word. Don't fix anything. Don't rush in to reassure. And don't say "you still could" unless you intend to be the one who makes it happen. If everyone upstream of you is already gone, write down the thing you know they never got. You know what it is. You've always known.
2. **Write the Promise.** One sentence. Present tense, today's date on it, a name in it. The formula: name gets the specific thing your people never got. Mine is "Zuri gets the oceans." Yours has to be concrete enough that a stranger could check whether it came true. "My kids get a better life" fails that test. "My daughter graduates with no debt" passes. "My mother sees the country she left at 19" passes. "Nobody in my house ever learns what an eviction notice looks like" passes. If your sentence sounds like a greeting card, keep sharpening until it sounds like a delivery date.
3. **Name both ends.** Under the promise, write two names: the person upstream who never got the thing, and the person downstream who will. If the downstream person isn't born yet, write "whoever comes after me" and mean it. A promise with names on it has witnesses. A goal without names is a mood.

4. **Post it where you live.** Copy the sentence by hand and put it where you'll see it every single day. Bathroom mirror. Dashboard. The inside of the front door. The lock screen if you must, but paper first. Understand what you're doing here: the world has been posting its forecast about you your whole life, and this is you posting yours over it. Daily sight is the whole method.
5. **Make the first move this week.** Not the whole correction. The first move, with a date on it: the savings account opened, the class enrolled, the passport application printed, the trip priced to the dollar, the call made. Small counts. A promise without a first move is just a wish with better handwriting, and this chapter showed you where unwritten wishes end up.

Keep the page from step one, the answers in their own words. Fold it up with the promise and keep them together. The day the promise comes true, you're going to want them side by side, and you're going to want to be sitting down when you read them.

The Crate

The crate went up on the back of a house because a man couldn't afford a horizon and refused to let that be the whole sentence. He couldn't hand his son the ocean. So he handed him an aim, and the boy shot at it until the streetlights called him in, and the aim outlived the man, which is what aims are

for. Every rule in this book is that crate wearing different clothes: a way to point yourself when nobody hands you the regulation thing. But an aim was never the destination. Sooner or later the shot has to come down somewhere, and mine comes down at the far edge of the country, where the water starts, where four empty cans stand for a promise being kept. There's one stretch of this story left, and it ends at the water. Bring your promise with you when you come. The crate taught us how to shoot. The ocean is where the shot lands.

Conclusion: Run It All

We started this book at a kitchen table, and we're going to end it at one. No montage, no gift shop on the way out. Just you, me, and the whole code laid out where you can reach it, the way I wish somebody had laid it out for me at 17, or 25, or 34, or any of the other ages where I paid retail for it.

My daddy carried numbers in his head the way other men carry loose change. He could look at a pile of bills on a table and call the total before your hand got near it. I didn't inherit the calculator. Everything I know, I know because I wrote it down and ran it until it moved on its own. So that's what this last stretch is. All 12 rules, restated short. Each one gets the command, the receipt, and the single move. Because I know what the middle of a bad week does to a book. You will not remember chapter eight in the middle of one. You'll remember one line, if I did my job. Here are the lines. Read them slow. Some of them cost me five figures. One of them cost me a season. A couple of them cost me people. The least you can do is not skim.

Use this section like a checklist, because that's what it is. The day something in your life stalls, run down the page until

one of these stings. The sting is the diagnosis. Go reread that chapter, run its exercise again with a pen, and get back to work. In all my years of building and losing and building again, it has always been one of these.

One thing before the list, because the order is load-bearing. Rules one through three are the foundation: what you start with, what you were handed, what fuels you. Four through six are the fall: what breaks you, how fast you get up, and who was actually standing with you when it happened. Seven through nine are the build: how you make something real out of whatever's left. And 10 through 12 are the handoff: what all of it was for in the first place. You'll live them out of order, the way I did. You'll understand them in order.

Figure it out. A hoop doesn't have to be regulation to teach you how to shoot. My daddy knocked the bottom out of a milk crate because a real goal cost helicopter money, and 30-odd years later I taught myself to code in a raw black terminal because I didn't know better tools existed. Same law both times: the ugly version teaches you fundamentals the pretty version never will. The move: flip the paper over, count what you already have, and take the ugliest workable first rep before you sleep tonight. Not this weekend. Tonight. Equipment was never your problem. It was never mine either.

Know what you inherited. The apple didn't fall from the tree. It just landed on different soil. My father handed me a code and a ceiling with the same two hands, and it took me years to learn I was allowed to keep the one and break the other. The move: two columns on one page, the code I keep and the

ceiling I break, one honest sentence under each. You can love the tree with your whole chest and still audit the fruit.

Bet on the insult. I am most dangerous when I am desperate. A coach once sent me a message through a teammate that boiled down to “you’re not enough,” and four seconds of game clock later, the number one team in the country stood around trying to understand what had just happened to them. The move: write 10 sentences that start with “they said I couldn’t,” turn each one into a number with a date on it, circle one, and rewrite it every morning until the scoreboard answers for you.

Pay the bill once. The truth would have cost me less than the lie. My daddy set out two folding chairs on a porch, told me he’d back whatever truth I told, and put the decision in my hands. I made the wrong call and paid interest on it for years. The move: name the one truth you still haven’t owned and pay it this week, to the person’s face if you can. A consequence comes due once. Interest never stops billing.

Get up faster. My daddy’s law, and he said it plain: the people who win aren’t the ones who never get knocked down, they’re the ones who get knocked down and get up faster than everyone else. He lived it the day our house burned to ash and he skipped the anger entirely and went straight to work. The move: pre-write your first three moves for the loss you fear most, and build your lifeline list of five names now, while the sky is still clear. Response speed is the only part of disaster you control. Grief gets a night. The plan gets the morning.

Count your friends twice. All your friends aren't your friends. I watched \$37,000 vanish into a smooth talker's account, and I have also had people climb out on limbs for me when no math said they should. Both of those live in the same ledger. The move: write the deposits and the withdrawals, make one structural fix this week (an agreement on paper, a boundary said out loud), and send one overdue thank-you to somebody on the savior side. Structure the trust. Keep the gratitude.

Build it before they believe you. Don't tell them you can build it. Build it. Put it in their hands. Let the work do the arguing. A company once asked me to review their platform, and instead I built them a brand new one, deployed it, and sent the login. One call later, the whole conversation had changed shape. The move: pick the room you want next, define the one artifact that proves you belong in it, ship it inside 30 days, and send it with a two-line note.

Treat every loss like tuition. It was the most expensive class I ever took. But I only had to take it once. I paid \$25,000 to learn that you verify the work, never the title, and my diploma was a backpack full of unsold tickets. The move: write down your three most expensive losses and the rule each one taught you, one sentence apiece. Then find the loss you're still paying for monthly, the lesson you keep refusing to learn, and cancel the subscription.

Always have your own ticket. Stay cordial. Carry no hate. And always have your own ticket. A man who had cost me money and months once offered me a courtside seat, and I

thanked him kindly from the seat I'd already bought. The move: find the one spot where your whole plan hangs on somebody else's yes, and build the alternate this month. Then pack something of value for the next big room you enter. My daddy's rule still stands: never walk into a room empty handed.

Keep the crate, change the game. Same crate, different game. The muscles basketball built in me turned out to be the exact muscles that built a farm out of raw dirt and then a company out of code. Games end. The shape underneath doesn't. The move: list every obsession you've ever had, circle the abilities that repeat under all of them, pick one new game that runs on the circles, and start introducing yourself by the muscle instead of the dead sport. You don't start over. You re-aim.

Be there, not just in the house. I didn't build all this to become another man who was in the house but not home. It took six months of too much office, and a wife quietly carrying what I refused to see, before I got the order right: husband first, Daddy first, code after. The move: put your people in the calendar before the work gets in, defend those blocks the way you'd defend a client meeting, and ask each person you love one question: "When do you feel like you have me?" Write the answers down. Believe them.

Leave them the ocean. Your past is not a prediction. It is a preparation. Near the end, I asked my father what he wished he'd gotten to see, and his answer is the reason my daughter is going to grow up knowing exactly what the ocean looks like. The move: write the one generational correction you

intend to make, present tense, dated, with the name of the person it's for. Put it where you'll see it daily. Then do the first concrete thing it requires before the week is out. The account opened. The call made.

That's the Milk Crate Code, all 12 rules, and not one of them needs a dollar to start.

If 12 feels like too many to carry, carry the first one. Figure it out is the seed the other 11 grew from. Every rule in this book is that first crate wearing a different jersey: inventory what you have, start ugly, pay the bill, keep moving, and aim the whole thing at somebody coming up behind you. My daddy compressed the entire code into four words and a nail. The rest of us need the long version. Now you have it.

* * *

Now for the part books like this usually skip.

The self-help shelf has a habit. The last chapter gets written from the summit. The author waves down from the finished life, the system gets full credit for everything in the frame, and the closing pages read like a museum tour where all the exhibits are done being built. I can't write you that chapter, and I want to be straight about why. It wouldn't be true.

Here's my scoreboard on the day I'm typing this. I run a young company with my wife, and our first paying client was a discount mattress store. We celebrated that check like a championship, because that's exactly what it was. I have been told no, recently, by rooms I had already built working

product for. I'm enrolled in a Computer Science degree at an age when most men are long done sitting for exams. Rejection emails still land. Plans still miss. Nobody stops me in airports, and I'm typing this from a home office in California with a three-year-old in the house, on a scoreboard that is very much still live. And there are rules in this book I have to re-run on myself with a pen in my hand, because knowing a rule and running a rule are two different jobs, and the second one doesn't end.

So call this book what it is: a report from the middle. Not a map drawn from a mountaintop by a man who finished climbing. Field notes from a man on the same wall you're on, a little higher up, shouting down what has held his weight so far.

I'd argue the report is worth more than the map. Every rule in here got tested from the middle. Broke, banned, benched, burned: that's the lab this code came out of. A code that only runs from a summit is a victory lap. This one runs at your altitude, because your altitude is where I logged every mile of it. I wrote once that losing the thing you love most is not the end of your story. It is the middle. And the middle is where everything interesting happens. I believe that line harder today than the day I wrote it, because I'm still in the middle, and it's still interesting.

Here's something else I can't give you: the ending. I don't know how my story turns out. That used to bother me about writing this book, until I understood it was the book's whole credential. A man who knows his ending is selling you

certainty, and certainty is the one product on this shelf that's always counterfeit. What I'm handing you is cheaper and it actually works: a way to keep building while the ending stays unwritten. Yours is unwritten too. That's the part of your story you're still holding the pen for.

Before I hand this off, I want the price tag visible one last time, because a recap makes everything look smooth, and none of it was smooth. This code cost me a knee. It cost me a diploma I never got to hold, years of probation, friends I had to subtract, and money I've already itemized for you down to the dollar. I'm not showing the receipts to make you flinch. I'm showing them because a code with the price tag torn off is a scam, and you'd be right not to trust it. Everything in here costs. It just costs less than staying where you are.

My daddy never once handed me a finished thing. Look at that man's gifts. A crate with the bottom knocked out. A river with no swim lesson attached. A porch decision with no advice inside it. Every gift he ever gave came with my half missing, and my half is where I got built. It took me about 30 years to understand that the missing half was the gift.

This book is built the same way, on purpose. The rules and the receipts are my half, and you're holding all of it now. The pen, the paper, the dates, the reps: that half is yours, and no page of mine can do it for you. If you've read this far and never written anything down, you don't own the code yet. You toured it. Go back with a pen. Start with whichever capsule stung when you read it a few pages ago. The sting is the assignment.

Keep this section close. Run down the list twice a year on your own schedule, and once more on any day something breaks. The day the job disappears, the day somebody you trusted shows you their other face, come back here and find the rule that fits the hole. A deal that dies because one man changed his mind is a ticket problem. A season of grinding while your family sees your back more than your face is the eleventh rule flashing. An expensive L you can feel yourself lining up to repeat is tuition trying to become a subscription. Match the break to the rule, go run that chapter's exercise again, and get back on the wall. That's what "run it all" means. Not once. On rotation, for the rest of your building life.

Now let me talk to the one reading this who thinks the clock already ran out. I was 37 years old when I typed my first real line of code, with a wife, a baby, and a business already on my plate. Late is a real cost and I won't pretend otherwise. I paid it in sleep and in pride. But late and locked out are two different conditions. One of them is a schedule problem. The other one is a story you're telling yourself, and you've read 12 rules' worth of evidence that the story is wrong.

And let me keep the promise I made at the front of this book by repeating it at the back. I promised you a way of moving. That's the whole offer. I won't promise you the money, because outcomes have too many hands in them that aren't yours. What I can promise is what the code has done every single time I ran it: it kept me moving through every ending, and it turned every ending into material for the next

build. Your past is not a prediction. It is a preparation. Run the code, and yours will be too.

The inheritance is transferred now. A hustler from Memphis ran this code his whole life inside games that were stacked against him from the jump, and he still managed to hand it to his son with a hammer and no speech. I ran it through every game they let me enter and a few they didn't. I'm handing it to you with a whole book, which means you got the long version, which means you have less excuse than I ever did. Where you run it next is none of my business and all of your inheritance. The crate is in your hands.

One stop left. Back at the kitchen table, I told you this book ends at the ocean. It does. Come on.

Crate 4: The Ocean

At the far edge of the country, where the land runs out, there is an office with a desk in it, and three feet from the desk sits a milk crate.

Nobody has knocked the bottom out of this one. Nobody has nailed it to anything. It sits flat on the floor and it is full of books, heavy ones, spines creased from use, and it carries all that weight without one word of complaint, which is what crates do.

On a shelf stand four beer cans. Budweiser. Empty, and kept. They are not trash and they are not decoration. In some houses the shelf would hold silver. In this one it holds cans.

Four times a man has driven west from this office until the land quit under him. Four times he has stood where the dirt gives way to sand and the sand gives way to saltwater, and opened a Budweiser and drunk it slow, for a father who lived a whole life and never once saw the ocean. The water came all that way to meet him and he came all that way to meet it, and between them they held a kind of visit. Each time, the man carried the empty can home. That is what the shelf keeps. Four visits. Four cans.

In the house there is a girl. She is three years old. She has two hoops, one inside and one outside, orange rims, real nets, bought from a store the way hoops are bought when the money is not a wall. Nobody had to knock the bottom out of anything for her. The crate in the office holds books now, and the girl holds the ball.

Her shot is real. Wrist flipped, follow-through held, rotation on the ball. Three years old, and the ball leaves her hands spinning the right way. The form did not come from nowhere. Nothing does.

The man rebounds. That is his work now, and of all the work his hands have ever done, hammering and hauling and planting and typing, this is the best of it. The ball comes off the rim and he runs it down and carries it back and sets it in her hands, and she shoots, and he runs it down again, for as long as she wants to keep going.

She always wants to keep going.

Light drains out of the sky. Down the street the streetlights buzz and come on, one by one, the way streetlights came on behind a house in Arkansas a long time ago, over a plastic square nailed to scrap wood, over a boy shooting by sound. The ball comes off the rim one more time. The man catches it and holds it a moment, this ball that has come further than any of them, dirt to hardwood, one pair of hands to another.

The girl puts her hands out.

He puts the ball in her hands.

"Here. Figure it out."